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ON 1ST OCTOBER 2026



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ENTRY BY
INVITATION ONLY

Flydubai nightmare: A pilot brawl, wounded captain, rapid descent

‘We felt that this was it’: Passengers recount flight fight
Reuters
Jerusalem, September 30

WHEN FLYDUBAI flight FZ1073 suddenly plunged from over 30,000 feet Wednesday, passenger Almog Italie said it felt like the plane was passing through “massive turbulence” before he realised a life-or-death struggle had unfolded in the cockpit.

Italie described passengers running to the front of the cabin and commotion in front of the cockpit, where Israeli officials said the co-pilot had

stabbed the captain to try to crash the plane flying from Dubai to Tel Aviv with more than 170 Israelis on board.

“It was dropping like for 20, 30 seconds, and then balanced, and then started dropping again, and balanced again, and then we saw that (there) are people in the front, directly (in front of) the cockpit,” he told *Reuters*. “Crew members and passengers from the front of the airplane took over and got control of the two pilots.”

“Within a few minutes, our plane completely lost control, and we felt that this was it — we were about to crash,” one passenger, Miriam Ohayon, told *Israel’s 124 News*, a television channel. “We heard screams on



Yaniv Hayun, one of the men who helped incapacitate the attacker on the flydubai aircraft bound for Israel from UAE, after arriving at the Ben Gurion International Airport near Tel Aviv on Wednesday. REUTERS

the plane, and when they opened the cockpit, there was a lot of blood.”

She recalled reciting a Jewish prayer often said in times of distress as the plane jolted

through the air. The incident began about two hours after takeoff when a passenger returning from the bathroom saw a struggle inside the cockpit and alerted passengers, Ohayon reported to her mother, Yasmin Ohayon-Abukasis.

Hila Gaier, who was on the flight, said that when the plane dove passengers couldn’t move. “You were sucked downward,” she told Kan, Israel’s public broadcaster. She said she was flying with her partner and two daughters. “I embraced them, told them I loved them, and we tried to practice breathing exercises,” she said.

Adam Polovincik, 40, who was on the flight with his family, described it as an “extreme experience,” even as he tried to remain calm for his children.

Doron Spielman, a spokesperson for the Israeli prime minister’s office, said the wounded captain, bloodied and lying on the floor, had drawn on “the last moments of his energy” to click open the release on the cockpit door.

“At that moment, some of the passengers that realised something was happening raced forward, entered the pilot’s cabin. They saw the injured pilot on the ground, and the other... the attacking pilot was standing over the control panel, bashing the control panel,” he said. A passenger subdued the attacker, he said.

—WITH NYT INPUTS

Saudi ‘rejected’ Israeli request to fly passengers

London: Saudi Arabia turned down a request by Israel to allow its planes to bring back Israeli passengers from a flydubai flight that made an emergency landing in the kingdom, two security sources said on Wednesday.

The request was made to allow Israeli military planes to bring back Israelis from Saudi Arabia, which has no diplomatic relations with Israel, the sources said. Saudi Arabia’s government media office did not immediately respond to a request for comment. REUTERS

Moscow sends nuclear warning to NATO amid rising tensions

Reuters
Brussels, September 30

RUSSIA HAS warned NATO would be ready to resort to nuclear weapons if the Western alliance attempted to cut off Kaliningrad, a Russian exclave that borders the Baltic Sea.

In a document sent to NATO and seen by *Reuters*, Moscow accused the alliance of a “dangerous and reckless course” that entailed “high risks of the outbreak of a direct armed conflict”.

The document said this included possibility of “Russian strikes against decision-making centers in the alliance’s member states right from the outset”.

“Russia will be ready to use the entire arsenal of forces and capabilities at its disposal, including nuclear weapons, in order to defend its territory should NATO countries undertake any attempt aimed at isolating the Kaliningrad Region from the rest of the country,” the diplomatic note said.

The warning highlighted Moscow’s urgent concern at what it sees as a growing NATO threat to Kaliningrad, a heavily militarised Russian territory.

TRUMP SAYS WITHDRAWAL A VICTORY FOR U.S. AND IRAQ

Iran: Received reply to latest proposal; US pulls out of Iraq

Tehran views the US pullout as a victory for ‘axis of resistance’
Reuters
Baghdad, Dubai, September 30

IRAN SAID on Wednesday it had received a US response to its latest proposal to revive the collapsed ceasefire in the Gulf, days after President Donald Trump said he had rejected it.



Iraqi security forces drive through Najaf as they celebrate the withdrawal of US forces from Iraq, on Wednesday. REUTERS

Iran’s allies celebrated after Washington withdrew its forces from neighbouring Iraq.

Tehran views the pullout as a victory for its “axis of resistance” of allied groups and a step towards its aim of driving US forces out of the region. Trump hailed “a very expensive excursion into Hell.”

He described the withdrawal by a September 30 deadline as “orderly” and said in a social media post: “It has been a long time, with very bad decision-making that got us involved in this quagmire in the first place, but soon, that will be part of History.” He said the shift was a victory for the US, Iraq and a sign of victory over Islamic State.

Araghchi said Tehran had not received a formal rejection. An Iranian government spokesperson said Wednesday that Araghchi had conveyed a US response to the government.

Last week, Qatari mediators shuttled between US and Iranian envoys in New York on the sidelines of a UN meeting, the first proximity talks between the warring sides since the ceasefire unravelled. An official briefed on the talks, who is not Iranian and spoke to Reuters on condition of anonymity, said the Qataris briefed Araghchi on the US response on Tuesday in Doha. The sides largely agree on the steps needed but still disagree over the order, the official said.

The withdrawal of the last US troops from bases in Iraq was celebrated by Tehran and its allies Wednesday. —WITH AP INPUTS

Strong indications of Iran role in air base incident: UK

London: The UK has “strong indications” that Iran played a part in the incident that saw five men arrested near a US-run military air base in England late at night, Prime Minister Andy Burnham said Wednesday.

“There are strong indications that Iran played a part in what happened over the weekend at RAF Fairford, but of course it remains an ongoing, complex, and serious police investigation,” Burnham told the BBC. “And of course, we are working closely with our colleagues in the United States of America.” AP

Trump says top tech firms have signed accord to ‘self-police’ AI development

Associated Press
Washington, September 30

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Tuesday said that he and a large group of leaders of artificial intelligence companies had signed a voluntary accord that will include internal and external reviews during a meeting at the White House aimed at addressing Americans’ fears about the technology.

“I think I’m seeing tremendous self-policing. And they understand that they have to self-police,” Trump told reporters during an impromptu press conference outside the West Wing.

Trump and House Speaker Mike Johnson met with leading executives from top tech firms that are spending hundreds of billions of dollars to build out AI infrastructure, including data centers in communities across the country, which have sparked grassroots, bipartisan opposition.

The accord was signed by Trump, Anthropic CEO Dario



US President Donald Trump during a meeting with top executives of AI firms in the East Room of the White House in Washington on Tuesday. AP

Amodei, Google CEO Sundar Pichai, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg, OpenAI President Greg Brockman, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang, and Elon Musk, founder of xAI, which is now part of SpaceX.

• AI ACCORD

WHAT IT CALLS FOR

External audits: Independent assessments of AI controls and monitoring systems.

Board oversight: An independent board committee to oversee internal and external audits.

Internal safeguards: Controls

to monitor AI capabilities and alignment during training and deployment, including cybersecurity, biosecurity and chemical threats.

Internal team: A dedicated team to ensure controls, monitoring and detection work as intended.



PM Burnham says UK should weigh ties with EU, including rejoining

Reuters
London, September 30

PRIME MINISTER Andy Burnham said on Wednesday Britain should consider options for its future relationship with the European Union, including rejoining the bloc, doubling down on his message that Brexit had “done more harm than good”.

The comments received a mixed reception from French President Emmanuel Macron. Tuesday, Burnham again said Britain should consider options for a future relationship, including not only full membership but also rejoining the EU’s single market and/or a customs union — reigniting a divisive debate that has split the country for the last 10 years.

“We could stay as we are. That’s definitely an option, if people think this is the right place to stay,” Burnham said, listing other possibilities including one to “go all the way”.

In interviews, he suggested any decision on a future referendum was a long way off, saying his speech was based on crafting a 10-year plan for the nation.



UK PM Andy Burnham (left), French President Macron

dealing with high levels of immigration.

Speaking to the BBC late on Tuesday, Burnham again said Britain should consider options for a future relationship, including not only full membership but also rejoining the EU’s single market and/or a customs union — reigniting a divisive debate that has split the country for the last 10 years.

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Injuries & arrests as French high school student protests spread

Saint-Denis: Dozens of people have been injured and hundreds arrested, most of them teenagers, officials said, in a wave of French student protests against teacher shortages and dilapidated buildings that spread to more schools across the country.

The demonstrations and blockades, which began last week and coincided Tuesday with a broader public-sector strike, have become a political flashpoint at a sensitive moment for France, as they spread to 356 high schools and turned more violent. On Thursday, the government will unveil the country’s 2027 budget, which is expected to involve spending cuts aimed at easing pressure on government finances.

In Saint-Denis students stood outside the gates of their school near a fire that had been set as police looked on. “There are cockroaches and rats everywhere in the school,” Fadila, a 17-year-old student, told Reuters. She said temperatures in classrooms could swing from sweltering to below freezing, depending on weather. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Blind man sues British Museum over lack of audio tours for Bayeux Tapestry



The British Museum

1066. But, Osman’s lawyers say, the British Museum said it would not be providing such audio tours as restrictions on the tapestry’s light exposure limit number of visitors. REUTERS

THE BRITISH Museum is facing legal action over its Bayeux Tapestry exhibition, with lawyers representing a blind man alleging museum is breaching equalities laws by not providing audio described tours. Dr Yusuf Ali Osman asked the museum whether live audio described tours would be provided for the exhibition of the nearly 1,000-year-old embroidery, which depicts the conquest of England by William I in 1066. But, Osman’s lawyers say, the British Museum said it would not be providing such audio tours as restrictions on the tapestry’s light exposure limit number of visitors. REUTERS

CHINA

New air base in Laos operational

CHINA HAS expanded its overseas military footprint in Laos, satellite imagery showed, with a new joint support and training center and aviation academy built on farmland at Ban Keun, about 50 km north of Vientiane, Laos’ capital. On Tuesday, Beijing’s Defence Ministry said the facilities were operational. REUTERS

MOROCCO

King names first woman PM

MOROCCO’S KING Tuesday selected a female PM to head the government for the first time in country’s history. King Mohammed VI named Fatima Ezzahra El Mansouri, a lawyer and politician from the centrist Authenticity and Modernity Party, to form a new government, according to a statement from Ministry of the Royal Household. NYT

• SYLVESTER STALLONE WAS RELIVING HIS EARLY YEARS AS A STRUGGLING ACTOR-WRITER WHO SOMEHOW CONVINCED UNITED ARTISTS TO BACK HIS MODEST STORY OF A JOURNEYMAN BOXER

‘You know, insecurity is a great motivator’: Stallone at 80 reflects on Rocky... 50 yrs later

Associated Press
New York, September 30

FIFTY YEARS after Sylvester Stallone pulled off one of Hollywood’s all-time long shots with *Rocky*, the Oscar-winning star still identifies with the character who for many embodies the outsider proving all the naysayers wrong.

But he no longer claims to be an underdog. “It would be so disingenuous to say you’re an underdog, as he said from his penthouse,” Stallone said during a recent interview, on a high floor of a luxury Manhattan hotel. “Yeah. Come on. I am a lucky dog.” Stallone, who turned 80 in July, is among the

most successful movie stars and filmmakers in history. He has generated billions of dollars through such blockbuster franchises as *Rocky*, *Rambo* and *The Expendables* and portrayed some of the most memorable film characters.

By choice and otherwise, Stallone has been reliving his early years as a struggling actor-writer who somehow convinced United Artists to back his modest story of a journeyman boxer’s shot at the heavyweight championship, and even allow him to play the lead despite having little acting experience.

His memoir *Steps*, published Tuesday, arrives less than two months before a fic-

tionalised and semi-authorised version of his story, Peter Farrelly’s *I Play Rocky*, arrives in theatres, with Anthony Ippolito in the starring role. *Rocky*, which beat out *Taxi Driver* and *All the President Men*’s among others to win the Best Picture Oscar, is one of those classic movies that only seem to benefit from the back story; Stallone’s own journey from the streets of Philadelphia to the Oscars stage echoes so well his character’s improbable rise.

He also condemns war, including the Iran War, as a story of sending people into a “meat grinder while the military complex is making zillions of dollars.” “I do believe that you have



A still from the movie Rocky released in 1976

to defend yourself. But to go on the offensive?” he says, adding that he would prefer not to be known as a “political figure.”

AP: Why write this book?

Stallone: The one thing I didn’t want to write about is my life. It’s this ambivalent roller coaster

ride. It’s not always the most pleasurable ride. And I thought, What am I known for? Pulling off this minor miracle in 1976, which falls under the heading of inspiration. That’s what I want to do. Because the character was an inspiration, I wanted to tell the people how it all came to be.

AP: How hard was it to relive some of those early memories?

Stallone: It was very hard because I spent 50 years burying that stuff. And it’s like you come across a lost city, and you start to become your own spiritual archaeologist, digging down. And it’s not pretty. But I didn’t want this to be, ‘Oh, woe

is me.’ Everyone has issues and a lot worse than me. I just wanted to touch on the essence because I still have this conundrum. If everything was really nice, maybe I wouldn’t be here, you know what I mean? If I didn’t have that insecurity which drives us. You know, insecurity is a great motivator.

AP: When was the last time you actually watched Rocky in its entirety?

Stallone: No, I didn’t. You know what I see. You’re sitting there and going through messages and somebody who’s 18 has put it on the internet or on TikTok. And how would this person relate to an 80-year-old

guy? They’re not, though. They’re not relating to me. It’s that character.

AP: Young people know about Rocky.

Stallone: In retrospect, that to me is the greatest gift. You know, you write something — I’m just trying to get some footage on myself. I’m just trying to write something really simple. I didn’t ever expect it to be in more than one or two theaters.

AP: And now you have a movie about you, I Play Rocky, coming out.

Stallone: How strange is this? A movie about me being in a movie.

Congress likely to remove Warring as its Punjab unit chief

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, September 30

THE CONGRESS high command has decided to change Ludhiana MP Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as its Punjab Congress president and appoint a new person, it is learnt.

Sources said that the Congress leadership in Delhi has also conveyed its decision to Warring. While sources in the Congress confirmed that the party will be getting a new chief in Punjab just a few months ahead of the Assembly elections, there is widespread speculation on the new appointee. The appointment of a new PCC chief will draw curtains on a four-month-old tussle between the Warring camp and those demanding his removal.

This latest development follows Punjab affairs in-charge Sachin Pilot's organisational feedback after he replaced Bhupesh Baghel earlier this month. Sources said more than 50 interactions with leaders and district functionaries fed into a report discussed with Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and KC Venugopal. Warring may be called to Delhi, and an announcement could come anytime soon.

This is the second major leadership debate of the year for the Congress in Punjab. In June and July, party observers Ajay Maken, Meenakshi Natarajan



Ludhiana MP Amrinder Singh Raja Warring

and Bhajan Lal Jatav assessed the unit. While the majority favoured former CM Charanjit Singh Channi, the high command instead retained Warring, made Channi campaign committee chair, and distributed other roles to Vijay Inder Singh, Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa and Amar Singh in a bid to balance factions and communities.

The names of the possible successor of Warring include Vijay Inder Singh, former minister and AICC secretary from the Malwa belt, frequently cited as a Hindu face who could head the organisation without being treated as the automatic chief ministerial candidate. The name of Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Gurdaspur MP and a Jat Sikh has also been circulating along with Amritsar MP Gurjit Singh Aujla, Jalandhar MLA Pargat Singh, and Rajia Sansi MLA Sukhbinder Singh Sarkaria.

Koder House, landmark of Jewish community in Keralam, gutted

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 30

KODER HOUSE at Fort Kochi, one of the last remaining landmarks of the erstwhile Jewish community in Keralam, was gutted in a major fire on Tuesday night. The Portuguese mansion, dating back to the 1800s, had been functioning as a heritage hotel.

Fire and rescue officials said the cause of the blaze is yet to be ascertained. "The fire began on the top floor of the three-storey building, and it soon engulfed the rest. There were no casualties as guests and staff had been evacuated," said an official.

Koder House was one of the important surviving landmarks of Fort Kochi's rich, cosmopolitan heritage. Built as a Portu-

guese mansion, the red-brick structure was given a facelift by Samuel S Koder, a prominent member of Cochin's Jewish community, who bought the building and renovated it in 1905. Koder, who died in 1994, ran the Cochin Electric Company, which was eventually sold to the government. He also began the first ferry service from Fort Kochi to Ernakulam. The Koders emigrated to Cochin from Iraq a few centuries ago.

Koder also served as an Honorary Consul of the Netherlands and was associated with establishing the Cochin wing of the Freemasons. His reconstruction of the Portuguese mansion transformed it into a distinctive example of Indo-European architecture, blending European colonial influences with local features.

•WRITEBACK

RESPONDING TO the report, "Elephant smuggled from Nepal, trail points to NGO in leopard poaching probe", published on September 28, 2026, Wildlife SOS writes:

"We wish to clarify that Wildlife SOS or its employees are neither undertaking nor have ever undertaken the repatriation of a female elephant from Nepal. Wildlife SOS was in talks with a Nepal-based NGO in November 2023 regarding the proposed repatriation of a male bull elephant named 'Rama'. Wildlife SOS subsequently engaged with the governments of India and Nepal regarding the proposed lawful repatriation. That process remains incomplete and no repatriation of Rama has taken place. Any suggestion that Wildlife SOS independently moved, trafficked or smuggled an elephant from Nepal is therefore factually incorrect and has no basis in the actual role played by the organisation...

"Trafficking involves the illegal movement or dealing in wildlife, whereas repatriation is the lawful return of rescued, recovered or confiscated wildlife pursuant to the requisite governmental approvals...

"We are also constrained to clarify the reference in the report to Suraj Pal. The report refers to him as being associated with Wildlife SOS while discussing an alleged transaction stated to have taken place in 2020. The factual position is that Suraj Pal ceased working with Wildlife SOS in 2016...

"...Wildlife SOS categorically denies any involvement in the illegal collection or trafficking of bear cubs and has worked for over three decades, in close partnership with the Government of India and State Forest Departments, to eradicate the practice of dancing bears in India. Wild-

life SOS remains committed to transparency, due process and wildlife protection and will continue to cooperate fully with the relevant authorities."

THE INDIAN EXPRESS RESPONDS:

The news report is based on chat records that are part of a Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) case file on the arrest on March 13, 2022, of three men with approximately 30 kg of ivory and a licensed revolver in Jaipur. The chat records and interrogation reports do not refer to a repatriated male elephant but the alleged purchase of a female elephant smuggled from Nepal in connection with the case.

The report published the response of Wildlife SOS CEO Karthick Satyanarayan to the contents of the chat records and quoted him as saying: "I have no knowledge of the purported chat records. Therefore, I am unable to verify, assess, or comment on the matter." It also sought Satyanarayan's response to the reference in the chat records to Suraj Pal. It quoted him as saying: "This appears to be a concocted narrative being circulated by individuals with mischievous and personal vendetta, having vested interests."

The report also quoted Wildlife SOS as saying in a separate email: "Suraj Pal was associated with us for a short period up to 2016 when his employment was terminated."

Regarding the reference to the bear cubs, the report accurately recorded statements of investigators that they tracked leads and circumstantial evidence into the trafficking of bear cubs but found "no smoking gun" and that "leads were pursued in Odisha, Jharkhand and pockets along the Nepal border before the trails dried up".

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Modi and Trump

is currently in the US for the G20 trade ministers' meeting. On the sidelines, he will meet US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer.)

Earlier this month, Chinese President Xi Jinping was in the US, from September 23 to 25, and had bilateral talks with Trump.

The conversation between Modi and Trump took place a day after External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, while underlining the complex nature of the India-US trade deal negotiations, said the two sides have reached a situation where there is "more or less an understanding on the trade agreement".

Flagging terrorism emanating from Pakistan as a key concern for India, he said if this is "not fully appreciated" by the US, then it has "an impact" on Delhi's relationship with Washington. Jaishankar was speaking at the Asia Society Policy Insti-

tute in New York, after spending an entire week at the UN General Assembly session.

On the India-US trade negotiations, Jaishankar pointed to the "stakes" and "complexity" involved. "Bear in mind, India is a society of small producers, small agriculture producers, small factories. Apart from the per capita gap between India and the US, the nature of production, nature of society is very different," he said.

"A trade negotiation required a certain amount of... patience and detailing to see it through... the expectation that it could rapidly move forward, I think, was tested against a ground reality which was much more complex," he said.

"Today, we have reached a situation where there is more or less an understanding on the trade agreement."

Gandhi Ashram

"The committee's role is to approve the content, design, and other aspects of the museum after assessing. Only after the CAC approves can a design be finalised," a source told The Indian Express.

"For instance", the source said, "one of our members visited Satyagraha House in Johannesburg, and gave a 60-page input on Gandhi's writings preserved there." Satyagraha House, which was designed by the German architect Hermann Kallenbach, hosted Gandhi in 1908-09.

Sources said the committee is currently reviewing a first draft of a plan submitted by Ecofirst for "authenticity". Once cleared by the committee, the content will go to the National Institute of Design (NID), which has been engaged for "proof-checking, review, and approval of the museum design submitted by Museum Studio", an official said.

NID, this official said, will decide the "best format to tell the story" to the "new generation, which is not inclined towards reading". All communication and content formats will be finally vetted by PMMLS and IIFH, sources said.

It is learned that the trust has capped the digital segment in the museums at 30% of the content presentation. Air conditioning will be provided in spaces

where electronic displays and similar items are present.

The trust had floated tenders for the restoration of 28 buildings that were part of the original Gandhi Ashram complex, including a hostel, a gaushala, a school, a spinning and weaving centre, a paper-making centre, and a creche. Ecofirst has been awarded a Rs 113 crore contract to design and develop museums and exhibitions in 23 buildings. The museum inside the Ashram Gaushala is being restored by the National Dairy Development Board.

The Sabarmati Ashram redevelopment project is being jointly implemented by the central government and Gujarat government. Urban planner Bimal Patel's firm HCP Design, Planning and Management Pvt Ltd prepared the masterplan and carried out the civil works.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel heads the Governing Council of the Mahatma Gandhi Sabarmati Ashram Memorial Trust. Retired IAS officer IP Gautam heads the trust's Executive Council.

"If we quantify Gandhiji's contributions to the country and the world, more than 60% is from this ashram - from the Champaran satyagraha... to the time when the British exited India", a source connected with the project said.

Mid-air scare

unknown and warned against "premature speculation". The cause of the altercation between the pilots was not clear.

The co-pilot, who an Israeli official identified as an Omani national, was arrested after the plane landed, Netanyahu said. Israel's Transport Ministry said there would be a joint investigation of the incident with the defence establishment.

(An AP report said Israel scrambled warplanes amid concerns about a possible hijacking.)

"All passengers are out of harm's way," Netanyahu said in a video statement released by his office. He also ordered tighter security on both Israeli and non-Israeli carriers flying into Israel.

Netanyahu quoted a passenger as saying that passengers, along with a member of the crew, broke into the cockpit after the aircraft "entered a tail-spin and began to dive" and found the co-pilot "trying to sabotage the plane's systems". "They saved many lives. They prevented a heavy disaster," he said.

The passengers departed Saudi Arabia for Israel aboard a flydubai replacement aircraft after eight hours on the ground.

The UAE is yet to comment on the incident, while the Dubai-owned airline said the aircraft was secured by on-duty crew who diverted it to Tabuk and landed it safely.

Rapid descent, then chaos

When the flight suddenly plunged from over 30,000 feet,

passenger Almog Italie said it felt like the plane was passing through "massive turbulence" before he realised a life-or-death struggle had unfolded in the cockpit.

Italie described passengers running to the front of the cabin and commotion in front of the cockpit, where Israeli officials said the co-pilot had stabbed the captain to try to crash the plane.

"It was dropping like for 20, 30 seconds, and then balanced, and then started dropping again, and balanced again, and then we saw that (there) are people in the front, directly (in front of) the cockpit," he told Reuters. "Crew members and passengers from the front of the airplane took over and got control of the two pilots."

Doron Spielman, a spokesperson for the Israeli Prime Minister's Office, said the wounded captain, bloodied and lying on the floor, had drawn on "the last moments of his energy" to click open the release on the cockpit door.

"At that moment, some of the passengers who realised something was happening raced forward, entered the pilot's cabin. They saw the injured pilot on the ground, and the other... the attacking pilot was standing over the control panel, bashing the control panel," he said, adding that the attacker was then subdued.

A video filmed on board and verified by Reuters captured the aftermath.

In it, two wounded men are seen lying on the floor, both bloodied. A voice speaking in

Hebrew off camera says one of them is the pilot "they tried to murder". A voice off camera identifies the other as the attacker, lying on his side with three stripes on his epaulette, indicating that he is a co-pilot.

"We were attacked now, on this airplane, they tried to murder the pilot, and we took control of the team/ staff," a man in a black shirt with blood on his face says.

Another man says: "We're standing here, no one is going to pass through the pilot's door."

Yasmin Abukasis said her daughter Miriam, who was among the passengers on the flight, had told her that she had heard screaming and that a man holding a knife had forced one of the pilots onto the floor, and that there was blood everywhere.

Reserve crew

A reserve flydubai crew that had been on board took control of the plane and landed it safely at Tabuk Airport (TUU), a flydubai spokesperson said.

A playback of the flight posted on flight-tracking website flightradar24 showed the plane cruising at 34,000 feet heading westwards over Saudi Arabia when it dropped more than 14,000 feet in 30 seconds, before veering northwest. It briefly crossed into Jordan, then returned to Saudi airspace and flew to Tabuk.

Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz said the attempted attack "was thwarted solely thanks to the heroism of several Israeli passengers who stormed the cockpit, subdued the terrorist, and -- with their own hands -- restored control of the aircraft to an additional flight crew

present on board".

"According to our preliminary information, the terrorist had a single objective: to crash the plane," he said in a statement.

Italie said the reserve crew "took over the airplane and balanced it".

Saudi Arabia's Tabuk airport, where the plane landed, said both pilots had been hospitalised after sustaining injuries. The airport reported that the flight made a distress call at 8:44 am local time, before landing safely at 9:45 am.

Flydubai operates daily return flights between Dubai and Tel Aviv, a route that is popular among Israeli nationals. The flight path normally uses airspace over Saudi Arabia and Jordan.

The incident heightened security fears in Israel weeks before Israelis vote in the first election since the Hamas-led October 7, 2023 attacks, with Israel's security figuring prominently in the campaigning.

Responding to the incident on X, far-right security minister Itamar Ben-Gvir wrote, "Terrorism is a devil with whom no agreement must be reached".

"Every pilot that is going to be flying into Israel, we are going to know the pilots' identities, know who they are, and do some type of security check," Doron Spielman, a Netanyahu spokesperson, told Reuters.

Netanyahu on Sunday met UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan during a rare visit to the Gulf country. Israel and the UAE have forged close security, military and economic ties since establishing diplomatic ties in 2020. REUTERS

'Hero' pilot is Indian

Spielman, a spokesperson for the Israeli Prime Minister's Office, as saying that the wounded captain, bloodied and lying on the floor, had drawn on "the last moments of his energy" to click open the release on the cockpit door.

"At that moment, some of the passengers who realised something was happening raced forward, entered the pilot's cabin. They saw the injured pilot on the ground, and the other... the attacking pilot was standing over the control panel," he said, adding that the attacker was then subdued.

Machchhar, who is being hailed as a hero, was taken to a hospital in Saudi Arabia after the Boeing 737 jet landed safely in Tabuk. His health condition could not be immediately ascertained.

According to his LinkedIn profile, Machchhar joined flydubai in June 2022 as a captain, after serving with SpiceJet for 11 years. He started his flying career with SpiceJet in June 2011, and was a senior commander and line training captain with the Indian airline in Mumbai before moving to flydubai, an Emirati government-owned

airline.

He is currently based out of Dubai. His LinkedIn profile lists his flying experience at 9,750 hours.

"Airline Captain with over 13 years of commercial flying experience on the Boeing 737 fleet, including extensive time as a Line Training Captain. Skilled in mentoring and assessing pilots, with a strong focus on safety, compliance, and operational excellence. Currently a Direct Entry Captain at flydubai, seeking to contribute further to the training team," his profile reads.

While details about the altercation and the sequence of events remained sketchy, some Israeli news outlets reported

that the pilot fought back the co-pilot to prevent the aircraft from crashing, with the crew and some passengers then helping in subduing the co-pilot.

"The aircraft was successfully secured by on-duty flydubai crew travelling on the flight, who diverted and landed the aircraft safely at Tabuk Airport. All passengers and crew are safe and accounted for," the airline said.

"At this early stage, the underlying reasons and motives behind this event are unknown and remain subject to a formal investigation. We urge all parties to refrain from premature speculation while authorities gather the facts," it said.

IIT-B

What do rules say?

IIT Bombay's procedures for handling acts of academic malpractice by students, dated April 2015, state that when an invigilator discovers an act of indiscipline by a student during an exam, "the invigilator should confiscate relevant material like chits, phones, answer papers, etc.

"A fresh answer book should be issued to the student, and the student should be allowed to resume writing the exam," states the procedure.

A detailed note then has to be prepared and submitted to the Head of the Department (HOD) conducting the course, it says.

The HOD will then refer the case to either the Departmental Academic Disciplinary Action Committee (D-ADAC). "The main role of the D-ADAC is in sifting through the evidence and establishing the type of malpractice, if any. The final recommendation should be unambiguous," states the procedure. Members who disagree with the report may add a dissenting note.

"In case the evidence is not clear, the benefit of the doubt goes to the student. The recommendation is forwarded via the

Head to the Dean (Academic Programme) for approval and implementation."

The students who have since protested on the campus have complained that the procedure was not followed in Sahil Wakode's case.

Since the central administration does not strictly monitor the implementation of the rules, the process can allegedly vary in how such cases are being handled across departments. This has led to growing demands for a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) in cases of academic malpractice, particularly in examinations.

Since the exams were postponed after Sahil Wakode's suicide, the remaining mid-semester examination papers are now going to be held after the SOPs are ready.

Protesting students have also raised questions about why Sahil Wakode was not given another answer sheet as per procedures and instead was taken out of the classroom.

The Indian Express did not get a response from IIT Bombay, when it reached out to the institute on Wakode's apology letter.

An officer from the Special Investigation Team (SIT), formed by the Mumbai Police to probe Sahil Wakode's suicide, said that they have written to the institute asking them to hand over all documents linked to the case.

Opp protest

Bhattacharya; and CPI's P Sandosh Kumar.

Addressing a joint press conference later, Kharge said the parties agreed to work together and involve young people and civil society organisations in their campaign. "Save Democracy marches would be held from October 2 to 8, followed by demonstrations outside district magistrates' offices, across the country. On October 6, Opposition MPs from both Houses of Parliament would march to the EC's office in New Delhi," he said. The Congress chief also said the Leaders of the Opposition (LoPs) of both Houses would seek an appointment with the President in the second week of October to submit a representation against what he alleged was a "vote chori government".

The Opposition parties, Kharge said, would also hold five large rallies, with their dates and venues to be decided later, to explain to voters alleged attempts to undermine their rights to elect their government.

Oppn to move SC

At the meeting, it was also decided that the INDIA parties will jointly approach the Supreme Court to challenge the 2023 law which provides immunity to the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and other Election Commissioners (ECs) for decisions taken while in office.

A PIL moved by an NGO challenging Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Of-

fice) Act, 2023 is already being heard by the Supreme Court, but the Opposition parties still decided to move the top court.

Section 16 of this Act states: "Notwithstanding anything contained in any other law for the time being in force, no Court shall entertain or continue any civil or criminal proceedings against any person who is or was a Chief Election Commissioner or an Election Commissioner for any act, thing or word, committed, done or spoken by him when, or in the course of acting or purporting to act in the discharge of his official duty or function."

'Bring back ballot papers'

Kharge said all parties present at the meeting agreed that elections should be conducted using ballot papers rather than Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs). He also called for a repeal of laws enacted by the

BJP-led NDA government which, he alleged, undermined electoral safeguards.

Kharge accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah of treating the EC as "puppets". He also appealed to the Supreme Court to expedite cases relating to the SIR, alleging electoral malpractices.

"Now everyone is realising that what Rahul ji was saying is correct," Kharge said, referring to Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi's allegations of irregularities in the electoral process. He compared the Opposition's allegations of "vote theft" with demonetisation, saying: "First Prime Minister Modi did not bandi, now he is doing vote bandi."

Rahul said the INDIA alliance parties were of the view that India's democratic system has been allegedly attacked by Modi, Shah and CEC Gyanesh Kumar. "We will ensure that those who have destroyed In-

dian democracy are punished," he said.

"There was also a feeling in the room that the Opposition has been quite successful in putting across to people that elections are stolen. And there is a new sense among young people that what is happening is wrong," Rahul added.

Mamata Banerjee said the INDIA bloc was "very much united" and demanded the immediate removal of the CEC. She alleged electoral irregularities in Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, Bihar and West Bengal, as well as during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

Banerjee said the Opposition had raised its concerns before the EC, Supreme Court and had "knocked on every possible door". She alleged that Gyanesh Kumar was responsible for "vote theft", and said his removal was now a demand rather than a request.

Banerjee also alleged that software had been used to ma-

nipulate the electoral process and claimed that around 92 lakh voters in Bengal and more than 13 crore voters nationally had been affected.

SIR row

The Indian Express on September 23 reported that ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record, at least 14 times in 10 months, to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes.

Following a full Commission meeting on September 26, the EC issued a four-page note setting out nine decisions that addressed several of the concerns recorded by Sandhu and Joshi.

Other INDIA allies which participated in the meeting included the Samajwadi Party, Shiv Sena (UBT), JMM, IUML, Kerala Congress (M), MDMK, VCK, RSP, Kerala Congress (Joseph) and AIFB.

One held, 3 detained over Sena UBT leader murder; kin say political rivalry

Raut wants former Thane mayor to be named suspect

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

ONE PERSON was arrested and three others were detained in connection with the murder of Shiv Sena UBT local Thane leader Pradeep Purnekar. Purnekar, a Vibhag Pramukh, was stabbed and shot dead at his office on Tuesday night before the accused fled. Family members of Purnekar have alleged he was murdered due to political reasons and blamed a couple from a rival political party for the murder. An officer with the Thane police said they have arrested the accused Pappya Shinde and are on the lookout for others. Three identified accused, including Shinde and three un-



identified accused have been named in the murder case filed at Kapurbawdi police station. DCP (zone V) Prashant Kadam said that Shinde was produced before the court and remanded to police custody till October 5. "So far Shinde has not revealed much during interrogation. He was not the shooter

but was present there. The other accused will provide clarity on the motive," Kadam said. Later in the day, Shiv Sena (UBT) leaders Aaditya Thackeray and Sanjay Raut demanded that police register a supplementary FIR against those who planned the murder. The demand was made at

Kapurbawdi police station, where Purnekar's family had staged a protest for over five hours and refused to accept his body until action was taken. Raut sought that former Thane mayor Meenakshi Shinde be named as a suspect, citing the family's allegations. He and Thackeray warned that Sena



(Left) A crowd gathers around the body of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Pradeep Purnekar (above) in Thane on Wednesday. DEEPAK JOSHI

(UBT) workers from across Maharashtra would gather in Thane if action was not taken. Meenakshi Shinde denied the allegations and said Sena UBT leaders were politicising the issue. As per the FIR, Purnekar has an office at Ganesh Nagar Church in Mandpada, Thane. The complaint filed by his relative Pradeep said that a day prior to the killing, Pappya, who had fought against Purnekar in

the municipal elections, visited him at his Thane office. He said that they spoke for an hour. On Tuesday night, when the murder took place, the complainant alleged that Shinde came to meet Purnekar in his office again. Shinde and Purnekar asked others, including the complainant, to leave the office. Pradeep said Nikhil Yadav alias Shooter and Santosh Kanodia alias Talli, two wanted accused in the case, too were present there with Shinde. The complainant said two or three others with their faces covered with helmets also went near the office. Suddenly Pradeep and others heard four to five bullet shots. The relative, in the complaint, claimed that he saw Shinde and others flee from the spot and Purnekar lying in a pool of blood. Purnekar was rushed to the hospital where the doctor said he was stabbed as well. He was declared dead following which a FIR was filed.

Attendance lapse: Doctors appear before authorities

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

DOCTORS WHO were issued show-cause notices by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) last week over their attendance appeared before civic authorities on Wednesday evening to submit their responses and defend their case, as the civic body stepped up scrutiny of doctors' availability during official working hours. The meeting was attended

by doctors, heads of departments (HoDs) and deans of BMC-run medical colleges and hospitals. At least 100 doctors were issued notices last week after an internal inquiry committee flagged instances where doctors were either absent or marked their attendance but were not available when required for patient care and procedures. The action follows complaints that some doctors leave hospital premises during duty hours, including for private practice.

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Antilia terror scare: Waze to remain in jail as HC stays bail till October 7

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, September 30

THE BOMBAY High Court on Wednesday stayed till October 7 the special court's order granting bail to dismissed police officer Sachin Waze, arrested in the Antilia bomb scare and Mansukh Hiran murder cases of 2021. This means Sachin Waze will remain in Thane Central Prison until the next hearing on the NIA's appeal against the special court's September 29 bail order.

A bench of Justices Girish S Kulkarni and Neela K Gokhale was hearing an appeal by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) against the bail order.

The NIA claimed the special court's ruling was "erroneous" and "illegal" and sought its quashing and a stay on its operation pending the appeal's disposal. Sachin Waze has been in custody since 2021 and was booked for offences, including murder, criminal conspiracy, and other offences under the Indian Penal Code (IPC) along with provisions of the UAPA and the Arms Act.

The special court on Tuesday held that Waze's act "prima facie falls short to satisfy the definition of a terrorist act under Section 15 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA)". Special Judge Chakor S Baviskar observed Mansukh Hiran's murder "at this moment does not appear to be a direct outcome of any terrorist act", making the stringent UAPA bail bar inapplicable.

The court noted the NIA failed to record statements proving the Ambani family was terrorised by the explosive-laden SUV parked outside their residence, Antilia, on February 25, 2021. Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Anil Singh and advocate Chintan Shah for the NIA argued before the High Court that the special court had erred on several counts, stating that Waze's act was a terrorist act. Justice Kulkarni-led bench



Sachin Waze

noted that while Waze's lawyers had appeared before the earlier bench, despite notice being issued to them by NIA, he was not represented before it. Therefore, the bench adjourned the hearing, issued notice to Waze and noted, "We are inclined to grant an ad-interim stay to the said order till the adjourned date of hearing (October 7)."

On Wednesday morning, the NIA struggled to find a Bombay High Court bench to urgently hear its challenge to the bail order. Another bench of the High Court recused itself from hearing an appeal by the NIA the same morning.

"Since in some distinct proceedings filed by the same petitioner (Waze), one of us (Justice Bharati H Dangre) had already recused. As far as Justice Ashish S Chavan, who is also a member of the bench, he has also expressed difficulty as he had appeared for the CBI in a distinctly connected matter," the bench noted, adding that the matter be placed before another bench. ASG Anil Singh then mentioned the appeal before Chief Justice (CJ) Mahesh Chandra Tripathi-led bench, stating that three other division benches may not be able to take up the matter and Waze's release in the meantime would hamper the proceedings.

The matter was later assigned to a bench led by Justice Girish S Kulkarni. On Wednesday, the matter was then listed for hearing before an alternate bench led by Justice Dangre.

BRIEFLY

NDPS accused gets bail for infant's care

OBSERVING THAT her 8-month-old infant daughter was in a "precarious condition" and required medical attention, the Bombay High Court this week granted an eight-month interim bail to a woman booked under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, as the mother was required to provide "acute care to the infant". The woman had been booked last year for being caught with 6 kg of cocaine. The bench noted the applicant had no antecedents and was granted interim bail for three months after her arrest to deliver the child.

Residents stage rasta roko after road accident

RESIDENTS OF Mahim Koliwada held a 15-minute rasta roko at Lady Jamshedji road during peak traffic Wednesday evening. Residents complained the 20-second signal along the road is ignored by bikers and vehicles, causing serious and fatal accidents to the pedestrians crossing the road. The area's corporator, Milind Vaidya from the Shiv Sena (UBT) was also present. On Tuesday, a resident of Koliwada was hit by a tanker running a stop sign, killing her. Vaidya said he would write a formal letter to police authorities, giving an ultimatum of 30 days.

EXPRESS Careers

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CRPD/SCO/2026-27/24 (Contractual Position)				
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	Deputy Vice President (Digital Marketing)	2	33	45
	Content Specialist	1	25	40
CRPD/SCO/2026-27/25 (Contractual Position)				
	Head Sales	1	40	52
	Central Research Team (Product Lead)	2	30	45
	Manager (Business Process)	1	30	40
	Project Development Manager (Technology)	1	25	40
	Central Operations Team (COT) Support	1	30	40

For eligibility criteria (age, experience, job profile etc.), vacancy details, requisite fees, other details and for online submission of application as well as online payment of application fees log on to Bank's website <https://sbi.bank.in/web/careers/current-openings>. Refer detailed advertisement to ensure eligibility and other details before applying and remitting fees. For any query, please write to us through link "CONTACT US" -> "Post Your Query" which is available on Bank's official website (<https://sbi.bank.in/web/careers/post-your-query>)

DATE FOR FILING ONLINE APPLICATION & PAYMENT OF FEES: FROM 30.09.2026 To 21.10.2026.

Place: Mumbai

Date: 30.09.2026

General Manager (RP & PM)

Janardan Bhagat Shikshan Prasarak Sanstha, Panvel
Plot No.4, Sector-11, Khanda Colony, New Panvel (W), Tal.: Panvel, Dist.: Raigad, Pin-410206
Applications are invited for Administrative Assistants

Nature of Post		No. of Posts
Administrative Assistant		02
Educational Qualification	Post Graduate (Preferably MBA) (Any Stream)	
Experience	Atleast 05 (Five) Years experience at Administrative Office either in Corporate or in Higher Educational Institutions	

Hard Skills

- Data Entry and Management
- Advanced Proficiency in Microsoft Office Suit
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- Typing Speed and Accuracy (English and Marathi)
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- Customer Relationship Management
- Business Correspondence
- Time Management and Scheduling

Soft Skills

- Effective Communication and Active Listening
- Time Management and Prioritization
- Adaptability and Flexibility
- Problem-Solving and Critical Thinking
- Attention to Detail and Accuracy
- Customer Service and Client Relations
- Teamwork and Collaboration
- Organizational and Filing Skills
- Confidentiality and Discretion
- Stress Management and Resilience

Applications with full details (Email address and WhatsApp number) should reach with the attested photocopy of certificates to **The Chairman, Janardan Bhagat Shikshan Prasarak Sanstha, 6th Floor, Plot No. 4, Sector 11, Khanda Colony, New Panvel (W), Tal.: Panvel, Dist.: Raigad, Pin-410206**. Candidates may submit application by email to jbsp123_sanstha@yahoo.in on or before 16/10/2026. In case of any query contact - Mrs. Suvarna Chaudhari - 9222161835

Hon. Shri. Ramsheth Thakur (Ex M.P.)
CHAIRMAN
Janardan Bhagat Shikshan Prasarak Sanstha Panvel

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(Affiliated to KBC North Maharashtra University, Jalgaon)
Permisson Letter No.: JDHE/Amravati/NOC/2026/00007
Dated: 17 July, 2026

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for the following **Grant-in-Aid, Full-Time posts** of Assistant Professor:

Sr.No.	Subject	No. of Posts	Category
1	English	01	Open
2	History	01	Open
3	Geography	01	Open
4	Economics	01	Open

Detailed Advertisement: Educational qualifications, eligibility conditions, pay scale and other details are available on the College website www.smccollege.in and KBC North Maharashtra University website www.nmu.ac.in

Application : Eligible candidates shall submit their applications within 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement, either offline or online.

E-mail: secretaryvbsm@gmail.com / smcmuk@gmail.com

Address for Correspondence :
The Secretary
Vidya Bharati Shaikshanik Mandal,
C. K. Naidu Road, Camp, Amravati- 444602.

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2.	Assistant Professor	Chemistry	01	Open
3.	Assistant Professor	Computer Science	01	Open
4.	Assistant Professor	Economics	01	Open
5.	Assistant Professor	Mathematics	01	Open
6.	Assistant Professor	Microbiology	02	Open

Permission has been granted vide **NOC No. JDHE/Jalgaon/ NOC/ 2026/00005** dated 04.09.2026 and KBCNMU/18/1106/2026 dated 24.09.2026.

Qualifications, Terms and Conditions: The requisite educational qualifications, terms and conditions, and pay scale for the post of Assistant Professor shall be as prescribed by the UGC and the Government of Maharashtra. Detailed information is available on the websites of the University and the College: www.nmu.ac.in; www.rcpasc.ac.in

How to Apply: Eligible candidates shall submit their applications along with duly certified copies of all relevant documents. Applications may be submitted within Fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this advertisement either in Offline or Online mode to the President/Secretary, R. C. Patel Educational Trust's R. C. Patel Arts, Commerce and Science College, Karvand Road, Near Karvand Naka, Shirpur, Dist. Dhule - 425405 (M.S.).

For Online Applications: Applications may be sent to contact@rcpasc.ac.in.

Hon. Rajgopal C. Bhandari
Secretary

Hon. Bhupeshbhai R. Patel
President

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Application Start Date: w.e.f. 30/09/2026
Last Date for Submission of Application: 21/10/2026
Contact Details: Ph.: 022-69519320 / Email: hr@cbhfl.com

Janardan Bhagat Shikshan Prasarak Sanstha, Panvel
Plot No.4, Sector-11, Khanda Colony, New Panvel (W), Tal.: Panvel, Dist.: Raigad, Pin-410206
Applications are invited for I.T. Coordinator

Nature of Post		No. of Posts
IT Coordinator		02
Educational Qualification	Graduate or Post Graduate in Computer Science / I.T. / Computer Applications / IT Management / Information System) With additional knowledge of I.T. hardware is preferred	
Experience	5+ Years in IT Management or leadership role	

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- **Security** - Implementing and maintaining security protocols, such as firewalls and antivirus software, to protect institute data and systems
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- **Documentation** - Creating and maintaining documentation for IT systems and procedures
- **Scope** - Complete IT infrastructure, Computer and Accessories, ICT equipments, Smart Boards, Projectors, Screens, CCTV Cameras, Online Meetings, VC, etc.

Skills and Qualifications

- **Technical Skills** - Strong knowledge of computer hardware, software, operating systems (Windows, macOS), and networking concepts
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- **Communication Skills** - Ability to communicate technical information clearly and concisely to users of all technical levels / management
- **Service Skills** - Excellent service skills to provide helpful and patient support to users
- **Organizational Skills** - Ability to prioritize tasks, manage time effectively, and maintain accurate records

Applications with full details (Email address and WhatsApp number) should reach with the attested photocopies of certificates to **The Principal, Changu Kana Thakur Arts, Commerce and Science College, New Panvel, (Empowered Autonomous) Plot No.1, Sector-11, Khanda Colony, New Panvel (W), Tal.: Panvel, Dist.: Raigad, Pin-410206**. Candidates may submit application by email to principal@ckthakurcollege.net on or before 16/10/2026. In case of any query contact **Mr. P. N. Thakur-90226 00288**

Hon. Shri. Ramsheth Thakur (Ex M.P.)
CHAIRMAN
Janardan Bhagat Shikshan Prasarak Sanstha Panvel

4 found dead inside grounded ship amid suspected theft bid

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, September 30

ASUSPECTED attempt to steal copper pipes from a grounded tanker turned fatal when a blast inside the vessel left four men dead and forced three others to flee, police said. The seven had allegedly entered the Nicaragua-flagged MT Al Jafzia, a merchant vessel, near Manori Island on Saturday evening to cut and steal copper pipes when the incident occurred near the engine room.

Police suspect a pipe connected to the vessel's air-conditioning system may have burst while the men were cutting it. Four of the men may have subsequently suffocated after inhaling the gas released from the AC, officials said.

One of the survivors, Vijaya Premnath Sanjiva, 40, suffered facial injuries and was also rendered unconscious after inhaling the gas. His two associates, who allegedly helped him escape from the vessel, are absconding.

"Sanjiva told us that he became unconscious after sustaining facial injuries and inhaling the gas. When he regained consciousness, he saw two of his associates near him. Before he could understand what had happened, they took him away from the vessel," said Deputy Commissioner of Police Sandip Ghuge, North Zone II.

A police officer said that the four bodies found inside the ship have been identified. Three of the deceased were residents of Virar, while one was from Colaba.

After the inquest panchnama, the bodies will be shifted to a hospital for post-mortem examination.

The incident came to light late Monday evening when Sanjiva made inquiries in Colaba and learnt that the men who had accompanied him to the tanker had not returned

Seven entered vessel to cut & steal copper pipes, say police; 1 injured, 2 absconding



The MT Al Jafzia was among three foreign-flagged merchant vessels that broke free from their anchorage off the Mumbai coast near Colaba on July 6 amid rough seas and strong winds.

home. He then approached the Gorai police station and told officers about their alleged plan to steal copper pipes.

According to police, the seven travelled from Colaba to the tanker in an engine boat, which they claimed they had purchased for fishing. Police are verifying the claim and suspect the men had done a reconnaissance before entering the vessel. They had also carried snacks and allegedly spent the night on the vessel. The blast occurred around 7 am on Sunday, police said.

After Sanjiva approached the police, the Gorai police alerted the Indian Navy, Coast Guard, Yellow Gate police, BMC, Disaster Management authorities and Fire Brigade.

"During the inquiry, police found four bodies near the engine room," Ghuge said.

The bodies have been sent for post-mortem examination. An accidental death report has been registered. Police are also in the process of registering an FIR. A theft case will be regis-

tered after the value of the allegedly targeted copper pipes is ascertained.

Police have contacted the owner of MT Al Jafzia and informed him about the incident.

The MT Al Jafzia was among three foreign-flagged merchant vessels that broke free from their anchorage off the Mumbai coast near Colaba on July 6 amid rough seas and strong winds. The anchor chain of the Nicaragua-flagged tanker snapped, causing it to drift before it ran aground near Manori Island.

The other two vessels also drifted close to the coastline, prompting the Indian Coast Guard to respond after being alerted by the Directorate General of Shipping. The Coast Guard had apprehended the three vessels in February after they allegedly carried out illegal mid-sea-ship-to-ship transfers of Iranian bitumen and fuel after switching off their tracking systems. The vessels were detained within Indian territorial waters, and cases were registered against their owners and others.

After nearly 4 years in freezer, 78-yr-old man's body cremated as family agrees

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, September 30

NEARLY FOUR years after his death, the remains of a 78-year-old man that had been kept in a freezer at a day-care centre in Kurar, Malad (East), were finally cremated on Wednesday after his daughter agreed to it.

The body was removed from the premises late Tuesday night after the deceased's wife gave her no-objection certificate for the cremation. Police arranged a vehicle to take the remains to a crematorium in the western suburbs, where the family performed the last rites and cremated him in an electric crematorium on Wednesday, a senior police officer said.

The man had died in June 2022 after suffering a heart attack. He was also undergoing treatment for cancer. Police said his death certificate recorded a natural death and that their inquiry had found nothing suspicious about his death.

His daughter, who is in her 40s, had kept his body in the freezer because she was deeply attached to him and wanted to preserve him permanently, police said. The matter came to light only after the premises became part of a proposed redevelopment project. The landlord informed the tenant operating the day-care centre that the premises would have to be vacated as discussions with a developer were underway. The tenant then



The body was kept in a freezer at a day-care centre in Kurar.

contacted the daughter and asked her to make arrangements to move the freezer.

As the tenant and the family

were looking for another place where the freezer could be kept, the presence of the body came to light and police were informed.

After his death, she had contacted an organisation in the US that provides body-preservation services. She told police she initially received a positive response but was unable to proceed for nearly a year because of health-related issues.

When she made further inquiries, she learnt that preserving a body in the US could cost around Rs 2 crore, police said. She then began looking for similar facilities in other countries at a lower cost and was trying to understand the legal formalities involved in sending a body abroad, including whether per-

mission from the Central government would be required.

The search continued for years. During this period, the daughter continued paying rent for the premises where the freezer was kept. Police said she did not disclose how much she had paid, describing it as a personal matter connected to her attachment to her father.

Since the amount was not directly relevant to the inquiry, police did not pursue it, the officer said. The daughter also told police that she got the idea of preserving her father after an acquaintance told her that he had sent his own father's body to the US for preservation. Police said they had not independently verified this claim.

Preserving a body: What does the law allow?

Zeeshan Shaikh
Mumbai, September 30

A 78-YEAR-OLD man's body lay in a freezer at a Malad day care centre for nearly four years after his death in 2022, police said. His daughter, who told police she was deeply attached to him, had obtained a death certificate and wanted to preserve his body, even exploring the possibility of taking it to the US. The unusual case raises a larger question on What does Indian law allow when a family wants to preserve a dead body and for how long?

Is there a fixed time limit for preserving bodies in India?

There is no single national law prescribing that every dead body must be cremated or buried within a specified number of days. Bodies may be kept tem-

porarily in mortuaries while relatives complete arrangements, police investigations or post mortems are carried out, or the remains are prepared for transportation.

The legal framework comes from several laws dealing with registration of deaths, public health, municipal administration and transportation of human remains.

Mumbai has a specific provision. Section 441 of the Mumbai Municipal Corporation Act says a person cannot retain a corpse on any premises, without burning, burying or otherwise lawfully disposing of it, for so long after death as to create a nuisance. The provision does not amount to a fixed number of days. Whether retention becomes un-

lawful therefore depends on the circumstances, including the condition of the body and the public health implications.

How are bodies preserved?

Refrigeration is the simplest method. Lower temperatures slow the biological processes that cause decomposition. The National Disaster Management Authority's guidelines on management of bodies also recognise ice as a method of preservation, particularly where refrigeration is not available.

For longer preservation, embalming may be used. In arterial embalming, preservative chemicals are introduced through a major blood vessel and into parts of the body. The NDMA guidelines describe

chemical preservation using formalin based solutions and say it can be used when bodies need to be preserved for longer periods, including when they have to be transported over long distances.

For bodies arriving in India from abroad, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare requires, among other documents, an embalming certificate, death certificate and prescribed packaging.

What is cryonics?

Cryonics is something quite different from keeping a body in a freezer. It refers to the experimental practice of cooling a legally dead person to extremely low temperatures, generally using liquid nitrogen, in the hope that future technology may one day make revival possible. The process involves

specialised preparation and the use of cryoprotective chemicals intended to limit damage caused by ice formation before the remains are placed in long term cryogenic storage.

What if the family wants to take the body abroad?

There are specific procedures for transporting human remains internationally. The Ministry of Health's eCARE system requires documents including an embalming certificate, death certificate and other clearances for human remains arriving in India. The remains have to be placed in prescribed, hermetically sealed packaging. The Aircraft Public Health Rules, 1954 require prior permission from the competent authority of the destination country and the relevant Indian authority.

Matang protest called off as state assures decision on demands

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

THE MATANG community called off its protest in Mumbai Wednesday morning after the state government assured protesters it will take a decision on their demand for sub-categorisation of Scheduled Caste reservations within three months.

The protesters had blocked the road between Metro Cinema and CSMT railway station as part of their agitation, demanding implementation of SC reservation through sub-categorisation and a Government Resolution (GR) on the issue.

According to police, Minister Girish Mahajan, accompanied by MLA Amit Gorakhe and a delegation, met protesters at Azad Maidan around 1 am on Wednesday and held discussions on their demands. The delegation assured them that the government would work towards resolving the issue within three months.

"A minister came and spoke with them late at night, following which the protest was withdrawn late at night on September 30," police said.

The protesters, who had been insisting on a GR on sub-categorisation, agreed to withdraw the agitation following the assurance and began making arrangements to return home.



Moderate rain lashed parts of Mumbai and its neighbouring districts on Wednesday. AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

Another rainfall deficit month for city, 20% below average in Sept

Nayonika Bose
Mumbai, September 30

WITH STRONG monsoon currents eluding the region, Mumbai reeled under yet another month of deficit rainfall with the suburban station recording below average showers of 304.2 mm throughout September.

As the southwest monsoon enters its final leg, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast only light showers in the upcoming week.

Typically, the suburbs of Mumbai receive 2,390 mm rainfall throughout the monsoon season that spans from June to September while the Colaba coastal station receives 2,102

mm rain. However, amid intensifying El Nino weather patterns, this monsoon season has been characterised by a rain deficit – barring July when the city clocked in above average rainfall by a margin of 66 per cent.

After recording below average rainfall in June and August, Mumbai recorded deficit showers even in September. Data from the IMD shows that between September 1 and September 30, the suburban station in Santacruz recorded 304.2 mm rainfall. This marks a 20 per cent below the normal rainfall in September when the Santacruz observatory records an average of 383.5 mm rainfall.

In some respite, moderate

spells of rainfall lashed parts of Mumbai and its neighbouring districts on Tuesday night. However, the showers remained concentrated in the suburban pockets which recorded 31.2 mm rain between Tuesday and Wednesday morning while the island city division remained dry.

In August too, Mumbai received only 318 mm rainfall which accounts for only 57 per cent of its actual monthly average of 560.8 mm. With the onset of October, the city now braces for the withdrawal of monsoon. The city is set witness further roll back in rain activity with the IMD forecasting on light showers throughout the Konkan region till the next week.

Sahil Wakode's parents seek police protection, cite 'intimidation' fears

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

THE PARENTS of IIT Bombay student Sahil Wakode, who died by suicide on September 18, have sought police protection, saying they fear intimidation and coercion by persons named in the case. In a letter to Mumbai Police Commissioner submitted through their lawyer Nikhil Kamble on Wednesday, the family also sought protection of evidence related to the case.

The letter points out that those named in the case, including IIT Bombay Director Prof Shireesh Kedare and faculty member Prof Suryanarayan Doolia, have not been arrested. The family apprehends that their positions and perceived influence could expose them to pressure or intimidation, it said.

The letter also refers to CCTV footage relating to Sahil's examination being broadcast by news channels on September 23, saying the source of its disclosure re-



Parents of Sahil Wakode sit on a hunger strike at Azad Maidan in Mumbai on Wednesday. GANESH SHIRSEKAR

mains unknown. The family has sought protection before any incident occurs, stating that they fear that persons seeking to obstruct their pursuit of the case could harm them.

Sahil's parents also continued with their hunger strike at Azad Maidan, which began on Monday, demanding the immediate arrest of those named in the case. The protest has to be renewed through permission

each day. Sahil's father, Ravindra Wakode, said that the family plans to continue with the protest until the accused is arrested.

Meanwhile, students continuing a sit-in protest near IIT main gate alleged that security personnel forcibly moved them to another location nearby, saying they were obstructing movement. IIT Bombay did not respond to a query on whether the protesters were forcibly moved.

97% of Ganesh idols immersed in artificial ponds this year: BMC

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

REDUCING THE environmental impact of idol immersion considerably after Ganeshotsav this year, 97 per cent of Ganesh idols in Mumbai were immersed in artificial ponds, according to Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) data.

Of the 1.97 lakh idols recorded this year, 1.92 lakh took place in artificial ponds, of which 1.22 lakh were of Plaster of Paris (PoP) and 69,846 were clay idols. The civic body had set up 383 artificial ponds across the city this time, up from 268 last year.

The makeshift ponds, created using inflatable tubes or by excavating available open spaces, are intended to prevent

PoP idols and other immersion debris from entering natural water bodies. PoP does not readily dissolve in water and can contribute to pollution and harm aquatic life.

"People are favouring these artificial ponds over natural ones, keeping in mind environmental concerns. From next year, we aim to set up artificial tanks dedicatedly for clay and PoP idols for easier retrieval of debris," a civic official told The Indian Express.

The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) guidelines stipulate that material deposited in designated artificial immersion ponds be removed and stored in an environmentally sound manner until it can be taken up for regeneration, recyc-



The civic body had set up 383 artificial ponds across the city. FILE

TOTAL	In artificial ponds	PoP idols	1.22 lakh
1.97 lakh immersions	1.92 lakh immersions	Clay idols	69,846

ling or reuse. For the time being, the debris of idol immersion are kept in a temporary storage facility at Mulund.

The use of artificial ponds gained momentum during the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020, when restrictions on gatherings led the BMC to provide immersion facilities within municipal wards. Initially, around 50 such ponds were set up across the city.

This year, K-West ward, covering Andheri West, Juhu and Versova, had the highest number of artificial ponds at 34, followed by G-South, covering Worli, with 32, and D ward, covering Malabar Hill, Kemp's Corner and Peddar Road, with 27.

In 2023, the Bombay High Court directed the civic body to ensure safe immersion of idols.

However, civic officials said larger public Ganesh idols were still more likely to be immersed in natural water bodies such as the sea because of their size.

The BMC collected Rs 18.7 lakh in penalties in 1,336 cases in September under its solid waste management bylaws, which came into force this year.

The highest number of cases — 443 — involved failure to maintain cleanliness in and around residential and commercial premises, attracting Rs 7.8 lakh in penalties. Another Rs 5.98 lakh was imposed in 35 cases involving construction and demolition waste. Of these, 29 involved dumping such waste at unauthorised locations and six involved its transportation without an approved plan.

• BRIEFLY

Manhole death in Santacruz: panel seeks action

THE NATIONAL Commission for Safai Karamcharis Tuesday wrote to the Mumbai Suburban district collector Saurabh Katiyar to take action as per the Manual Scavenging Rules, 2013, on the death of Santosh Ganpat Kashe, who was cleaning a sewer in Santacruz. Rahul Kashyap, the secretary of the panel, instructed the Collector to ensure that an insurance of Rs 10 lakh is paid to the victim's family, and a compensation of Rs 30 lakh is paid to the family for their rehabilitation. ENS

Edu dept officers protest against police action

OFFICERS OF the school education department from Malegaon staged a protest at Azad Maidan Wednesday demanding that police action against some of them while they were performing their duties be quashed. Protestors demanded that no police action should be taken against officers without permission from the education department. This comes days after the death of a teacher at a Malegaon school, allegedly during an inquiry by local education department officers. ENS



FESTIVAL TIME: Residents of Dharavi make earthen garba pots ahead of the Navratri festival. AKASH PATIL

HC discharges Rahul Raj Singh in Pratyusha Banerjee suicide case

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

THE BOMBAY High Court on Wednesday discharged Rahul Raj Singh, accused in the suicide case of actor Pratyusha Banerjee in 2016. Banerjee, who played the lead role in the television show Balika Vadhu, died by suicide at her rented apartment in Goregaon (West) on April 1, 2016.

Rahul Raj Singh was booked on charges of abetting her suicide and was granted anticipatory bail by the Bombay High Court in July 2016. He moved the Sessions Court with a dis-

charge plea after the Bangur Nagar Police submitted a chargesheet in 2018.

While Singh claimed that the couple was planning to get married in December 2016, Banerjee was deeply disturbed because of her mother's constant interference in her affairs.

The Dindoshi Sessions Court in the western suburbs rejected his discharge plea in August 2023, prompting him to approach the High Court with a revision application, challenging the rejection order.

The sessions court, while refusing relief to Rahul Raj Singh, had observed that statements

of witnesses prima facie showed the accused had made the life of the deceased a "living hell" and it was the harassment by the accused that made Banerjee take her own life.

However, a single-judge bench of Justice Shivkumar G Dige of the HC relied on sub-missions by senior advocate Aabad Ponda and advocate Shreyans Mithare for Singh that the last conversation between him and the deceased reflected that he tried to convince her not to take any drastic or extreme step while he was on his way to meet her; therefore, there was no case of abetment against him.

Kanjurmarg Metro Line 6 depot clears final legal hurdle

Sabah Virani
Mumbai, September 30

THE LONG-RUNNING legal battle over the Kanjurmarg land earmarked for the Metro Line 6 depot ended, with the Supreme Court on Tuesday refusing to interfere with a Bombay High Court order rejecting a former leaseholder's claim over the 15-hectare plot.

The order clears the final legal hurdle before the land can be transferred from the Centre to the Maharashtra government, paving the way for construction of the long-delayed depot.

The Supreme Court dismissed a special leave petition filed by Maheshkumar G Garodia, who had claimed rights over the Kanjurmarg land under a 99-year lease. The order, passed by a bench headed by Chief Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, was uploaded on Wednesday.

The Bombay High Court had in February rejected Garodia's claim.

MMRDA sets up control room for emergencies on project sites

Sabah Virani
Mumbai, September 30

AMID A rise in the number of incidents at metro project construction sites, the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) has set up a 24x7 Safety & Response Co-ordination Centre (SRCC) to register public grievances and safety concerns.

Citizens have been instructed to dial 1800228801 for all concerns linked to construction sites, barricading, traffic management, road conditions, damage, dust, or other inconveniences. The complaint will then be escalated based on its urgency. Senior officials, who will track the SRCC dashboard, will follow up on the concerns raised and recurrences across projects, contractors, and consultants. This action comes after multiple incidents in September, several of which proved fatal.

Some MMRDA officials said concerns registered with the SRCC will be tracked until some corrective action is taken.

VJTI MUMBAI
वीजमता इंजिनियरिंग संस्थान मुंबई
Veeramata Jijeebhai Technological Institute
(Autonomous Institute of Govt. of Maharashtra)
H. R. Mahajani Road, Malunga (East), Mumbai - 400 019
Phone: +91 22 24198101/102 Fax: +91 22 24102874 www.vjti.ac.in

Notice Inviting Tender (Second Call)

E-tenders are invited for the work of "Renovation of Existing Internet Laboratory as CoE AI." (Second Call) having an estimated cost of Rs. 1,11,89,000/- from eligible contractors having experience in this type of work.

The blank tender forms are available on the Maha Tender website: <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

The interested tenderers are requested to download the entire document from the MahaTenders website.

Last date of submission of the E-Tender document duly filled in shall be 12th October 2026 up to 5.30 p.m.

For further details, please see the detailed tender notice on the Mahatender website. The right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof will be with the competent authority of VJTI.

Registrar
VJTI, Mumbai

STATE BANK OF INDIA

MUMBAI (METRO) CIRCLE, CCO DEPARTMENT

Local Head Office, Bandra Kurla Complex,
Bandra (East), Mumbai - 400 051

EMPANELMENT OF CONSULTANTS FOR CONDUCTING TECHNO ECONOMIC VIABILITY (TEV) STUDY

State Bank of India, Mumbai (Metro) Circle invites applications in the prescribed format from the Individual, Proprietor, Partnership Firms, Company, Limited Liability Partnership (LLP) for empanelment as TEV/ (Techno Economic Viability) Consultant for the period from **01.12.2026 to 30.11.2029** for conducting TEV studies for the Bank.

The Application format along with the details regarding eligibility criteria and terms and conditions can be obtained from Bank's website <https://sbi.bank.in> under "Empanelment of vendors" in "SBI in the News".

Those willing to get empanelled shall submit their applications in prescribed format along with relevant enclosures/ documents etc. to the nearest **SME Intensive Branch/Regional Business Office/ Administrative Office** latest by 24.10.2026 (05.00 P.M.). After receipt of the documents & duly verified KYC by the officials of the respective branches, the said application will be forwarded by the concerned Branch to **The Dy General Manager & CCO, State Bank of India, Local Head Office, "Synergy" 7th floor, C-6, "G" Block, Bandra - Kurla Complex, Bandra (East), Mumbai- 400 051.**

Existing empanelled TEV Consultants needs to apply afresh with all the necessary documents.

The bank reserves the right to update, amend/ modify, or supplement the terms and conditions of empanelment and withdraw the advertisement without any notice. The issuance of this advertisement does not imply that the Bank is bound to empanel the applicant as TEV consultants, and the Bank reserves the right to reject all or any of the applications without assigning any reason whatsoever.

TEV Consultants having offices in Mumbai Metropolitan Region & Konkan region of Maharashtra State & Goa State will only be considered for empanelment.

Place: Mumbai
Date: 21.09.2026

Deputy General Manager & CCO

Maharashtra

CITES 'ABYSMALLY SLOW PACE OF TRIAL'

HC grants bail to HAL employee arrested for 'sharing fighter aircraft details' with ISI

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, September 30

CITING THE "abysmally slow pace of the trial," the Bombay High Court on Tuesday granted bail to an assistant supervisor of Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) arrested by the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) in 2020 in a "classic case of honey-trapping" for allegedly sharing secret information on Indian fighter aircraft with a person affiliated with Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI).

A single-judge bench of Justice Milind N Jadhav on Tuesday passed an order on a bail application by Deepak Shravan Shirsath, who was arrested by the ATS in October 2020 on charges of espionage, claiming that he was lured by a woman, posing as a UK-based model with an interest in aeronautics, into sharing pictures and vital information on Sukhoi jets. As per the ATS Nashik unit, the ISI created a fake social media account of a woman, who lured the applicant, working with HAL for 16 years, into sharing

pictures of his notes and HAL's manufacturing unit at Ozar.

"This is a classic case of honey-trapping where the applicant was indicted under various provisions of the Indian Penal Code, Indian Official Secrets Act, and the Information Technology Act. Two accused persons are involved, one is absconding as usual which happens in such cases," Justice Jadhav noted, adding that the applicant had been incarcerated for four years and 11 months. The bench observed that the charges were framed

against the applicant and the trial had commenced, but the prosecution had examined only five out of 59 probable witnesses; therefore, "the pace of the trial is abysmally slow, which is prima facie evident."

Justice Jadhav noted that while senior advocate Mihir Desai for the applicant would argue on the merits of the case, the court would "refrain from commenting on the same since the trial has commenced," and would decide the plea "purely only on the basis of prolonged incarceration."

Additional Public Prosecutor Rajeshree V Newton for the ATS opposed the plea, seeking his incarceration till the completion of the trial for being accused of sedition and waging a war against the nation.

However, Justice Jadhav rejected the argument and granting bail on strict conditions held, "I am prima facie of the view that Article 21 of the Constitution persuades me to consider the Applicant's case where the right to speedy trial and justice is a valuable right of the Applicant for grant of bail."

MPSC aspirants call off Oct 2 protest after meeting CM

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

MPSC STUDENTS decided to call off their October 2 agitation following a meeting with Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis Wednesday in Mumbai. In the meeting, the state government assured aspirants about addressing all issues raised by them regarding the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) exams, in addition to assurances of massive recruitment drives.

At the meeting, Fadnavis informed the students that the government will initiate recruit-

ment for government jobs for three years. It will also consider posts that will be vacant after existing employees retire. He assured that all processes along with a recruitment time table will be ready within a month.

MPSC aspirants have been agitating over various issues such as exam irregularities, paper leaks, delays in results as well as recruitment processes. Aspirants had been demanding the resignation of MPSC chairman Vivek Bhimanwar. The October 2 agitation was scheduled to be held in Pune.

During the meeting, the CM

said, "MPSC president is a constitutional post. The state government and Governor cannot remove him from the post. They don't have that right to do so. The decision rests with the president of India based on the recommendations of the Supreme Court."

The students had demanded the removal of MPSC's former and present president and its members under section 371. The government has assured of a judicial process within three months in the matter, however, the MPSC secretary's transfer will be

done immediately.

All the MPSC exams will be done offline. The government will not take any decisions without consulting all students groups. "Recruitments to government jobs will be done on a massive scale which will break all the previous records. Over the years recruitments for 30,000 to 40,000 jobs were pending. The sanction for filling posts would never exceed 30 to 40 per cent. Now the government has taken a decision to initiate the process to under-

take recruitment on a larger scale," Fadnavis said.

The government said a mechanism will be built so that exams can be done through one single card which will be available at a low price.

Manoj Pingale, a candidate who was part of the delegation that met with the CM, said, "The discussion has been positive. Candidates are also hopeful of upcoming revamps in the recruitment exam processes, as a government-appointed committee is looking at over."

GOVT. OF BIHAR

BIHAR COMBINED ENTRANCE COMPETITIVE EXAMINATION BOARD
L.A.S. Association Building, Near Patna Airport, Patna-14.

Website : bceceboard.bihar.gov.in / Helpdesk : helpdesk.bceceboard@bihar.gov.in

UNDER GRADUATE MEDICAL ADMISSION COUNSELLING (UGMAC)-2026 for MBBS/ BDS/ B.V.Sc. & A.H./ B.F.Sc. in Govt. Medical / Dental / Veterinary Colleges / College of Fisheries and Private Medical / Dental Colleges of Bihar

Adv. No.- BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/10 Dated 30.09.2026

Notice for Round-3 Online Application & Choice Filling

Online Registration & Submission of Application-cum-Choice filling after Round-2 are invited from such qualified, eligible & interested NEET(UG)-2026 candidates for appearing in the Round-3 Online Counselling of Under Graduate Medical Admission Counselling (UGMAC)-2026, who have not done the Registration and submission of Online Application or who has completed their registration process but did not duly submit Online Application with payment of requisite Counselling Fee & Security Deposit against Adv. No. BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/01 & 2026/02 Dated 07.08.2026, 2026/05 Dated 11.09.2026, 2026/07 Dated 15.09.2026 and 2026/08 Dated 17.09.2026 and are not admitted in any Medical / Dental Colleges of India, for admission to the first year UG Medical / Dental Courses (MBBS/ BDS) in Government / Private Medical / Dental Colleges and B.V.Sc. & A.H. / B.F.Sc. courses in Govt. Veterinary / Fisheries Colleges of Bihar state based on the Rank of UGMAC-2026 prepared on the basis of AIR of NEET(UG)-2026 on the basis of vacant seats available after admission on the basis of UGMAC-2026 Online Round-2 Counselling held from 27.09.2026 to 29.09.2026.

2. Updated Seat Matrix of vacancies after completion of Round-2 Counselling is available on Board's website: bceceboard.bihar.gov.in. If any further vacancies due to resignation etc. arise, the Updated Seat Matrix will be uploaded on the Board's website. The candidate must see it before Online Registration & Submission of Application-cum-Choice filling / submitting their Consent / editing of choices for Online Counselling.

3. The online Registration & submission of Application-cum-Choice Filling / Editing of Application Form data / Editing of Choices will start from 03.10.2026.

4. Eligibility criteria for counselling / admission Fee payment procedure, instructions and other details for filling up online applications form-cum-choice filling are available in the Prospectus of UGMAC-2026 and the related Advertisement No.-BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/09 dated 30.09.2026, which can be seen / downloaded from the Board's website: bceceboard.bihar.gov.in.

Controller of Examination

Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC)
(A Government of India Enterprise)

4th National Call for Proposals under E-YUVA Scheme

Empowering Youth for Undertaking Value Added Innovative Translational Research

BIRAC'S E-YUVA FELLOWS
Upto 150 Under Graduate pursuing students shall be supported to undertake entrepreneurial projects
*1st and 2nd year UG students are encouraged to apply

BIRAC'S INNOVATION FELLOWS
Upto 27 Post Graduate or Postdoctoral students shall be supported to undertake entrepreneurial projects

Salient Benefits

- Fellowship and Annual research grant for biotech entrepreneurial projects
- Incubation support under any 9 E-YUVA Centres and mentoring by BioNEST Bio-incubators
- Integrating young minds into the biotech ecosystem

Application Submission Starts
1st October 2026

Apply Online
www.birac.nic.in

Closes on
31st October 2026 (17:30hrs)

FOR ANY QUERIES, PLEASE WRITE TO:
Dr. Chhaya Chauhan, Chief Manager & Incharge-Incubation | sped4@birac.nic.in
Ms. Harshita Bhawsar, Officer-Incubation & ED | user-038@birac.nic.in

FORM - II
STARONE GLOBAL PRIVATE LIMITED
Notice under sub-section (2) of Section 15 of Electricity Act, 2003

1. The Starone Global Private Limited ("SGPL Applicant"), a public limited and a Government company incorporated under Companies Act, 2013 incorporated on 28.06.2016 under Companies Act, 2013, has made an application under sub-section (1) of Section 15 of the Electricity Act, 2003 for grant of **Category-V** license for inter State trading in electricity in all regions across India before the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, New Delhi. The necessary details in respect of the applicant are given hereunder.

i) Authorized issued, subscribed and paid-up capital:

a)	Authorised share capital Rs. 2,00,00,000/-
b)	Issued share capital Rs. 44,75,000/-
c)	Subscribed share capital Rs. 44,75,000/-
d)	Paid-up share capital Rs. 44,75,000/-

ii) Shareholding pattern (indicate the details of the shareholders holding 5% and above of the shares of the applicant):

Name of Shareholder	Mr. Venkat Maloo
Citizenship	NA
Residential Status	India
No. of Shares	1,37,500
Shareholding %	31%

Name of Shareholder	Mrs. Sunanda Maloo
Citizenship	NA
Residential Status	India
No. of Shares	2,25,000
Shareholding %	50%

Name of Shareholder	Mr. Ashok Kumar Maloo
Citizenship	NA
Residential Status	India
No. of Shares	85,000
Shareholding %	19%

iii) Financial and technical strength: SGPL has adequate financial and technical resources and full-time professionals having industry expertise in the power sector including power trading, regulatory affairs and finance.

iv) Management profile of the application including details of past experiences of the applicant and/or the persons on the management of the applicant in generation, transmission, distribution and trading of electricity or similar activity.

Saswat Kumar Maharana - Vice- President, Operations: possesses more than 15 years of experience in the fields of System Operation, Power Trading and power market operations. **Qualifications:** B.Tech from Indus College of Engineering, Odisha (2011), and is presently pursuing a Master of Business Administration in Operations from Syntaxis School of Digital Learning.

Manish Agarwal - Vice President, Finance: possesses more than 12 years of experience in finance, commerce and accounts, including taxation, audit and statutory compliance. **Qualification:** Chartered Accountant, Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, (2012) Licentiate of the Insurance Institute of India (2019), and holds a Bachelor of Commerce (Honours) degree from Calcutta University.

Deepesh Kumar - General Manager, Operations: possesses more than 14 years of experience across power trading, power distribution, open access and electricity market operations. **Qualifications:** Bachelor's degree in Engineering (Electrical and Electronics Engineering) from Sri Siddhartha Institute of Technology, Visvesvaraya Technological University, Belgaum, Karnataka, (2012).

Anirban Dey - Senior Manager, Business Development: has experience in the field of System Operation and Power Trading, including power system forecasting and scheduling, and power exchange trading operations. **Qualifications:** Diploma in Electrical Engineering from SMIT, West Bengal, (2016), and a Bachelor's degree in Electrical Engineering from MAKAUT, (2019).

Hemant Pratap Singh - Manager, Operations: has experience of over 5 years in System Operation, Power Trading, solar photovoltaic system design and permitting. **Qualifications:** Integrated Bachelor's and Master's degree in Civil Engineering from Galgotias University, Uttar Pradesh, (2021).

v) Volume of electricity intended to be traded during the first year after grant of license and future plans of the application to expand volume of trading: **Upto 500 MWs**

vi) Geographical areas within which the applicant will undertake trading in electricity: **Across India**

vii) Net worth as on 31st March of three consecutive years immediately preceding the year of application or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application: (values in INR)

Date	Net worth
31 st August 2026 (on the date of special balance sheet)	INR 2,06,59,068/-
31 st March 2026	INR 2,03,64,162/-
31 st March 2025	INR 1,29,46,405/-
31 st March 2024	INR 44,12,338/-

viii) Year-wise current ratio and liquidity ratio of the applicant for three years preceding the year in which the application is made, or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application:

Date	Current Ratio	Liquidity Ratio
31 st August 2026 (on the date of special balance sheet)	1.43:1	1.16:1
31.03.2026	1.20:1	0.87:1
31.03.2025	1.47:1	0.88:1
31.03.2024	1.44:1	0.78:1

ix) (a) SGPL is authorized to undertake trading in electricity under the Main Objects clause of its Memorandum of Association.
(b) The said clause reads as:
"2. To establish and carry on the business of trading in electricity and act as a trader in sale and purchase of electricity and electrical energy in any form and in any market including power exchange and derivatives market, and by any process and in any fuel, derivatives including but not limited to renewable energy certificates, carbon credits, energy conservation certificates, financially traded electricity forwards, or by products connected With or related to the generation and supply of electrical energy, enter into demand side management contracts, energy conservation contracts including energy performance contracts, megawatt contracts, enter into contracts for banking of electricity in accordance with provisions of Electricity Act, 2003 or any statutory modifications or re-enactment thereof and rules or regulations made thereunder, to operate as an energy trading company and to get registered with appropriate agency including the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, Bureau of Energy Efficiency or any other authority or regulatory commission under the framework of Energy Conservation Act, 2001, Electricity Act, 2003, and regulations/rules framed therein and do all acts and things necessary or required for doing aforesaid business, including providing advisory and consultancy in issues related to energy and trading of energy."

x) Details of cases, if any, where the applicant or any of his associates, or partner, or promoters, or Directors has been declared insolvent and has not been discharged: **NONE**

xi) Details of cases, if any, in which the Applicant or any of his Associates or partners or promoters or Directors has been convicted of an offence involving fraud or misfeasance in public office during the previous three years preceding the year of making the application and the year of making the application and the date of release of the above person from imprisonment, if any, consequent to such conviction: **NONE**

Name of the person: N/A
Relationship with the Applicant: N/A
Nature of offence: N/A
Date of conviction: N/A

xii) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever refused license, and if so, the detailed particular of the application, date of making application, date of order refusing license and reasons for such refusal: **NO**

xiii) Whether the Applicant has been granted a license for transmission of electricity: **NO**

xiv) Whether an order cancelling the license of the Applicant, or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors has been passed by the Commission: **NO**

xv) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever found guilty in any proceedings for contravention non-compliance of any of the provisions of the Act or the rules or the regulations made there under or an order made by the Appropriate Commission, during the year of making the application or five years immediately preceding that year? **NO**

2. The application made and other documents filed before the Commission are available for inspection by any person with Mr. Venkat Maloo, working as Director, addressed at, Diamond Heritage, 6th Floor, Office No. N - 616A, 16 Strand Road, Kolkata - 700001, West Bengal, India - India, email: venkat@staronepoles.com and telephone/mobile no.: (+91) 9674776462.

3. The application made and other documents filed before the Commission have been posted on: www.staronepoles.com

4. Objections or suggestions, if any, on the application made before the Commission may be sent to the Secretary, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, 6, 7 & 8 Floor, Tower 8 World Trade Centre, Naurogi Nagar, New Delhi - 11029, E-mail: secy@cerindia.gov.in within 30 days of publication of this notice, with a copy to the applicant.

5. No objections or suggestions shall be considered by the Commission if received after expiry of 30 days of publication of this notice.

Sd/-
Mr. Venkat Maloo
Director, SGPL

Place: Kolkata
Date: 30th September 2026

EXPRESS special

Drought drives early exodus of sugarcane workers as crops fail

Workers left as early as Aug & Sept with little or no farm work and income

Sadaf Modak
Beed, Dhule, September 30

THE IMPACT of Maharashtra's drought is showing up not just in parched fields but in an early exodus of sugarcane workers, with families from drought-hit Beed, Dhule and Nandurbar leaving their villages weeks before the usual cane-cutting season, after their kharif crops failed.

The workers are mostly small farmers and landless labourers who migrate every year to sugar factories in western Maharashtra and Karnataka to cut and load cane. While the migration usually begins after Dussehra, once farmers have harvested their own crops, this year many have left as early as August and September after being left with little or no farm work or income.

The state government has declared drought in 265 of Maharashtra's 358 talukas across 32 districts. In parts of Marathwada and northern Maharashtra, the failure of the kharif crop has meant families dependent on small farms and agricultural labour have begun looking elsewhere for income even before the farm season is over. Some have travelled farther than usual, including to Tamil Nadu.

In Beed, where rainfall remained absent for much of August and September, families with small landholdings began leaving after realising there would be little work available on other farms.

For Jyoti Thorat, a resident of Kathoda in Beed, six members of her family left for Tamil Nadu by the end of August, their first such migration to the state after a mukadam, or labour contractor, told them work was available at sugar factories there.

"There was no yield from our bajra crop. With no source

of income to survive here, my sister-in-law went to Tamil Nadu with her husband, their two sons and daughter-in-law, and her one-year-old baby. The child could not be left behind without the mother so she had to be taken too. We have spoken on the phone a few times and they told us that the weather is harsh and they are facing many difficulties," said Thorat, who has herself travelled for sugarcane-cutting work in the past.

The drought has also pushed the family into debt even before the migration began. Their two-acre bajra crop failed, forcing them to take an advance from the mukadam to buy bajra from the market, as well as groceries, medicines and clothes. The family is expected to remain at the sugar factory until March.

In Dhule and Nandurbar, too, workers began leaving in the first week of September for sugar factories in western Maharashtra. "We left earlier this month with about 60-70 persons for Baramati. There was no work because the crop was destroyed. Some have taken advance loans and will work at karkhanas (factories) until Holi before they return home. Depending on the loan taken, most are paid around Rs 70,000 as a total amount or according to the tonnes they cut and load," said a mukadam who accompanied farmers from Pangaon village in Dhule.

The cane-cutting system is built around seasonal migration. Workers are typically hired through mukadams, who provide advances before the season and arrange their travel and work at sugar factories. At the factories, workers spend seven to eight hours cutting sugarcane and several more hours loading it onto trucks. Under the "koyta" system, a



Many families in Beed's Kathoda village have left their homes for sugarcane cutting in other regions including Tamil Nadu, western Maharashtra and Karnataka. NARENDRA VASKAR

couple is treated as one unit and is paid around Rs 366 per tonne of sugarcane cut.

For families whose own crops have failed, the advance from the mukadam can provide immediate cash for food



and other essentials, but also ties them to work at the sugar factory for the season.

The early migration comes against the backdrop of long-standing concerns over the conditions of sugarcane workers. In 2023, the Bombay High Court took suo motu cognisance of a report on their condition and noted that 10 to 12 lakh workers migrate from drought-prone areas, including Marathwada, for sugarcane work.

The court had recorded concerns over the lack of drink-

ing water, sanitation and other basic facilities for workers, as well as the risk of bonded labour. When the matter was last heard in March 2025, the state had agreed to suggestions made by amicus curiae Mihir Desai, based on a report by advocates Devyani Kulkarni and Rishika Agarwal. These included better housing, regular health check-ups, creches for infants and continuing the education of children accompanying their parents.

Jivan Rathod, who had filed an intervention plea in the case, said most of the recommendations had not been implemented by sugar factories and that their compliance was not being adequately verified by state authorities.

"The most basic aspects of housing, clean water, and sanitation facilities are also not being adhered to. Now, most of those who are migrating for work are facing acute financial distress because of the drought. There should be stricter compliance by the government regarding their condition but it is not being done," Rathod said. One of the recommendations

in the case was registration of workers migrating for employment. However, district authorities in Marathwada said they had so far received no reports of migration. Officials said employment would be made available to those facing distress through the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G).

Farmers and labourers, however, said work under the scheme had not been forthcoming even as the rains failed.

"The work at a sugar factory is backbreaking. Women have to carry 30-40 kgs of the cut sugarcane on their heads to load and unload them on trucks each time. Why would someone prefer to stay away from their homes in such conditions if work guaranteeing minimum wages were available here? The early distressed migration makes bargaining for their rights even more difficult in such conditions. Failing to account for and provide them employment is a political and administrative failure," said Manisha Tokle of the Mahila Ustod Sanghata and a women's rights activist.

Mounting loans & failed crops: 2 farmers die by suicide in 2 days

Shubham Kurala
Pune, September 30

TWO FARMERS in Maharashtra died by suicide within 24 hours of each other last week, unable to repay loans after their crops failed for the second consecutive year. One was in Nashik's Niphad taluka and the other was in Beed's Ambajogai.

On September 25, during Ganesh immersion processions, Satish Shivaji Kolgire, 38, was found dead on his farm in Radi village in Beed.

His elder brother Gajendra Kolgire found him around 7 am. "Satish was under stress as his loans had mounted to Rs 7-8 lakh. His crops had failed due to drought, and he could not recover his investment or repay what he owed," Gajendra said.

The family owns just one acre. Satish's wife, Vaishali Kolgire, said the couple worked on other people's farms to make ends meet and pay for their children's education. Their son is in Class 6 and their daughter in Class 8. "We don't even have our own house, and the children are too young. The only hope is from the government now," she said. Buddhiraj Sukale, Inspector at Ambajogai (Rural) police station, said, "He appears to have taken the step after his crop failed, and was unable to pay the loans. And no suicide



Satish Kolgire and Santu Rayate. EXPRESS

note was found," he said.

A day later, on Saturday, Santu Rayate, 56, a farmer from Khadakmalegaon village in Niphad taluka of Nashik, allegedly consumed pesticide on his farm. His son, Sham Rayate, 31, said his father left home around 8.30 am, saying he would collect fuel from the petrol pump for the sprayer to be used on their cabbage crop. When he did not respond to calls throughout the day, Sham went looking for him, while Santu was found unconscious after consuming pesticide in his farm. He was rushed to hospital but was declared dead.

Sagar Kote, Assistant Police Inspector at Lasalgaon police station, said, "A note was found in Santu's pocket stating he had consumed the toxic chemical because he could not repay loans. We have registered it as an accidental death and will submit the report to the Tehsil-dar-led committee for any government aid in cases of farmer suicides," he said.

LOAN RECOVERY

Banks directed to not approach farmers in drought-hit talukas

Sub-committee to chief secy: check if RBI can issue note to stop recovery

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

AS THREE-FOURTHS of Maharashtra reels under drought-like conditions, the state government has directed banks not to recover loans from affected farmers.

The stern message came from the drought sub-committee, headed by Revenue Minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule, two days after the state government declared 265 talukas drought-prone and initiated Trigger-1 relief. On Wednesday, 45 more talukas were added to the drought-prone list.

Bawankule said that, in view of the drought-like conditions in the state, all district and taluka officials should be present in their respective offices and attend to drought-related work.

He has also urged Chief Secretary Rajesh Aggarwal to find out whether the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) can issue a letter to stop loan recovery from drought-affected farmers in Maharashtra. Similarly, co-operative credit societies have also been cautioned against harassing farmers for loan/financial recovery.

To ensure help for all farmers affected by drought, the administration has obtained their personal signatures on every panchanama – a taluka-wise exercise to ascertain the exact crop loss suffered by every farmer.

To ensure uninterrupted supply during summers, the water resources department has been instructed to initiate effective water management of dams, ponds, and rivers.

What sub-committee has decided

The drought sub-committee agreed that the government resolution should be issued at the earliest and drought measures should be initiated without waiting to complete formalities.

It has also decided to use a

Sugar federation seeks Rs 1,000 per tonne aid for cane farmers

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 30

WITH DROUGHT expected to hit sugarcane output and recovery rates in Maharashtra, the National Federation of Co-operative Sugar Factories has sought a subsidy of Rs 1,000 per tonne for cane farmers and Rs 500 per tonne for sugar factories.

"Due to drought conditions, sugarcane production is set to decline, and the weight of sugarcane will decrease owing to water scarcity. Therefore, farmers should be granted a subsidy of Rs 1,000 per ton," federation president Harshvardhan Patil said at a press conference at Sugar Bhavan on Wednesday.

Patil said factories could incur losses of Rs 1,000 to Rs 1,200 per tonne because of lower sugar recovery and should therefore receive a subsidy of Rs 500 per tonne.

The federation has also demanded that the minimum selling price of sugar be increased to Rs 45 per kg.

Patil said a delegation led by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis had recently met Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah and raised demands including an increase in the minimum selling price of sugar, a Rs 5 increase in ethanol prices from B and C heavy molasses, debt restructuring and an increase in the Sugar Development Fund.

No decision has been taken on the demands, he said.

majority of CSR funds for drought measures.

Farmers have been experiencing financial distress amid massive crop loss in the Kharif season – primarily due to monsoon rain deficit, aggravated by a gap of 40–60 days between two rain spells.

Sources in the cooperation department said, "The state government had announced its biggest crop loan waiver of Rs 40,385 crore during the monsoon season. The loan waiver is estimated to benefit 56 lakh farmers."

At least three lists of eligible farmers for loan waivers have been processed.

The crop loan waiver is up to Rs 2 lakh, and the reward incentive for the non-defaulted is Rs 50,000.

With the drought situation and crop loss, farmers have failed to recover the expenses they invested during the sowing of Kharif produce – calculated at an average of Rs 18,000 to Rs 20,000 per acre for soybean cultivation – pushing them to borrow from private financial centres, moneylenders, the sub-committee members said.



MONSOON EXIT: With southwest monsoon entering its final leg, clouds hover over Mumbai's skyline on Wednesday. The Indian Meteorological Department has forecast light showers next week. AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

• WATERSHED CONSERVATION MODEL IMPLEMENTED SINCE 1970s CREDITED FOR VILLAGE'S WATER MANAGEMENT

Why Anna Hazare's Ralegan Siddhi stays green amid drought

Manoj More
Pune, September 30

• A FARMER couple in Puna-wadi village stares at a pile of charred bajra. "It got wrecked on its own. How can the crop survive when there is no rain?" asked farmer Macchindra Borude, who had invested Rs 15,000 in the crop and lost everything. "I hope there will be some rain when the monsoon withdraws. I am expecting an onion crop. If it doesn't rain..."

• A few kilometres away, in Parner village, another farmer stands before 18 acres of flattened fields. "After last year's crop failure due to wet drought, I was expecting good rain this monsoon. But in August and September, we could not collect even a glass of rainwater. All our wells, which are 70-80 feet, are running dry. As a result, our crop of soyabean, onion, tur, maize, and bajra has been destroyed," said Balasaheb Awati, 55. Having borrowed Rs 10 lakh, he now faces the prospect of repaying the

loan with little or no income from this season's harvest.

• In another farm, Vilas Borude's decision to run a rotavator through his standing bajra crop shocked villagers. "The crop had grown to a couple of feet and there was no possibility of it growing further as in last two months we only had half an hour of rain. It did not make sense to wait for the crop to wilt completely...so I destroyed it," he said.

These heartbreaking scenes are emblematic of the crisis unfolding in Parner, one of the 14 talukas declared drought-hit in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district. Across the taluka's 131 villages, a prolonged dry spell and severe rainfall deficit have left farmers devastated, grappling with uncertainty about repaying their mounting debts.

Last week, with the state recording a rainfall deficit of 18 per cent this year, the government declared drought in 265 of the state's 358 tehsils—about three-fourths of Maharashtra. Though the Maharashtra



Amid drought, a green valley in Ralegan Siddhi; (right) In another village, crops flattened after rain stayed away for 2 months. MANOJ MORE

government has promised compensation, farmers remain unconvinced. "The government made a similar promise after last year's wet drought. But so far, it has failed to pay even that amount. I don't know when this year's amount will be released," Balasaheb said. "Our village has a population of 13,000 and more than 3,000 farmer homes and we all are



facing a similar predicament. We have no clue what the future holds for us," he added.

A green success story

Yet, amid the parched landscape, one village stands out: Ralegan Siddhi, thanks to the watershed conservation model implemented by social activist Anna Hazare since the 1970s, seems relatively insu-

lated from the drought.

"Compared to other villages in the district, Ralegan Siddhi is better placed. This is because our villagers capture every drop of rain water and store it in check dams and nala bunds (embankments), which has resulted in recharging of the groundwater table," Hazare told The Indian Express in Ralegan Siddhi.

The contrast is evident. Unlike other parts of Ahilyanagar district, where crops have withered away due to poor rainfall or have been destroyed by frustrated farmers, visitors to Ralegan Siddhi are greeted by acres of green fields, standing crops, and percolation tanks filled to the brim.

"We are in a good position today as far as the water situation is concerned. Our farm ponds and percolation tanks have adequate water," said Ashok Awati, a 40-year-old farmer from Ralegan Siddhi, adding a word of caution. "As of now, we are getting borewell water but we are not confident

how long this will sustain. This is because it rained only for three days this monsoon. In August and September when we expected rain, it hardly rained."

Need plans to save water: Anna Hazare

Ashok's father, Baban, 73, recalled the drought in 1972. "When Maharashtra was hit by the worst drought in its history, another villager and I left Ralegan Siddhi and worked in Gujarat to sustain our families. Several other villagers also did the same. The situation is better for us today because of Anna Hazare's efforts. We have water, other villages don't," he said.

Ralegan Siddhi sarpanch Jaysing Mapari credited Hazare for the village's current situation. "It is due to his efforts that several check dams and nala bunds have come up in Ralegan. It has helped us save every drop of water and recharge our groundwater table. If it rains heavily once more, we will be completely drought-free," he added.

Top Lashkar commander killed in J&K encounter

Express News Service
Srinagar, September 30

THE LAST surviving member of the four-member group of Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorists that carried out some of the most sensational terror attacks in recent years in J&K, Hashim Musa, was killed in an overnight encounter in the Khansahib area of central Kashmir's Budgam, the Indian Army said on Wednesday.

Officials said LeT's commander Musa, also known as Asif Fauji, was killed in a joint operation built on intelligence inputs in an area under the Khansahib police station. Security forces were pursuing Musa for some time and "recently a specific all-stakeholder plan for his neutralisation was put in place after technical and human intelligence about his movement and presence were received", officials said.

"Further to the ongoing operation, during the search early morning in General Area Palmaidan, the body of Pak-based Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorist, identified as Mohammad Asif alias Hashim Moosa was recovered along with war-like stores," Army's 15 Corps said in a statement on Wednesday.

Officials also stated that with Musa's death, "the entire group of four senior LeT commanders operating in the UT since 2022, and responsible for several attacks, stand

neutralised".

Musa was linked to several terror attacks, including Halan (August 2023), Dehra Ki Gali (December 2023), Kandi (May 2023), Shahsitar (May 2024), Shiv Khori (June 2024), Gagangir (Oct 2024), Bootapathri (Oct 2024), and the Baisaran attack in April 2025, an official note from the Ministry of Home Affairs stated.

Three other members of the group were killed by security forces over the years — Junaid Bhat (December 2024, Operation Dachigam); Suleiman (July 2025, Operation Mahadev); and Yasir (September 2026, Operation Asdhar).

Musa is believed to have infiltrated the valley in 2022. He came into prominence after his photos surfaced in the forensic analysis of the phone recovered in Operation Dachigam in July 2025. "In the photograph, he was accompanied by foreign terrorist Suleiman Shah, local theorist Junaid Ramzan Bhat, and another foreign terrorist Yasir," a senior security official told *The Indian Express*.

According to officials, the group comprising Musa, Junaid, Yasir and Suleiman Shah carried out the Halan attack (Kulgam) on August 4, 2023, in which four Army personnel were killed.

On December 21, 2023, the group attacked Army vehicles in Poonch, in which five Army jawans lost their lives.

Bihar clears Rs 62.5 cr for water cannons, anti-riot vehicles

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 30

IN A year marked by student protests and demonstrations, the Bihar Cabinet on Wednesday approved Rs 62.52 crore for 30 water cannons and 86 anti-riot Vajra vehicles for law-and-order duties.

At a meeting on Wednesday, the Cabinet gave administrative approval for 30 water cannons of Rs 88 lakh each, costing Rs 26.40 crore, and 86 new Vajra vehicles at Rs 42 lakh each, costing Rs 36.12 crore. The purchases are intended for crowd control during agitations, festivals, fairs and election rallies.

The Home Department, which is under Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary, said the vehicles would also be used during VIP and VVIP visits and movements, and to deal with riots, land disputes, road accidents on national highways, communal sensitivities and other emergency situations.

The decision comes weeks after the Bihar Police announced the formation of District Anti-Riot Forces (DARF),

with dedicated units at the district and sub-divisional levels to respond to violent protests, communal tension, road blockades and attacks on government property. It also comes after a series of protests in Bihar, from NEET to the Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE-4), and clashes this week following protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

The Cabinet approved 30 agenda items, including the draft Bihar Green Hydrogen Policy, 2026; a revised Rs 351.85-crore cost for grid electrification of 177 habitations covering 21,644 households in Kaimur and Rohtas under the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme; second-stage financial approval for a proposed Taj City Centre hotel in Patna; and creation of 34 posts each for two proposed universities.

In July, protests over an alleged NEET-UG paper leak left 13 civilians and 91 police personnel injured. Among those wounded were three people who suffered bullet injuries in Siwan, including a 17-year-old minor.

NARCOTICS WORTH RS 3,000 CRORE

500 kg drugs seized from boat near Lakshadweep; 5 Pak nationals held

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, September 30

A JOINT operation between the Gujarat Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) and the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) has led to a massive drug bust. About 526 kg of narcotics, including heroin and methamphetamine, worth Rs 3,000 crore, have been seized from a dhow crewed by five Pakistani nationals. The seizure took place west of the Lakshadweep Islands on Sunday.

The Coast Guard said in a statement on Wednesday, "Executing precise sea-air surveillance based on actionable intelligence, Bharatiya Tatrakshak (ICG) assets maintained unyielding tracking before initiating hot pursuit, neutralizing the target, and boarding a suspicious Iranian dhow on September 25. "The high-seas operation resulted in the seizure of approximately 526 kilograms of high-grade contraband — comprising heroin and methamphetamine — valued at over Rs 3,000 crore in international markets, alongside the swift apprehension of five Pakistani nationals operating the vessel," the statement said. The dhow, its crew, and the seized



A joint operation by the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) and Gujarat Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) has led to the seizure. PTI

contraband were sent to Mumbai with an armed escort for joint interrogation and multi-agency legal proceedings.

Intelligence and the chase The intelligence leading to the seizure was gathered by the Gujarat ATS earlier this month. On September 10, Inspector JM Patel received information that a Nigerian national held a meeting in Ahmedabad through an intermediary. During the meeting, an order was reportedly placed for approximately 500 kg of methamphetamine and heroin, which was to be transported by an Iranian dhow named "Azad".

The consignment was to be delivered to a Tamil Nadu-based boat in Indian waters in the Mumbai-Kochi-Lakshadweep region, the ATS said.

The ATS statement said, "An advance payment towards the value of the consignment had already been sent through the hawala channel, while the remaining amount was to be transferred through hawala following delivery of the drugs. As the consignment was of a large quantity, a conspiracy had been planned to unload it from the boat along the Tamil Nadu coastline and subsequently transport it in smaller quantities through other

vehicles for delivery to a Nigerian national in Punjab."

It added, "A wanted accused in India and a drug smuggler named Haji Salim, through their associates, had planned to send the consignment aboard the Iranian boat Azad within approximately 15 to 20 days. The boat's Tandel (boatswain) was reportedly to use a Starlink device."

The Gujarat ATS then contacted the Indian Coast Guard Headquarters in Delhi. A team under ATS SP K Siddharth was dispatched to Kochi in Kerala. The Gujarat ATS team met senior Coast Guard officers at Kochi and formed a joint team. The team onboard a Coast Guard vessel carried out surveillance and checks of suspicious boats in the area.

An ATS official told the media on Wednesday, "During this operation, on September 25, the boat identified through the intelligence input was located in Indian territorial waters west of Lakshadweep. The Coast Guard vessel intercepted and stopped the boat. Thereafter, ATS and Coast Guard officers boarded and searched the vessel. The suspicious boat was subsequently brought to Mumbai."

EXPRESS special

'Goldy Brar is watching': At house of FBI most wanted, lips sealed, walls up

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Muktsar (Punjab),
September 30

CONCERTINA WIRE atop tall walls that prevent outsiders peeking in, CCTV cameras keeping a 360-degree watch, and multiple old and torn notices of the NIA — the house that Goldy Brar once lived in stands out from its middle-class colony along Kotkapura Road in Muktsar city.

The neighbourhood, with several retired police officers, is aware, and wary. Police sources said they suspect that Goldy keeps a watch on the house via CCTV's from wherever he is.

Where he is, is a million-dollar question — literally. That's the award the FBI announced this week for information leading to Goldy's arrest, having just added his name to its list of 10 Most Wanted Fugitives. He is identified in the list as Satinderjeet Singh, the formal name that a few here remember Goldy by.

The house with a green canopy strung over the main porch, providing further privacy, is located over 600-odd sqm, with around 150 sqm set aside for trees and plants. Goldy's parents Shamsher Singh and Preetpal Kaur live here. The two were arrested in January 2026 on the charge of helping run Goldy's extortion racket, handling the calls made to businessmen across Punjab, and are now out on bail. Soon after the arrests, an audio clip purportedly from Goldy surfaced, threatening police authorities for their action.

At the residence, Preetpal answers the door, but refuses to



Goldy Brar's parents now live in the house in Muktsar city. EXPRESS

open, or say anything. Apart from police, NIA and FBI, rival gangs are seen as threats to aides of Goldy, including his parents.

Neighbours say the family moved into the house around 2004, shifting here from the police quarters. The peeling remnants of multiple official notices on the wall outside indicate the number of times the NIA has raided the house. Among the few willing to talk about the family is an elderly passerby, who refused to be named. He called Shamsher "respectable", while adding that no one in the neighbourhood remembers seeing Goldy. Police sources say Shamsher was compulsorily retired in 2021 after allegations of helping his son.

Another person out for an evening walk adds, "We don't want a single word attributed to us about Goldy or his family."

Security agencies believe Goldy fled to the US in 2022 after the murder of Punjabi singer Sidhu Moosewala in May that year. In the chargesheet,

the NIA called Goldy the attack's "mastermind".

While the FBI describes him as "operating as a top leader of the Lawrence Bishnoi Organized Crime Group in North America", a purported audio clip of Goldy that surfaced in June 2025 indicated a rift between him and Bishnoi (lodged in Gujarat's Sabarmati Jail). The duo is believed to have fallen out after Bishnoi's brother Anmol was held in the US and extradited, with Bishnoi blaming Goldy and Azerbaijan-based gangster Rohit Godara over handling of the case.

In the June 2025 audio, Goldy also denied allegations of any links with Pakistan's ISI, claiming, "I urge the media and administration to confirm facts before labelling someone a patriot or a traitor. We have never acted against the nation."

The Punjab Police, which designated Goldy a terrorist in January 2024, has welcomed the FBI focus on Goldy, though officials say that he could have been caught a while ago had

Canadian authorities taken its warnings seriously.

A senior state intelligence officer told *The Indian Express* they had been working in tandem with central agencies to nab Goldy for a long time, adding, "We were very disappointed with Canada... Despite an Interpol Red Corner Notice and his placement on Canada's Be On Look Out list, no arrest was made. He was subsequently removed from the list without explanation," the officer said.

The Punjab Police maintain Goldy openly ran his extortion racket from Canada, before shifting base to the US. In December 2022, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann announced at a press conference in Gujarat that US authorities had detained Goldy in California. But this was later found to be incorrect.

As per a dossier prepared by the Punjab Police on Goldy and other such criminals operating abroad, "Over recent years, Indian citizens have been subjected to coordinated and sustained extortion calls carried out by these criminal networks, from Canadian territory." It said the victims are typically small businessmen and entertainers.

"Extortion demands are conveyed through anonymous international calls, VoIP services, and encrypted digital platforms. The threats accompanying these demands include targeted killings, shootings at residences, and intimidation of family members. In several cases, when demands are not met, these threats have been carried out."

INPUTS FROM MAN AMAN SINGH CHINNA, CHANDIGARH

SP's candidate for RS polls: Reliance exec Nathwani Junior

Maulshree Seth
& Parimal A Dabhi
Lucknow, Ahmedabad, Sept 30

VETERAN SAMAJWADI Party (SP) leader Ram Gopal Yadav and Reliance Industries executive Dhanraj Nathwani on Wednesday filed their nomination papers for the October 16 Rajya Sabha elections as the SP's candidates.

While the selection of Ram Gopal Yadav, a seasoned leader and uncle of SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, was expected, Nathwani's name came as a surprise even within the party circles.

Nathwani, 40, is the son of Director, Corporate Affairs for Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), Parimal Nathwani, who was re-elected to the Rajya Sabha from Jharkhand as an NDA-backed Independent in the June 2026 election, securing his fourth consecutive term in the Upper House.

Referring to Dhanraj Nathwani, Akhilesh said he was happy that the SP got an opportunity to send a person from the new generation to the Upper House. "Many parties have a footprint in the corporate world. So the Samajwadi Party has also decided to have a Rajya Sabha MP to connect with the business world," he said.

Nathwani, who thanked the SP chief for his nomination, is a senior corporate executive of the Reliance Industries.

According to his LinkedIn profile, he is currently group president at the Mukesh Ambani-led conglomerate, and also a director of Reliance New Energy Ltd and Reliance Projects & Property Management Services Ltd. He oversees the group's Jamnagar manufacturing division, one of the world's largest integrated refining and petrochemical complexes, and also works with Reliance Jio in Gujarat.

Nathwani also leads the en-



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, Dhanraj Nathwani (right) and Ram Gopal Yadav in Lucknow, Wednesday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

gineering, procurement, and construction vertical and supervises all construction and infrastructure projects in the Reliance ecosystem. He also oversees Reliance Jio Defence System Ltd, which focuses on high-tech manufacturing of advanced military equipment and aerospace propulsion systems. He has been associated with Reliance Industries for about 16 years, and has held various senior positions.

Nathwani has also been associated with sports administration. He is currently the president of the Gujarat Cricket Association, which runs the Narendra Modi stadium, succeeding Union Home Minister Amit Shah. He is also a member of the Gujarat State Wildlife Board.

An official release from the Reliance Group stated, "Nathwani serves as board member of Reliance Corporate IT Park Ltd and drives critical manufacturing and business verticals of RIL, bringing extensive experience across industry, infrastructure and emerging technologies." Nathwani is also vice chairman of Dwarakadhish Temple Administrative Committee in Dwarka and member of Nathdwara Temple Board. He is also a member of Board of Governors of Pandit Deendayal Energy University in Gandhinagar, founded by Reliance Group chairman Mukesh Ambani who also chairs the university.

Ex-IAS officer found dead at Bhopal home, caretaker missing

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, September 30

Retired IAS officer Rakesh Agrawal was found with his throat slit at his residence in Suraj Nagar under Ratibad police station limits early Wednesday morning, with police saying they were investigating the disappearance of a caretaker who had been hired through an agency only days before the murder.

Agrawal's body was found inside his bedroom at his residence behind Panghat Colony in Suraj Nagar. According to ACP Ankita Khatakar, the suspected time of the murder was between 2 am and 3 am.

Agrawal's wife woke up at around 4 am and found the door of her room latched from the outside, police said. She allegedly called another caretaker, Amar, who helped open the door and found Agrawal lying dead inside with his throat allegedly slit.

Police say they are now looking closely at Varun Kumar, a caretaker who had been hired through an agency three days earlier as a 24-hour caretaker-cum-male nurse. Kumar, who is reportedly from Punjab, has been missing since the incident. Police suspect he may have fled and have begun efforts to trace him.

Most of his belongings, save for a pair of clothes, were also missing from the house, officials said. "The caretaker had been hired through an agency three days ago as a 24-hour caretaker-cum-male nurse. He is currently untraceable and we are trying to establish his movements," ACP Khatakar told *The Indian Express*.

Investigators are examining the physical evidence from the house, CCTV footage from the surrounding area and other leads to determine who was inside the premises at the time of the killing.

● GEETA, ARJUN AND SANTOSH ARE AMONG 210 MAOISTS WHO SURRENDERED IN OCTOBER LAST YEAR; HAVING PASSED THE EXAM WITH FLYING COLOURS, THE THREE REVEAL WHAT'S NEXT

Year after giving up arms, 7 former Maoists clear SSC exam – 3 with First Class

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 30

WHILE GROWING up in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli district, Geeta Narote had a keen interest in academics. But due to circumstances, she had to drop out of school in sixth standard. Soon, she got influenced by the Maoist movement, left home, and became "Dr Champa".

When she returned to the mainstream after two decades, she knew exactly what to do: Get back to academics.

At the age of 35, she cleared her SSC exams this month. "I want to become a nurse," she tells *The Indian Express*.

Geeta is among 210 Maoists who gave up arms in October last year. Seven of the former Maoists wrote the SSC exams this year. Of these, three, including Geeta, secured the first

class. All of them wrote the exam in August from Chhattisgarh Open School.

The three former Maoists said they held fire-arms but never fired a bullet.

Geeta said she belonged to Gurekasa village in Dhanora tehsil where she lived with her parents and three sisters. She was a 10-year-old girl when Maoists killed her father. Despite her father's death, Geeta got influenced by the Maoist movement, impressed by their claims of fighting against "patriarchy and forced marriages and talks about women's rights." She joined the movement, which brought her to Abujhmad in Chhattisgarh.

"The Maoists encouraged people to study but there were no means for it. But our suppliers used to bring us medical related books. I also have had a

tablet since 2017 on which I would read," said Geeta.

"I was also trained in treating bullet wounds, stitching, administering injections as well as giving medicines for several health issues... and helped villagers who could not get medical aid," she added.

Geeta was a divisional committee member in the CPI (Maoist) when, led by Takkalapalli Vasudeva Rao, alias Rupesh, known as the Maoists' bombmaker, she surrendered in Jagdalpur.

Geeta got Rs 50,000 from the government. She used some of it to buy books. Geeta said she received some guidance from one "Pathak sir", adding that "most of it was self-study".

"...I will complete my HSC and try to become a nurse. I wish to see my mother and sisters soon," said Geeta, who lives in a



rehabilitation centre in Jagdalpur.

Like Geeta, Arjun Oyam, 32, also wanted to study but as Maoism intensified in his village, the teachers stopped coming to school. Arjun comes from Todka village, which falls in Bijapur district's Gangaloor



(Clockwise from left) Former Maoists Santosh, Arjun and Geeta said they held firearms but never fired a bullet

area, infamous for mass recruitment of Maoists.

"During Salwa Judum, my house was burnt and I lost my books too... I ended up joining the Maoists in 2010 and was sent to Abujhmad," he said.

With the Maoists, Arjun became an Area Committee

Member (ACM). However, he continued to study. "I studied in their political school and became a teacher there for a year, teaching basic Maths, Hindi, Environment etc. I also requested them to send me to a government school but they said I will get arrested... I did not agree with them when they murdered Anganwadi workers and teachers," said Arjun.

With hundreds of Maoists being killed, Arjun thought he would die too. "But our leaders chose to give up weapons. The Bijapur SP, among others, encouraged me to study. The policemen helped me get my birth certificate and caste certificate needed to apply for the exam, and Chaitu dada (a former Maoist) encouraged me to study," he said. Arjun also gave credit to his friends who guided him on WhatsApp. "In the day,

I received training in fish-farming and on working as an electrician and spent my nights studying," he said.

"Now I want to complete my studies and become a teacher in my village," added Arjun.

Asked how his life has changed, Arjun said, "There is a huge difference. First time in my life I got to see a lot in the outside world like social media and education. They (authorities) took us to Raipur and showed us the Vidhan Sabha, Tribal Museum, Jungle Safari and Cricket stadium..."

Like Arjun, Santosh Achla, better known as Sannu, an ACM, was also a teacher in the Maoist party. "My father was a suspected Maoist and died in judicial custody in 2023 after spending years in jail. My mother died this June and I was allowed to attend her final rites," said Sannu,

31. He dropped out of school in the second standard.

"I joined the Maoists in 2008 after getting inspired by Chetna Natya Manch (cultural troupe of the Maoist party) as I also wanted to sing, dance and give speeches. We were told that the Raoghat mining project will take away our village in Gundur, Koyelibeda, in Kanker district (in Chhattisgarh)," he said.

The Maoists taught Sannu to read and write and he became a teacher in 2023, teaching young cadres basic Maths and Hindi. "I had a phone without a SIM card on which I used to read. I used a memory card and a pen drive to get online books," he added.

Sannu said he wants to study further. "I want to start my own business and also do farming on my land. But to do anything, you need to be educated."

A surprise visit, and a Gulf too wide

THE PERCEIVED threat from Iran and a desire for economic cooperation pushed Israel and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to sign the Abraham Accords in September 2020, after which their relationship has been characterised by limited public engagement and discreet diplomacy. That is why Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's recent trip to Abu Dhabi, his second since the start of the West Asia war in late February, is significant. It comes against a backdrop of a changing regional dynamic: Iran's weakening grip on the Strait of Hormuz and signs of a thaw between the UAE and Saudi Arabia — a relationship that had deteriorated in recent months over their economic competition and involvement in civil wars in Yemen and Sudan. The visit also comes amid a major political row in Israel ahead of the October election over reports that UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan had warned Netanyahu of an impending Hamas attack just days before October 7, 2023 — a claim the Israeli PM has denied.

Taken together, these developments point to countries in the region increasingly carving out their own paths as the US and Iran negotiate or escalate. Iran's retaliation — pummelling Gulf countries with drones and missiles, with the UAE hit the hardest — has underscored the limits of relying solely on the American security umbrella. But the story is far from over. A sustained rise in crude exports from West Asia in September also means that Tehran could look for other ways to maintain its leverage over Washington. Indeed, Speaker of Iran's Parliament Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf said this week: "Where we do not sell oil, no one will sell oil." For the UAE, which has acquired air-defence systems and counter-drone capabilities from Israel that its Arab allies did not provide, the lesson is that it needs partners capable of providing hard security. For Israel, a cooperative Arab partner across the Persian Gulf offers both strategic depth and diplomatic value, strengthening the broader architecture of the Abraham Accords at a time when its war on Gaza has been globally condemned.

The emerging alignment, however, carries a contradiction of its own. Israel may offer the UAE weapons, but that does not resolve the conflicts that continue to destabilise the region, many a result of Israel's own military adventurism, as in Lebanon and Syria. Nor can the Abraham Accords indefinitely remain insulated from the Palestinian question; Israel's war in Gaza and settlement expansionism in the West Bank continue to shape Arab public opinion. The UAE and Israel may, therefore, have strong reasons to deepen their relationship. But without a political framework that addresses regional tensions in the long run, the stability and security they seek will remain elusive.

A library without a home speaks of a larger absence

THE CENTRAL Secretariat Library (CSL) predates the republic. Established in 1891 as the Imperial Secretariat Library in Calcutta, it moved with the capital to Delhi and was renamed after Independence. Its collection runs to over 8.5 lakh books and documents, including material dating back to 1702. It is, in other words, a working archive of the Indian state, a repository of institutional memory. Yet, as a report in this newspaper has shown, with Shastri Bhawan, its home since 1969, set to make way for the Central Vista redevelopment, the library is yet to find a new space. A government that is building a new administrative centre is also making a statement about what belongs at the centre of public life. That a project of such scale and ambition should leave an institution of archival importance without a secure home is a troubling statement of priorities.

As a long-term project involving some of the country's most storied buildings, relocation could not have been an unforeseen complication. As early as 2023, the Culture Ministry had sought commensurate space in the new Common Central Secretariat that is at the heart of the Central Vista redevelopment project. Public discourse and expert opinion around the demolition of the National Archives Annexe and the relocation of the National Museum's collections to the Yuge Yugeen Bharat Museum, coming up in the North and South Block buildings, have underscored why proper inventories and cataloguing, conservation facilities, climate-controlled storage for fragile and rare material, digitisation, trained staff and access are crucial to the preservation and upkeep of objects of national inheritance. Such provisions should, in fact, have been integral to the project from the outset.

There is also a cautionary precedence in its own history that shows that when institutions are displaced without a durable plan, temporary arrangements can lead to permanent absences. CSL's regional languages section, the Tulsi Sadan Library, was temporarily shut for the construction of the Mandi House Metro station in 2011, its contents housed in the National School of Drama premises. The library is shut to this day. The government must ensure that a similar fate does not befall the CSL.

At Nagoya, promises kept, a winning arc

SINCE 2003, India has quietly gone about honing skills in Compound Archery, an event ignored by most sports powerhouses because it was not on the Olympics programme. Recurve archery Olympian Sanjeeva Kumar Singh was smitten by the un-complex bow, which is easier on the shoulders and sighting, and brought it to India 23 years ago. On a bright Nagoya morning, archers Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Rajesh Jadhav beat Koreans Choi Eun-gyu and Jung Yoon-park to clinch a gold medal in the mixed team event, giving India its first Los Angeles Olympic quota from the Asian Games. It was a vindication of India's persistence in sticking to a non-Olympic event, and training at elite levels.

The next two years will see several domestic talents, including multiple world champion Jyothi Surekha Vennam and last edition winner Aditi Swami, besides players from Punjab, Maharashtra and Telangana, readying to clear the trials that will send India to LA 2028. India boasts tremendous young talent in the men's team, following in the footsteps of pioneer Abhishek Verma. But for now, the day belonged to Chikitha and Sahil.

Chikitha watched her parents sell off their rice harvester, and was cheated out of a good quality bow by a fraud of Rs 1.5 lakh. But the family kept at it. A karate black belt, she was built to be tough. Sahil watched his father suffer a job loss during Covid and continued shooting with bent arrows, till his mother sold off her jewellery to refurbish his equipment. The compound bow might be simple in essence — it has sights and a vibration regulator so no recoil-equivalent — but stories of Indian practitioners are about beating difficult odds, and winning.

The Editorial Page

ECI and Court make it harder, not easier, to trust in independent institutions

RARELY IN the annals of Indian constitutional history have two key institutions, the Supreme Court of India and the Election Commission, acted in tandem with such shameless disregard for the constitutional purpose of their office, inflicting administrative cruelty on citizens and disenfranchising them. The SIR enterprise, which in principle may be justified, was so badly conceived and executed that it has left citizens reeling. But worse still, at almost every opportunity to set things right, these institutions have responded mendaciously, failing to address any of the core concerns their critics have raised about the fairness and ease of the SIR process. Ritika Chopra and Damini Nath's reporting in this paper highlighted important questions about the functioning of the Commission. But they were not merely procedural questions. They raised serious substantive questions. The opaque process, including the software protocols, was shifting the burden of proof onto citizens. These days, nothing is shocking. But still, the idea that the Election Commission files appeals en masse against 16 lakh voters in West Bengal who had been found eligible for inclusion is stunning indeed.

The SIR mess is the joint effect of the Supreme Court and ECI. The Election Commission has the power to ensure the integrity of voting lists. The independence of the Commission requires that the removal of the Commissioners be by impeachment. The only practical mechanism of accountability was therefore the Supreme Court. It should have, without infringing on the Commission's powers, insisted on the strongest possible procedural and substantive safe-

guards against the misuse of that power. But the net effect of Court intervention was to legitimise the whole exercise, without any real safeguards. Worse still, the Court, via Justice Joymalya Bagchi, gave *ad hominem* remarks suggesting those who were excluded could simply vote in the next election. The same sentiment is again repeated by the Chief Justice in his refusal to expedite the hearing of a petition before the by-election in Rejinagar and Nandigram, regarding the pending appeals in West Bengal. They sent a powerful signal that voting rights can be treated casually. In effect, the Lordships and the Election Commission were the guarantors of this right, according to procedures they could make up in whichever way they liked. More than the technical details of the SIR saga, it is this culture of impunity that has become institutionalised.

The lack of self-awareness of these constitutional bodies is staggering. You would have imagined that a Chief Justice, first criticised and socially sanctioned over his remarks (allegedly misunderstood) about "cockroaches", would be a little more self-aware of what it means to treat citizens as free and equal? It is one thing for the government to adopt a governing style where it regards reasonable demands for accountability as an affront to its authority. The government at least will still, we hope, face a contested election. But for constitutional functionaries, whose mandate is to protect citizens from arbitrary power and disenfranchisement, to act in this manner systematically smacks of incredibly bad judgment. What do



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

But think of the implications of this dynamic. It is a way of saying that the rot in the system does not begin and end in politics; it saturates a whole elite and perhaps even a generation of voters and public servants

we call the resultant constitutional order? The Shameless Constitution? The Constitution of Impunity? This is a condition which the historians of Rome knew well: Where despotic and arbitrary power can inhabit important constitutional offices without formally abolishing them.

There is a distressing institutional dynamic at work here. There are legitimate questions to be asked about what the government knew, and what it thought of the legality of the goings-on in the Election Commission. But the truth is, when the Supreme Court of India and the Election Commission conduct themselves with such a lack of constitutional self-awareness, it is hard to focus the blame on the government. One might say that the actions of the Election Commission are at the behest of the government. But the independence of the Court and Election Commission has now become a shield for the government as well. So we are in a curious situation: For once, the Opposition's ire is directed at constitutional authorities. Ironically, the government gets off lightly.

But think of the implications of this dynamic. It is a way of saying that the rot in the system does not begin and end in politics; it saturates a whole elite and perhaps even a generation of voters and public servants. The Supreme Court has once again belatedly raised the question about the appointment procedure for the Election Commission; the executive has inordinate power over the selection process. But the Supreme Court's own conduct is living proof that the formal appointment process greatly underdetermines the

quality of people being appointed, or their conduct in high office. Procedure is no substitute for virtue, nor can it manufacture it.

The BJP's long-term political strategy has been to cultivate a nihilism about institutions: It thrives on the scepticism about constitutional functionaries. The Election Commission and the Supreme Court have reinforced this script, making it harder to believe in independent institutions. It will take a drastic effort to reverse that tide. The Election Commission's press notes in response to queries raised about its conduct are a partial response to public criticism: Part admission of procedural impropriety, and partly a commitment to help voters who are facing queries. But while the media and Opposition are mobilised, there is still a curious absence: The mobilisation of the disenfranchised voter. This may be partly because the process is still not complete; the legal measures are still underway. But most voters whose political rights have been snatched away remain outside the zone of visibility. Converting that statistic into political agency has not been easy, and blunts the power of the anger at the process.

The resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner might send one signal of accountability. The Court belatedly restoring integrity to the SIR process might send another. But something important has already been destroyed: The citizen's faith that constitutional institutions, and a few old men, are worth believing in.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

In aftermath of BRICS, going back to Bandung



M A BABY

IN APRIL 1955, leaders of 29 newly independent Asian and African countries gathered at Bandung in Indonesia. Most of their nations had been colonies a decade earlier. They agreed on 10 principles — most importantly, sovereignty, non-interference, refusal to join great-power military blocs and support for peoples still under colonial rule. Six years later, at Belgrade, that spirit became an institution — the Non-Aligned Movement.

NAM was never merely about staying neutral; it was a platform for the decolonisation of the world. It stood with Algeria and Vietnam, with the struggle against apartheid in South Africa, with the peoples of Palestine. In the 1970s, it carried the demand for a New International Economic Order into the UN — fair prices for what poor countries produced, access to technology, and a voice in institutions designed without them.

India was NAM's founder and, for decades, its moral centre. After the Soviet Union collapsed, the world became unipolar, and NAM lost its compass. Many of its members, including India, drifted towards Washington. NAM survives in name; its purpose has been abandoned.

Into this vacuum has come BRICS. Formed in 2009, it now represents more than half of humanity. The 18th Summit in New Delhi earlier this month produced a 140-point declaration that reads, in places, like an echo of Bandung — reform of the Security Council, the IMF, the World Bank and the WTO; condemnation of unilateral sanctions; an end to the blockade of Cuba; a Palestinian state on the 1967 borders with East Jerusalem as its capital; climate finance for countries that did not cause the climate crisis.

But let's be honest, BRICS is not the heir to NAM's anti-colonial mission. Its members have very different systems and interests, and several are close partners of the US. That is why the declaration condemns "unilateral coercive measures" without naming who imposes them, and calls for "maximum restraint" in West Asia without naming the aggressor. These silences are the price of consensus. BRICS seeks a world with more than one centre of power. It does not seek to end domination

itself. It wants to reform the dollar-centred order and says nothing about the debt that consumes the budgets of poor nations.

This limited project matters, and the Global South has every reason to strengthen it. When tariffs are used as a weapon and sanctions on one country disrupt the trade of many, alternatives count. Trade settled in national currencies, development finance without strings, a reserve arrangement outside the IMF — these give governments room to breathe. The more members BRICS has and the stronger its institutions, the harder it becomes for any single power to dictate terms to everyone else.

Which brings us to India, which has now hosted the BRICS summit while behaving as a junior partner of the US. It has deepened military and trade arrangements with Washington aimed at containing China. It maintains a strategic embrace of Israel while signing a declaration on Palestinian statehood. It has been silent on American actions against Iran, Venezuela and Cuba, and has refused to unambiguously condemn the destruction of Gaza.

Surveys across West Asia have consistently ranked Israel and the US as the greatest threats to the region's security. New Delhi has placed itself on the wrong side of the very region it wants to court. And before the summit, the government hid the capital's slums behind screens. One cannot lead the Global South while dancing to Washington's tune and hiding one's own poor.

India has a choice. It can be one more country jostling for favours in Washington, or it can reclaim the role it once played — the moral voice of nations that were told their place in the world and refused to accept it. That means a foreign policy free of American pressure, solidarity with Palestine, opposition to sanctions, insistence that the rich countries pay their climate debt, and a push to make BRICS more than a lobby for a better seat at the table.

Bandung was never about balancing between great powers. It was about asserting the right of peoples to decide their own destinies. That is anti-imperialism in plain words, and it remains the way forward.

The writer is general secretary, CPI(M)

When a woman walks alone at night



RISHIKA SINGH

A YOUNG woman in Delhi today and a celebrated mid-20th century American author might not seem to have much in common. But reading reports about protests over the alleged gangrape of a minor in a Delhi park at night reminded me of Sylvia Plath's words, written almost 75 years ago.

She wrote at 18, "Being born a woman is my awful tragedy... my consuming desire to mingle with road crews, sailors and soldiers, bar room regulars — to be part of a scene, anonymous, listening, recording — all is spoiled by the fact that I am a girl, a female always in danger of assault and battery... Yet, God, I want to talk to everybody I can as deeply as I can. I want to be able to sleep in an open field, to travel west, to walk freely at night..."

One news report described a protest poster that read, "It's not my fault I crave the night air, it's your fault you crave taking it away from me." When I first heard about the case, I assumed it referred to a similar incident a decade ago, when I had just become a student at Delhi University. When such events repeat themselves, it becomes tempting to curse womanhood itself, as Plath did.

That, however, would mean we as women should agree to let go of something innate not only to humans but perhaps all living beings — a sense of curiosity about the world. When a young woman expresses the desire to venture out, especially at night, patriarchal societies raise suspicion about what she might do with that freedom. Narrow standards of social acceptance make it preferable to limit her movement. Never mind that women are known to face violence without leaving their homes and at the hands of familiar people, or that no one has ever suggested limiting the movement of an entire class of men to ensure safety.

Plath's words lay bare this injustice. What about the right to go here and there, to experience and learn what the world actually is? It can mean smelling the lingering scent of flowers at night in a park, trying a famous chaat shop in another part of the city, striking up a conversation at a public spot, or even finding out one doesn't enjoy those things. Is experiencing such simple pleasures and disappointments not enough justification to build institutions that can ensure women's safety? And what does this social messaging mean for today's women, raised to become educated, financially independent, and consider themselves as capable as men? There is a double standard, where they are told to harbour the same ambition and undertake the same responsibilities while remaining in the supposedly protective space of home and daylight hours, unequipped to participate in the world in its totality.

Movements such as "Take Back the Night" have tried to mobilise women to hold marches and go out in groups at midnight to make the radical act of a woman venturing out in the dark less so. Of course, these acts must be accompanied by functioning law-and-order systems to become routine and, hopefully, unremarkable. But as the protestors of Delhi show, maybe one answer to the problem Plath posed is a critical mass of women going out to see the world, not circumscribed by their femininity, but asserting with full force that they deserve to be out and about as much.

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40 YEARS AGO

October 1, 1986



First-ever Asiad gold for Usha

ECSTASY AND AGONY. That was India's lot on the second day of the track and field championships of the 10th Asian Games in the Olympic stadium in Seoul. The peerless P T Usha stormed to her first-ever Asiad gold in the women's 400m hurdles in record-breaking time. She was just as convincing in the 200m semifinals and it doesn't look as though the film star, model and crack sprinter of the Philippines, Lydia de Vega, can succeed in her pursuit of a phenomenal haul of six gold medals.

Spurious liquor kills 4 in Delhi

A HUSBAND and wife and two others died of

liquor poisoning in the capital over the past 24 hours, the police said. Shankar (35) and his wife Champa (28) died in J P Hospital after they had consumed spirit that had apparently been adulterated, the police said. Both were from Gujarat and had been staying in Company Bagh, selling utensils, the police said.

Gorbachev and Reagan to meet

THE SOVIET leader, Mikhail Gorbachev and the US President, Ronald Reagan, are to meet in Iceland for a two-day summit on October 11 and 12, according to a surprise announcement from the governments. The two leaders, who met for the first time in Geneva in November last year,

will travel to Reykjavik, the capital of Iceland, for their second summit. Gorbachev is expected to visit the United States later this year. Reagan made the announcement at a brief unscheduled meeting with the press at the White House. The Soviet Foreign Minister, Eduard Shevardnadze, followed suit at a news conference in New York.

Kashmir in the UNGA

AFTER A gap of four years, India and Pakistan were involved in an exchange over Kashmir in the UN General Assembly after the Pakistani Foreign Minister, Sahabzada Yaqub Khan, raised the matter in the 159-member forum.



Pause SIR and conduct an audit of voter deletions



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE GROWING controversy surrounding Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar highlights an interplay of public protest, parliamentary conflict, coalition dynamics, legal challenges, and institutional credibility. At the centre of the dispute is an unprecedented buildup of pressure from multiple sectors of Indian society and politics, raising critical issues about how a constitutional authority can navigate public scrutiny. It also raises a more fundamental question: Whether the existing legal framework and political structure allow for accountability or create an insurmountable barrier to removal.

Public dissatisfaction has manifested on the ground through organised protests led by activists, student groups, and major parties, most notably and energetically, the Congress party. These movements seek to mobilise public opinion across key urban centres. Congress has conducted some 930 protest agitations against the CEC this week, with more to come. Compounding this grassroots momentum is a concerted push at the political level by the Opposition, whose leaders have called not only for the CEC's immediate resignation but also for criminal proceedings to be instituted over allegations of bias favouring the ruling party.

In Parliament, opposition lawmakers will attempt to leverage legislative mechanisms to challenge the CEC's standing. Having previously submitted notices seeking his removal on grounds of partiality, which were declined by the presiding officers of both houses, Congress legislators, in partnership with INDIA bloc allies, are preparing fresh notices of impeachment. However, the constitutional threshold for removing a CEC is exceptionally high, deliberately modelled on the impeachment procedure reserved for a Supreme Court judge. Under Section 11 of the 2023 Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, a commissioner may resign by writing to the Presi-



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

dent, but dismissal requires the admission of a petition by parliamentary leadership, followed by a majority vote in both houses, making involuntary removal nearly impossible without government backing.

This is further complicated by the political realities of the current government, which operates as a coalition rather than a single-party majority. Key coalition allies within the ruling alliance have voiced concerns, demanding transparency and formal explanations regarding internal decisions and procedures of the Election Commission of India (ECI). It is true that the BJP's allies have demonstrated remarkable compliance during the first two years of the current NDA government, and are usually only too happy to acquiesce in the government's stand on any issue. But because the governing coalition relies on these partners to maintain its majority, public questioning from allies can strip away much of the administrative insulation the executive might otherwise offer to a constitutional appointee like the CEC. If an influential BJP leader like former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan can be deemed dispensable, a retired bureaucrat like Gyanesh Kumar can be dropped all the more easily if the liabilities around him make him too hot to handle.

Concurrently, the conflict has reached the judiciary through two separate lines of challenge before

the Supreme Court. The first directly challenges specific administrative and technological decisions undertaken by the CEC, alleging that key policies and software modifications were implemented unilaterally without a unanimous consensus of the three-member ECI. The second petition targets the constitutionality of the 2023 selection process itself, which replaced the CJI on the selection panel with a Union cabinet minister, thereby shifting the panel's balance to an executive-dominated two-to-one majority. Both can open a Pandora's Box of controversies surrounding the ECI.

Adding to the legal complexity is Section 16 of the 2023 legislation, which grants serving and former election commissioners immunity from civil or criminal proceedings for actions carried out in the discharge of their official duties. While this provision effectively shields the CEC from individual prosecution under current law, the provision itself remains subject to judicial review. If the SC finds that such blanket immunity is unconstitutional, Gyanesh Kumar is liable not only to being dismissed but to criminal prosecution for some of his manifestly *mala fide* decisions and actions.

But there remains the political problem: The BJP's obdurate determination to cling to its positions, however unreasonable or unpopular, on the basis of a stubborn conviction that it has greater staying

power than the fickle winds of public opinion. During an earlier controversy when the Opposition unitedly demanded the resignation of a cabinet minister, a BJP minister blithely told a press conference, "We are the NDA, not the UPA. We don't give in." The belligerent defence of the CEC and the SIR by BJP spokespeople, CMs and functionaries in recent days suggests that such an attitude is likely to be the BJP's preferred path of resistance, rather than defusing the controversy by tossing an individual overboard. The BJP's assertion seeks to explicitly contrast itself with what it portrays as Congress's "weakness" or readiness to fold under media or Opposition pressure. By refusing to yield, the ruling dispensation signals that parliamentary disruptions, protests, and press conferences will not dictate executive decisions or resignations. There is no doubt that the CEC's resignation would be claimed as a major victory by the Opposition, casting doubt over past electoral outcomes and creating significant uncertainty ahead of upcoming state elections. The BJP's obduracy reassures party cadres and cabinet members that the central leadership will back them against external attacks rather than sacrificing them for short-term news cycles.

Yet the continued tenure of Gyanesh Kumar as CEC threatens to undermine the perceived neutrality of the ECI, without which the credibility of our electoral system stands diminished. Just a few years ago, the ECI was a model for the world, sought after by the UN and requested to advise a variety of developing countries and emerging democracies on how to construct their electoral systems and conduct effective elections. Today, the shambolic performance of an electoral authority that has deleted a global record 130 million voters from the rolls, and reduced one election booth to just one voter, has reduced India's reputation as the world's largest and most respected democracy to a farce.

With elections approaching, the authorities must support a pause in the disputed SIR, demand disclosure of the ECI's decision-making record, and back an independent audit of deletions and software changes. Until these concerns are credibly addressed, every successive election will risk deepening the very crisis of democracy it is meant to resolve.

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram

When Congress loses an election, it blames the democratic system



GURU PRAKASH

I REMEMBER the morning after the Bankipur by-poll results. As a voter and as a political worker, I was disappointed. Bankipur was a seat our party had held for years, and the result went decisively against us. Yet, what struck me in the days that followed was our response. I did not hear our party blame the Election Commission of India (ECI), the voters' list or electronic voting machines. The voters had spoken. Democracy does not promise every political worker the result he wants; it promises a process through which the voter gets to decide.

That experience has stayed with me as I hear Congress increasingly question the ECI. A mature democracy must distinguish between electoral disappointment and institutional illegitimacy. The first is a consequence of political competition. The second is a grave constitutional allegation and must be supported by evidence. Congress's present concern about the ECI's independence also sits uneasily with its own history.

The Justice J C Shah Commission, which examined excesses during the Emergency, made severe findings concerning Navin Chawla's conduct as a senior Delhi administrator. Yet Chawla was subsequently appointed Election Commissioner in 2005 under the Congress-led UPA government and became Chief Election Commissioner in 2009.

The post-retirement trajectories of former election commissioners offer another reason for institutional consistency. M S Gill, who served as CEC from 1996 to 2001, subsequently entered Parliament on a Congress ticket and served as a Union minister. TN Seshan, whose tenure transformed the public understanding of the ECI's powers, later contested a Lok Sabha election as a Congress candidate. None of this proves misconduct while they were in office. But neither can such history be erased when political parties debate the institutional independence of the ECI.

The deeper lesson comes from the Emergency. When the Allahabad High Court set aside Indira Gandhi's election, the political response was not simply to return to the electorate. The Emergency followed; political opponents were imprisoned, civil liberties curtailed, and the normal democratic process disrupted. A party that has been central to that history carries a special responsibility when it questions the institutions through which citizens periodically exercise their sovereign choice.

This is not an argument that the ECI is beyond criticism. Far from it. Voter-list revisions, election scheduling, enforcement of the Model Code and administrative decisions should always remain open to scrutiny. The Constitution provides mechanisms for precisely that scrutiny: Representations before the Commission, judicial review and statutory remedies.

The Supreme Court's jurisprudence recognises the extraordinary constitutional responsibility entrusted to the ECI. The recent controversy over Bihar's Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls offers an important contemporary example. In its May 2026 judgment, the Supreme Court upheld the legal basis of the SIR and recognised the constitutional and statutory powers available to the ECI in relation to electoral rolls. Justice Surya Kant's observations during the proceedings also underscored the importance of correcting discrepancies in electoral rolls.

There is also an international dimension that deserves recognition. India's Election Commission is not an isolated domestic bureaucracy. It is part of a global community of election-management bodies. The ECI is a founding member and former chair of the Association of World Election Bodies and participates in international electoral institutions and networks. Its India International Institute of Democracy and Election Management has trained election officials from scores of countries, while international delegations have participated in India's election-observation and Election Visitors' programmes. International engagement is not a certificate of infallibility. But it demonstrates that India's electoral administration has developed substantial institutional capacity.

The present legal framework for the appointment of Election Commissioners provides a formal role for the Leader of the Opposition in the selection process. This followed the Supreme Court's intervention in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* and Parliament's subsequent enactment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023. The precise architecture of the law can and should be debated, and aspects of it remain subject to judicial scrutiny. But the larger principle is important: The legitimacy of constitutional institutions is strengthened when the political Opposition has a recognised place in their architecture. That is an invitation to Congress, not an accusation against it. Participate in strengthening the institution. Challenge decisions where there is evidence. Take legitimate grievances to the Commission and the courts. But do not turn every electoral disagreement into a referendum on the legitimacy of the democratic process itself.

My party has lost elections. Some defeats have been painful. Bankipur was one of them. But the democratic response to defeat cannot always be to search for an institution to blame. Sometimes the answer is simpler and more demanding: Perhaps the voter wanted something else. I learned that lesson in Bankipur. Perhaps our political discourse needs to learn it again.

The writer is national spokesperson, BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Basic freedoms

WOMEN'S SAFETY is one of the biggest issues in the country today ("We need to manage public spaces, not women", *IE*, September 30). According to NCRB data, a woman is raped roughly every 18 minutes. This situation is truly disheartening. The steps taken to combat the problem curtail women's freedom even more. The victims are being taught to stay at home. The real focus should be on educating sons on how to respect women.

Toshani Saha, Bengaluru

Anti-pollution plan

DELHI'S PROACTIVE winter anti-pollution plan marks a welcome shift from emergency panic to early preparedness, yet seasonal curbs and temporary bans remain insufficient for the Capital's deep-rooted crisis ("Delhi's winter pollution plan must go beyond bans and curbs", *IE*, September 30). With stubble burning overlapping with Diwali and adverse weather patterns expected, tackling this challenge requires transcending municipal boundaries for seamless regional coordination across neighbouring states. Ultimately, true clean air will only be achieved by moving beyond punitive restrictions to establish a year-round governance framework that prioritises robust public transport, sustainable incentives, and enduring administrative accountability.

Ananthapadmanabhan, Bengaluru

Narrow the gap

THE APPARENT deadlock comes as there is a push-and-pull between Iran and the US over the state of shipping via Hormuz ("US, Iran and the missing endgame", *IE*, September 30). President Donald Trump declined a ceasefire proposal from Tehran because he expects to restart U.S. attacks after the midterms. The key question now is whether Qatari mediation can narrow the gap.

SS Paul, Nadia



BALAKRISHNAN MAHADEVAN

INDIA HAS done something remarkable with UPI. We did not merely digitise an existing payment instrument. We created an open, interoperable, account-to-account payment infrastructure at population scale. But the more fundamental idea was strategic: To build a home-grown payment rail that would reduce our dependence on international card schemes and their economics.

India could have simply accepted the existing card architecture and its pricing model. Instead, we built our own. An editorial in this paper (A small fee, a stronger UPI', *IE*, September 17) has welcomed the decision to levy a fee. But I would ask a simple question: If India could innovate so dramatically on payment technology, why should we not innovate on pricing too?

UPI is fundamentally a credit-transfer system. The payer initiates a transfer from their bank account to the beneficiary's account. RTGS, NEFT and IMPS follow the same basic principle. Cards are economically different. A card transaction is essentially a pull transaction: The merchant initiates it and the customer's account or credit facility is debited based on authorisation.

The question is not whether UPI should have a sustainable economic model. It should. The question is whether a payment rail deliberately designed as an alternative to card networks should automatically adopt a percentage-based pricing logic developed

We innovated with UPI. Why not with merchant fee?

for card networks. We engineered our way out of dependence on the old payment rails. Can we also price our own rail on our own terms?

India's credit-transfer systems have traditionally used simple, fixed or slab-based pricing, with maximum charges, rather than percentage-of-value pricing. NEFT historically had maximum charges of Rs 5 for transfers up to Rs 1 lakh and Rs 25 above Rs 1 lakh. RTGS charges were capped at Rs 25 for Rs 2-5 lakh and Rs 50 above Rs 5 lakh. And importantly, IMPS — itself an NPCI-developed, real-time credit-transfer product — followed the same broad philosophy. In 2016, the government directed public-sector banks that maximum charges for IMPS transactions above Rs 1,000 should not exceed the corresponding NEFT charges.

When India created its real-time credit-transfer system, it did not build a percentage-of-value pricing model. It used simple, low, slab-based pricing with maximum charges. So why should UPI now require 0.40 per cent MDR, with a maximum of Rs 300?

UPI operates at an extraordinary scale. An IIM Bangalore analysis of NPCI's 2024-25 financials calculated total NPCI expenses of Rs 2,270 crore against 230.2 billion transactions — approximately 9.8 paise per transaction across NPCI's payment systems. On the narrower operational-cost basis we have been examining, excluding marketing, the figure is around 5 paise per transaction. The

wider ecosystem obviously has other costs — banks, merchant acquirers, fraud management, security and customer support. But the question remains: How much revenue is genuinely required for cost recovery and sustainability? NPCI also demonstrates what scale and frugality can achieve. There is perhaps something for the wider ecosystem to learn from that.

UPI and India's wider Digital Public Infrastructure were not created merely to maximise transactions or create revenue pools. They were built to expand economic participation. A small merchant accepting Rs 50, a migrant transferring money instantly, or a citizen accessing a digital public service represent participation in the formal economy. Banks and technology firms need sustainable economics. The answer is not to reject markets or profit. But sustainability should not make us lose sight of the purpose for which this infrastructure was created.

Markets can create wealth. Businesses can make profits. Technology can create efficiency. But economic efficiency must ultimately ensure well-being. That is why we built UPI as DPI. Perhaps the next innovation in UPI should therefore be as bold as the first: Not simply how we move money, but how we price the infrastructure that moves it.

The writer is former chief operating officer, NPCI and formerly with the World Bank — Payment Systems Development Group

Politician meets protestor: An uncivil story

basic norms in public by an elected official is not the appropriate moment to dwell on the wider problem of escalating rage and frustration. However, there is a direct link between abuse of power by its formal custodians and a public mood that validates citizens venting their anger. The video of the incident shows people plucking pieces of the road surface with their bare hands. Someone who has long suffered badly made, unsafe roads might already be on edge. To then watch the minister responsible for that road slapping a protesting citizen can look like a sufficient provocation for blinding rage.

Assume that enough people will pause to acknowledge that acting out of blinding rage will only make things worse. The more insidious problem now is that once the provocation is felt to be valid, some form of retali-

ation is seen as automatically justified. At the next level are those who argue that not expressing your anger is cowardice. It is difficult to know the extent to which elementary principles of civil behaviour have been abandoned in Indian society as a whole. Regardless of the scale, the core problem is now large and threatens the stability of everyday life. So, what kind of social energy is required to

The video of the incident shows people plucking pieces of the road surface with their bare hands. Someone who has long suffered from badly made, unsafe roads might already be on edge

restore and nurture a civic ethos?

The first, seemingly elusive, requirement is that the institutions through which formal power operates honour the letter and spirit of the law. This means that those who hold office in these institutions must be speedily prosecuted for violations. Who is to make this happen and how? Prospects for this look more hopeful now than at any time in the last decade or more. The pall of fear that had settled over *samaj* may not have lifted entirely, but it is sufficiently cracked for the light of courage and defiance to filter through.

A great deal now depends on what ethos the young people demanding change choose to adopt. Yes, there have been incidents of blind rage, but by and large the emerging youthful energy seeks to build formations and processes that foster participation and

cooperation, rather than an order-and-command culture. Above all, they are keen to learn from the experiences of earlier generations. The Jayaprakash Narayan slogan "*Hamla chahe jaisa hoga, haath hamara nahin uthega*" (no matter how we are attacked, we will not retaliate with violence) is faintly audible in the background.

Young people cannot do this alone. There is no substitute for more active participation by people of all ages in demanding accountability — regardless of which ideological group or party one supports. Such work may not be as dramatic as "venting" your anger, but it will foster what currently looks like a pipe dream to many: Basic well-being.

The writer is the founder of the YouTube channel 'Ahimsa Conversations'

At INDIA huddle, Rahul pitches for decisive fight, Mamata for larger Opp

Manoj C G & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, September 30

THE MEETING of the INDIA bloc parties in Delhi Wednesday saw Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, pitching for the Opposition's unity while stressing that it will have to trust itself.

Both Rahul and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said it was time all democratic forces come together against the BJP-led government.

Rahul is learnt to have told the meeting that the system which had been put in place by the ruling BJP was crumbling and that it was now a fight to the finish for the Opposition. Rahul also said some of the INDIA parties may have differences in some states but that should not come in the way of all the allies uniting and working together at the national level, sources said.

He said there should be unanimity among the INDIA partners who should not be speaking against each other. He claimed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi was "psychologically broken" and that the Opposition has "already won the



INDIA bloc leaders at the meeting in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

psychological battle", sources said. The meeting was marked with several interesting exchanges. Sources said G Devarajan of the Forward Bloc suggested that the leaders take out a march to the EC office immediately after the meeting.

TMC chief Mamata Banerjee supported him and told Rahul that it was a good suggestion. Rahul was agreeable but other leaders felt the protest march should be organised in a structured way and not in an impulsive manner, sources said.

Taking a cue from CPI(M) general secretary M A Baby, who said efforts should be

made to bring together all parties, civil society groups and intellectuals opposed to BJP, Mamata told the meeting that she had spoken to BJD chief Naveen Patnaik Tuesday and planned to reach out to non-NDA parties which are not part of the INDIA alliance. She said it was time to bring everyone together and even observed that she did not have any ego now as she was the "biggest sufferer".

In his intervention later, Rahul said all the parties were sufferers and that the people were ultimately the real sufferers, sources said. While arguing that efforts should be

made to bring all Opposition parties together, Mamata, at one point, even obliquely suggested to the Congress that it can have the PM's post but it will have to bring everyone on board.

Kharge intervened and is learnt to have said that the Congress was not after power or the PM post as it "only wants to save the nation and democracy", adding that talks about power and PM's post were not relevant now, sources said. Rahul is also learnt to have told the INDIA partners that history will remember the group of leaders at the meeting for "saving the nation and the country's democracy", sources said. He claimed that officers in the EC, CBI, and ED have started getting in touch with him regarding alleged irregularities in their offices.

National Conference leader and J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah spoke about alleged irregularities in the West Bengal elections, among other issues, and flagged alleged capture of institutions by the government.

Independent MP Kapil Sibal said there was no point seeking the arrest of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh

Kumar as he has immunity under the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023.

Proposing that the Opposition parties should jointly move the Supreme Court to challenge this law, which was accepted by the grouping, Sibal said the campaign against the EC needs to be undertaken "politically and legally", sources said.

CPI(M)-L leader Dipankar Bhattacharya highlighted the alleged malpractice by the EC in changing Form 6 for new voters.

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray, who joined the meeting virtually, alleged that the EC was not just indulging in "vote theft" but also "helping the BJP in breaking the Opposition parties", said sources. He also said that the Opposition needs to be on the ground on the issue of "vote chori".

The meeting did not formally deliberate on the Opposition's proposal to again move an impeachment motion against Gyanesh Kumar in Parliament, although some leaders discussed it on its sidelines.

Key leaders absent, INDIA bloc rejected Rahul as its face: BJP

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 30

REACTING TO INDIA bloc meeting on Wednesday, the BJP attacked the alliance leaders for allegedly peddling "pre-packaged excuses" for their eventual defeat in the upcoming polls.

Underlining the absence of key opposition leaders from the meet, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said it indicated that the alliance was not in favour of accepting Rahul Gandhi as its leader. "Despite successive electoral defeats, the Congress, instead of engaging in introspection and apologising, continues to spread confusion, allegations and lies... the absence of key alliance partners from the INDI Alliance meeting has raised questions about its unity," Chouhan told reporters at the BJP headquarters.

Calling the call for 'save democracy' marches an "attempt to protect dynastic politics", he said the people would not accept the politics of dynasticism, adding that the Congress and Opposition bloc are "looking for excuses for their defeats by questioning constitutional institutions, the judiciary and the electoral process".



Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan at a press conference in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANI

"Why was Akhilesh Yadav not present at the meeting if the issue was so important, particularly when elections are due in a state like Uttar Pradesh... M K Stalin was also absent. The DMK has said that wherever the Congress is present, it will not sit with it. Arvind Kejriwal was also absent. Uddhav Thackeray did not join physically but participated virtually," he said.

"There was no information about Hemant Soren. The condition of the INDI Alliance has become such that, '*Ek dil ke tukde hazaar hue, koi idhar gira, koi udhar gira*'. The truth is that the INDI Alliance is not prepared to accept Rahul Gan-

dhi as its leader."

Chouhan also said the outcome of the meeting was, "Zero vision, 100% frustration and advance excuse for defeat". "They are preparing the ground for defeat even before the upcoming polls and are already looking for excuses for their defeat. The 'Save democracy march' programme has been announced from October 2-8. This is... 'save dynasty march'. However, the people have decided that they will no longer allow dynastic politics to continue," he said.

Chouhan said that as far as procedures were concerned, it is the ECI "that will decide what should and should not be done" and not the Opposition.

"Constitutional institutions will perform their duties independently. The entire world is aware of India's democracy and its EVM system. It is through these same EVMs that the Congress won elections in Karnataka, Telangana, and Himachal Pradesh," he said.

"Mamata Banerjee will not decide who remains the Prime Minister of the country or who becomes the chief minister of a state... people of the country decide..." he added.

'What is the glitch?': HC asks EC after six names removed from Goa electoral rolls

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, September 30

WHILE HEARING a petition where names of six members of a family had been deleted from the electoral roles after their Form 8 applications for address change were rejected, the High Court of Bombay at Goa on Wednesday said the draft roll cannot be the basis for deletion of names from the electoral rolls and that administrative software systems cannot supersede statutory laws.

The petitioners — Paresh Salgaonkar and five members of his family — said that they had moved to a new house in the same Santa Cruz Assembly constituency prior to the commencement of the SIR process and were instructed by the BLO to submit Form 8 for change of address. At the time of processing of these forms, errors were reflected since no record of their Electors Photo Identity Cards (EPIC) were found, and as such, the only option available in the ERO-NET login was 'reject'.

The petitioners submitted that the Assistant Electoral Registration Officer informed them that their EPICs had been deleted from the rolls and consequently, their Form 8 applications could not be processed.

The only recourse available was to submit Form 6 since there was no option in ERO-NET for reviewing or restoring the deleted EPICs.

EC extends SIR schedule in 2 states

New Delhi: The ECI on Wednesday decided to extend the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh and Meghalaya, postponing the publication of the final electoral roll to October 16 and October 26, respectively.

"A meeting of the ECI was held today at 4.30 pm at Nirvachan Sadan, New Delhi. The meeting was attended by Chief Election Commissioner Shri Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Dr SS Sandhu and Dr Vivek Joshi. During the meeting it was decided to extend the SIR dates in Andhra Pradesh and Meghalaya," it said. **ENS**

The petitioners told the court that this explanation is untenable in law since Form 6 is applicable exclusively to first-time electors seeking fresh inclusion of their names in the elector roll and them being existing electors, seeking a change of address within the same Assembly constituency, are statutorily required to apply under Form 8.

A division bench of Justices Amit S Jamsandekar and Valmiki Menezes on Wednesday said the draft roll cannot be the basis for deletion. "Otherwise, Form 6, 7 or 8 have no meaning, Form 6, 7 and 8 are specifically

for either a person who is a new voter, a person who has lost the right to vote, or a person who is shifting," the court said.

The court told the ECI that the software "system did not allow" to accept Form-8. "He [petitioners] was never a new voter. He was an existing voter. He became new for your system," the court said.

The bench questioned the EC regarding provisions empowering the Commission to delete names without a hearing. "Show us from the Act... what empowers you to delete without hearing?... Your officers were helpless, and they just decided to throw it on the system. So, they recorded it in the order, saying that the system has rejected. We are very perturbed by this... we are just wondering how many more who have not come to court," the bench said.

"What is the glitch? Once a Form 8 comes, the authority must apply its mind and see whether this person has really moved. When he has moved, ... how does he load it into the system? How does the officer break into the system and set it right? There is no explanation for how the officer cannot override the system and put his order under it?" the bench asked.

Observing that "lakhs will go off the rolls", the court added, "Here there is only one family. Take a situation where there are so many people who have shifted residence."

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, September 30

WHEN NIRUPAMA Tripathy, a Booth Level Officer (BLO) in Odisha's Dhamnagar Assembly seat, opened the app she was using for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, she discovered at least 227 Form 7 applications seeking deletion of voters' names uploaded using her credentials without, she says, her knowledge.

Tripathy wasn't the only one. Several BLOs in Dhamnagar's Notified Area Council — an Urban Local Body, alongside municipalities and municipal corporations — claimed several Form 7 applications similarly uploaded in their names. On September 4, 10 such BLOs registered a police complaint and approached the Bhadrak District Collector. On September 7, the BJD, principal opposition party, submitted a memorandum to Odisha Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) RS Gopalan on the issue.

Now, after a preliminary inquiry, the Election Commission has suspended Santosh Kumar Nayak, the Executive Officer of the Dhamnagar council and the area's Assistant Electoral Registration Officer (AERO) for the SIR exercise, who allegedly used the credentials of BLOs to submit the bulk deletion applications. The applications were also withdrawn, with most of the voters against whom Form 7s were allegedly filed fraudulently in Dhamnagar figuring



BLOs submit a complaint to police in Odisha's Dhamnagar. EXPRESS

in Odisha's final electoral roll, released on September 21.

As per officials, over 90% of these applications concerned Muslim voters. Dhamnagar, located in northeast Odisha, is one of the few Assembly seats in the state with a sizeable Muslim population. The BLOs who spoke to *The Indian Express* said that almost all voters flagged via Form 7s had been cleared by them in the enumeration round, and mapped to the 2002 SIR.

Apart from the large presence of Muslim names in the applications, what raised suspicion, sources said, was the high number of Form 7s, over 3,000, from one seat of Dhamnagar. In contrast, across Odisha's 147 Assembly seats, 20,707 names were deleted on the basis of Form 7 applications, working out to an average of 141 voters per seat.

After the BJD's memorandum, the CEO offices sought a report from the Additional Sub-Collector, Bhadrak, who is the

Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) for Dhamnagar. "The allegations in the memorandum are of a sensitive nature and thus need immediate examination," the September 8 letter read.

A source said, "The ERO verified the issue internally and prima facie found that the forms had been processed in an unauthorized manner."

On September 21, the CEO wrote to the Bhadrak District Collector, saying the ECI had "conveyed its approval for suspension and initiation of disciplinary proceeding" against Nayak, "in connection with... allegations of unauthorised use of BLO credentials/ OTPs and unauthorised submission/ uploading of Form-7 applications during the ongoing SIR exercise". On Monday, the Odisha Housing and Urban Development Department issued the official order suspending Nayak.

CEO Gopalan refused to comment on the matter.

• THIS TIME, ISSUE MOVED FROM EC & ITS EQUATIONS WITH GOVT TO ONE THAT AFFECTS MILLIONS OF VOTERS — WHO ARE CONCERNED WHETHER THEIR NAMES WILL BE ENROLLED, DELETED, OR RESTORED IN THE ROLLS

Why Gyanesh Kumar row marks crucial reckoning in BJP vs INDIA bloc battle



THE NEERJA CHOWDHURY COLUMN
WEEKLY INSIGHT INTO WHAT'S CHANGING IN NATIONAL POLITICS — AND WHY

"AGAR VOTE se khilwarh hua toh Bhagat Singh paida ho jayenge," remarked a Sikh taxi driver in Delhi. Whether or not the prevailing situation can throw up Bhagat Singhs is debatable, but his words reflected his feelings about his right to vote.

The next week will tell us more about the direction of the protests that are underway to press for the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, who has been in the eye of a storm over various alleged irregularities in the conduct of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) and the deletion of over 13 crore voters from the draft electoral rolls during the exercise.

"What next?" is a question

uppermost on the minds of many after the Election Commission of India last Saturday held its first meeting since *The Indian Express* exposé on the deep divide within the poll panel and glaring gaps in its processes.

The ECI's note on its nine decisions along with a photo of the CEC flanked by the two Election Commissioners (ECs), Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, showed they had made peace and were on the same page now. *The Indian Express* reported that the two ECs had objected on record 14 times in 10 months on a range of issues. The ECI's note sought to address some of the concerns raised by Sandhu and Joshi — such as the decision to circulate the agenda of the ECI's meeting in advance and its minutes afterwards.

The ECI's response was ambivalent on various other issues which have triggered widespread concerns: the changes to Form 6 for new voters including Gen Z (which was strongly objected to by Sandhu and Joshi), and the centralisation of voter database restricting the

statutory rights of designated officials like the Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to access it for updating voter lists.

BJP's challenge

With the ECs appearing to be going along with him now, the CEC may have got a breather, even as the Opposition parties and the CJP are doubling down over their demand for his ouster.

The BJP came out with full-throated support for the CEC, and its worried NDA allies who had called for the CEC's clarifications, seemed satisfied, at least for now, with the ECI's statement. It goes without saying that Kumar's resignation may aggravate the situation for the BJP, and embolden the Opposition to demand more. For all its defence of the CEC, the BJP brass could not be oblivious of the current restlessness prevailing in the country, which may signify a shift in public mood.

The BJP would want the crisis to be defused rather than escalate on an issue as crucial as the right of voters to elect their government. We know how



Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar (centre) with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu (left) and Vivek Joshi. FILE

seriously the common people take their vote and queue up from early morning on polling day to press the EVM button.

The BJP dismissed Sandhu and Joshi's differences with the CEC as a routine matter which had also happened in the past. The ECI is no stranger to controversy since the days when a multi-member body was set up by the Narasimha Rao-led Congress government, which was challenged by the then CEC T N Seshan, who brought wide-ranging reforms, including the Model Code of Conduct, in the

poll body to change its face.

In 1993, the Narasimha Rao government promulgated an ordinance to fix the number of the ECs at two and appointed M S Gill and G V G Krishnamurthy as the ECs, which was seen as a bid to undermine the CEC's authority. Seshan challenged it in the Supreme Court, which in 1995 upheld the validity of the multi-member poll panel, vesting the ECs with equal rights as the CEC and ruling that decisions must be made unanimously or by a majority vote by them.

In January 2009, then CEC N

Gopalaswami had written to the President seeking the removal of EC Navin Chawla, citing a "lack of political neutrality". Chawla was eventually appointed the CEC. The issues, then, were mostly about pique and a tug of war between the CEC and ECs about their powers or their proximity to the government of the day, which wanted a pliant EC.

SIR crisis

This time, however, the issue is different. It has moved from the ECI and its equations with the government to one that affects millions of voters directly — who are concerned over whether their names will be enrolled, deleted, or restored in the electoral rolls, as the case might be. Many suspect the ECI of being an instrument to keep them out of the poll process.

There was a time when the ECI would run public campaigns to encourage voters to enrol and to vote. It has been a double whammy for the poor voters, who, without their names on the rolls, could lose access to the benefits of government welfare

schemes. So the issue is also an emotive one this time. And the CEC's image has taken a beating, even as the ECI and the ruling dispensation have sought to control the damage. Also, the credibility of the polls conducted by the ECI have taken a hit, which should worry any government.

Many used to marvel how the outcome of an election in India was never contested by the losing party, even as individual defeats were challenged in courts. Prime Ministers, weak or powerful, would make way for their successors with humility. For all the faultlines that exist in the country's democratic landscape, the transition of power always took place peacefully.

All eyes are now on the Opposition and the Supreme Court where petitions have been filed questioning the CEC's conduct and seeking to declare the SIR illegal. The Congress has held protests in state capitals and other places across India. After the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting on the issue Tuesday, the party said the Opposition INDIA bloc will decide

on launching a nationwide movement against alleged electoral malpractices. The CJP has also called for a "Jantar Mantar 2.0" in Mumbai on October 2 to demand the CEC's removal.

The ground for the Opposition seems to be more fertile today than it has been over the past 12 years. But its capacity to mount pressure on the ECI — and the government — and undertake an agitation to ensure the inclusion of every legitimate voter in the rolls, would depend on how effectively it can close its ranks besides getting other non-NDA parties like the DMK, AAP, BJD and YSRCP on board too.

A few days ago, LoP Rahul Gandhi said he "loves swimming in the sea when it's rough". The most challenging task that lies before him is clear — to pull together the entire Opposition before charting his next course.

Neerja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of 'How Prime Ministers Decide'

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• LEGAL

‘Public view’: Why HC said SC/ST Act covers online slurs

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, September 30

THE CALCUTTA High Court has held that casteist slurs on social media can attract provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, observing that “public view” under the law is not confined to physical spaces. A single bench of Justice Uday Kumar said the requirement of “public view” under Sections 3(1)(r) and 3(1)(s) of the Act “transcends physical space into the digital domain”. The ruling comes weeks after the Supreme Court reiterated that not every caste-related remark amounts to an offence under the Act and that courts must closely examine whether its statutory requirements are satisfied.

What the law says

Sections 3(1)(r) and 3(1)(s) of the SC/ST Act criminalise intentionally insulting, intimidating or abusing a member of a Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe by caste name “in any place within public view”. To establish these offences, three elements are required: the accused should not be a member of an SC or ST community, the act must be intended to humiliate the victim on the basis of their caste, and the incident must occur in a place “within public view”. Digital cases turn on the third requirement.

The Supreme Court in *Hitesh Verma v. State of Uttarakhand* (2020) held that “public view” means a place where members of the public can witness or hear the alleged utterance. “If the alleged offence takes place within the four corners of the wall where members of the public are not present, then it cannot be said that it has taken place at a place within public view,” it said.

‘PUBLIC VIEW’ IN THE DIGITAL AGE

● A key element required to establish offences under SC/ST Act is that the incident must occur ‘within public view’.

● Calcutta HC said this element can go beyond physical space. Kerala HC, too, said in 2022 that the Act’s interpretation must keep pace with tech advances.

What the Calcutta HC held

The petitioner, a member of a Scheduled Caste, complained that two men from general caste communities had used casteist expletives against him on Facebook. Police later filed a closure report, saying Facebook had not provided user details. The complainant filed a petition against that closure in a special court at Alipore, which rejected it. The HC set aside the order, describing the special court’s reasons as “perverse” and pulling up the police. On the question of public view, the court held that it “transcends physical space into the digital domain”.

What other courts have said

The Kerala HC in *Sooraj V. Sukumar v. State of Kerala* (2022) said courts cannot interpret the law as if society had remained unchanged since its enactment. It described the SC/ST Act as an “ongoing statute” and observed that statutes may have to be interpreted to accommodate technological advances. A restrictive reading could defeat the purpose of law.

• CLIMATE

Rising sea level threat to India’s eroding coastline



EXPERTS EXPLAIN

SHIVANG AGARWAL
& NIMISH SINGH

ON 24 September, the UN General Assembly adopted its first ever declaration on rising sea levels, which pose an existential threat to populations around the world.

The rise in sea levels has been “accelerating” (to quote the declaration) for some time now. The rate of global rise more than doubled from 2.1 mm a year in 1993-2002 to 4.7 mm a year in 2015-2024, according to the World Meteorological Organization. In 2024 alone the sea rose 6 mm, the largest annual increase on record.

Much of what is coming is locked in. Even on the lowest-emissions path, global sea level will rise about 38 cm by 2100 above its level of the early 2000s, according to ‘Surging Seas in a Warming World’, a 2024 technical brief from the UN Secretary-General’s Climate Action Team. If emissions keep climbing, the brief puts the figure at about 77 cm. The brief says the sea will keep rising for centuries to millennia even if the world reaches “net zero”.

Amid these scenarios, the declaration focuses on the loss of territory faced by vulnerable countries — such as the island nations of Tuvalu and Kiribati in the Pacific, as well as the Maldives. Importantly, it also asks nations to build sea-level rise projections into the planning and design of their coastal infrastructure — which is where India has work to do. Let us look at both aspects.

Can a country retain its statehood even if it loses its territory?

Under the 1933 Montevideo Convention, a State is defined using four main criteria: a permanent population, a defined territory, a government and the capacity to enter into relations with other states.

But if rising sea levels swallow a State’s “defined territory”, or render it uninhabitable for a “permanent population”, does it still remain a state? This is the question the UN declaration attempts to settle. Indeed, it affirms that a country stays a country when the sea takes its land.

The declaration mentions a “presump-



Coastal erosion in Tamil Nadu. A report says 45 mn Indians may be at risk from sea level rise by 2050. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

tion in favour of continued statehood”, so such a country keeps its sovereignty, its rights and its seat at the UN. Crucially, such a country would also maintain its nautical boundaries — which are calculated from the coast — even when the coastline retreats.

For people who lose their homes, the declaration asks countries to respect their human rights and to “encourage strengthened international cooperation to assist persons affected”. One example of this is already underway. By December 2025, over a third of Tuvalu’s 11,000-strong population had applied for climate visas to migrate to Australia under a bilateral treaty.

What does India gain from a promise for small islands?

At the meeting, Sibi George, Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs, welcomed the declaration and backed stable maritime zones and continuity of statehood. He also reaffirmed equity and “common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities”, the principle that every country must act on climate change, while those that caused more of it and can afford more should do more.

India has its own stake in the text. A 2023-24 remeasurement counts 1,298 offshore islands and islets and a coastline of 11,098 km. Lakshadweep and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands carry India’s boundaries at sea far into the Arabian Sea

A key provision in declaration

Countries can maintain nautical boundaries, which are calculated from the coast, even when it retreats.

● Lakshadweep and Andaman and Nicobar Islands carry India’s nautical boundaries far into sea.

● So, a pledge to keep those nautical boundaries fixed protects India’s waters.

and the Bay of Bengal. So, a pledge to keep those nautical boundaries fixed protects India’s waters as well as the Pacific’s.

Is India’s own coast ready?

The government’s National Centre for Coastal Research tracked the whole mainland shoreline between 1990 and 2016 and found that about a third of it was eroding.

Nationally, the losses and gains are roughly balanced, with 234 sq km lost to erosion and 231 sq km gained elsewhere. The losses, however, are concentrated: the assessment finds nearly 400 km of coast retreating by more than 5 metres a year, and another 225 km by 3 to 5 metres. West Bengal alone has more than 170 km in the fastest category, about a third of its coast.

Under the 2019 Coastal Regulation Zone notification, the strip where nothing new may be built is 50 metres wide in densely populated rural areas once a state’s coastal plan is approved, and 200 metres elsewhere. Both are measured from the high-tide line — which the notification defines as the line the highest spring tide reaches today. So, on a stretch losing 5 metres a year, a house approved 50 metres from today’s high-tide line would stand at the water’s edge in about ten years if the retreat continues. Even a 200-metre strip would last about 40 years.

The Survey of India has mapped a better line, a hazard line, that takes in sea level rise and shoreline change, and it has been shared

with the coastal states. The 2019 rules use it as “a tool for disaster management plan” and for land-use planning, while the no-build strip is still measured from today’s tide. The declaration India supported recognises the need to build sea-level projections into the planning of coastal infrastructure.

Where does India fall short?

In the Sundarbans, for instance, the loss has already happened. According to India Water Portal, Ghoramara island shrank from about 7.2 sq km in 1972 to 3.6 sq km in 2022. Families who had moved there from neighbouring Lohachara, which disappeared in the early 2000s, were displaced again within a decade, and those relocated were moved to marginal land without secure tenure or livelihood support.

Indian law has no clear category for people who lose land gradually to erosion, so each relocation is decided case by case. A 2025 review in *Frontiers in Marine Science* journal estimates that 45 million Indians will be at risk from sea level rise by 2050 and notes that India “still lacks comprehensive legislation” to deal with these risks. Fiji has shown one way: It wrote relocation into its Climate Change Act in 2021, with a trust fund to pay for it.

What should India do before the UN meets again?

The declaration schedules another high-level meeting on sea level rise by September 2030, which gives India four years to show results. It can start by measuring the no-build strip from the hazard line, or widening it by the local erosion rate, beginning with the stretches the National Centre for Coastal Research shows retreating fastest.

It also needs a law for people displaced slowly by erosion and rising water, one that gives relocated families land title and livelihood support at the new site.

And it should keep pressing on money. The declaration calls for scaled-up finance and “timely and predictable disbursement”. The UN Environment Programme puts developing countries’ adaptation needs at over \$310 billion a year by 2035, against \$26 billion of international public adaptation finance in 2023. At the Baku climate summit in 2024, India objected to the new goal of \$300 billion a year by 2035 as “too little and too distant”. It should press the same case at COP31 in Antalya in November.

Agarwal is Senior Fellow at the Institute for Governance & Sustainable Development; Singh is Director, Science, Gateway Research Foundation.

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

\$2-tn valuation, catastrophic AI risks: Inside Anthropic’s IPO filing

Anagha Jayakumar

New Delhi, September 30

FOLLOWING ITS CEO Dario Amodei’s recent call for artificial intelligence (AI) companies to slow the development of increasingly powerful models, Anthropic is preparing for a potential \$2 trillion valuation. The company confidentially filed documents with the US Securities and Exchange Commission in June, setting the stage for a potential initial public offering (IPO). The listing is now expected after the US midterm elections in November.

In the draft prospectus reviewed by *Reuters* (it is publicly unavailable), Anthropic argues that AI will transform the global economy far more profoundly than industrialisation, electricity, and the internet.

Losing a lot of money

Anthropic’s estimated \$2-trillion valuation target is more than double its estimated valuation of \$965 billion this May, signalling rapid growth. The company, however, has been losing large sums: revenue grew 12-fold to about \$4.6 billion in 2025, but its operating loss widened to \$8.06

billion from \$2.98 billion in 2024.

The headline net loss was almost \$42 billion, but roughly \$34 billion of that was an accounting charge tied largely to financing instruments that could potentially convert into shares, rather than money spent operating the company. Anthropic nevertheless ended 2025 with \$20.28 billion in cash, cash equivalents and short-term investments.

Warnings about AI risks

The company, which has long highlighted its emphasis on safety, also claims that advanced AI could present “catastrophic or existential risks to humanity”.

The filing also discloses that Anthropic’s AI models have been used “in ways that could lead to self-harm, acts of violence toward others, or other adverse outcomes” despite safeguards. Anthropic has thus far not been named in any lawsuit concerning the mental health of users. Notably, Anthropic has not disclosed how much it has spent on safety research in the filing, and says returns on its safety investments are currently unclear.

The filing also singles out risks from AI agents, anticipating legal claims over the actions of autonomous agents that act outside

Benchmark for market value

● Anthropic’s proposed listing follows SpaceX’s blockbuster IPO in June, which valued the company at \$1.77 trillion.

● It could set a benchmark for how public markets value frontier AI companies, with rival OpenAI also preparing to go public.

the instructions or parameters set by their developers. Since July, OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta and Google have disclosed a series of such incidents. Anthropic anticipates that its legal contracts may not adequately protect it from “significant and unpredictable” legal claims arising from AI agents’ actions.

Compute remains central

Anthropic spent \$7.33 billion on compute and infrastructure in 2025, more than three times its 2024 spending and more than half of its \$12.65 billion in total operating expenses. The company has at least \$518 billion in cloud, computing and infrastructure obligations over the coming decade. This includes at least \$111.1 billion to Google, \$110 billion to Amazon and \$31.4 billion to Microsoft over seven to 10 years.

Founders retain control

Anthropic is structuring the company so its seven co-founders, including Dario and Daniela Amodei, retain 50.1% of voting power over key corporate matters even after outside investors buy shares. The filing acknowledges that this could result in decisions that conflict with shareholders’ financial inter-

ests. The special voting arrangement will begin to wind down once only two or fewer founders, or their successors, remain.

Revenue sources are few

Anthropic’s rapid revenue growth comes with a major concentration risk: nearly a quarter of its revenue in 2025 came from just two customers. The filing does not identify them, and many of Anthropic’s largest customers are not locked into long-term contracts, allowing them to reduce or stop spending comparatively easily.

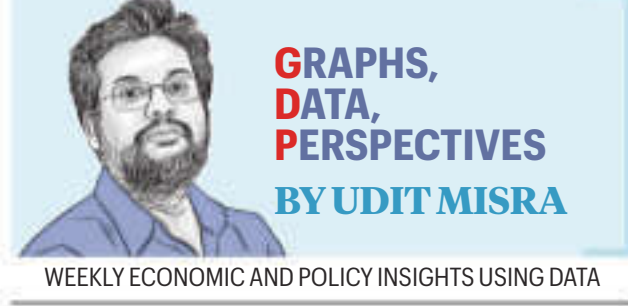
The filing highlights Anthropic’s heavy dependence on a small group of Big Tech partners and customers. Amazon and Google handled 47% of its 2025 sales, while Anthropic paid cloud platforms about \$351 million in distribution fees.

It also reflects the increasingly circular nature of AI financing: companies such as Amazon and Google are simultaneously major investors in Anthropic, infrastructure providers and commercial partners. Anthropic, in turn, has committed hundreds of billions of dollars to buying computing capacity from the same ecosystem.

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• ECONOMICS

US Treasury yields at 25-yr high: What are bond yields, what happens when they rise



THE YIELD on the 30-year US Treasury bond hit the highest level in around 25 years on Tuesday. This instrument is an IOU (I owe-you) document used by the US government to borrow money from the market.

The yield denotes the return on investment that a lender can expect when loaning the money to the government for a particular length of time. So a 30-year bond refers to a loan the government repays over that same period.

Governments borrow money for all kinds of durations, ranging from a few days to several years. As the chart shows, yields have been rising not just for long-term borrowing but across all durations.

Reasons

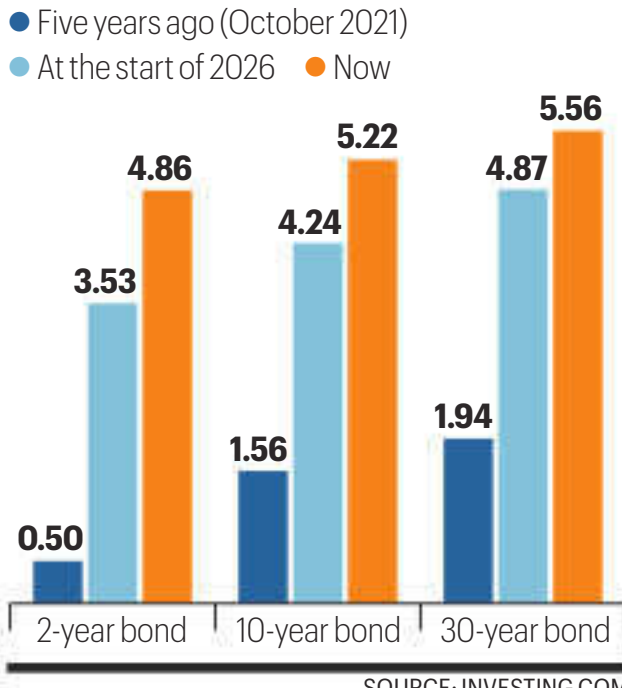
But why are bond yields going up? Doesn’t the government say upfront how much it will pay? When a government borrows it stipulates an exact amount — called the coupon — that it will pay at the end of each year to the bondholder (or lender). But, government bonds, especially those issued by the US government, are heavily traded in the secondary market, and it is in this trade that yields start shifting.

Imagine the US government floating a one-year bond of \$100 with a coupon of \$10. In other words, the lender will get \$110 at the end of the year. The rate of return is 10%. But suppose that soon after launching the bond, the US starts a war that spikes inflation — as it has done this year. Inflation basically means your money is worth less and less with the passage of time. As inflation starts to go up, it threatens to eat away or reduce the real value of that \$10 the lender was supposed to get at the end of the year.

In such a case, the lender will try to sell the bond in the secondary market before

• Yields rising across durations

US treasury bond yields (in %)



inflation completely ruins the returns, and use their money to invest in other places which pay a better return.

But given the rising inflation, other participants in the bond market may not be willing to pay \$100 for the same bond anymore. Instead, they may offer a lower price. That’s because at a lower price of the bond that same \$10 “yields” a higher rate of return at the end of the year.

As the price of the bond falls, based on what market participants demand as an acceptable rate of return, the yield rises. While this is not an exact example, it shows what has been happening lately. Investors are demanding higher rates of return in nominal terms because inflation is threatening to eat into real returns (the returns after taking away the effect of inflation). Apart from inflation concerns, just the sheer increase in the demand for loans (by governments and businesses around the world) is also pushing up what lenders want as returns.

Implications

Rising yields on US bonds have two broad implications.

ONE, it signals higher borrowing costs

for the US government. In other words, if yields on existing bonds are rising, the US government will have to match them when it goes to the market to borrow again. Like any other government, the US government, too, routinely goes to the market to borrow money — either to meet some new expenditure or to pay back old debt that is maturing.

Either way, higher borrowing costs typically imply that a larger portion of the US budget would have to be spent towards paying interest. That, in turn, leaves less money available for other priorities — say providing social security for US citizens.

Thanks to the US government’s increased borrowing each year (called the annual budget deficit) pushing the pile of existing debt to over \$40 trillion as well as rising bond yields, the total annual outgo towards interest payments from the annual budget has ballooned from around \$600 billion before the Covid-19 pandemic to \$1.2 trillion as of 2025.

TWO, higher yields for the US govern-

ment also signal higher borrowing costs for every other government and business, including higher interest rates on home loans.

Since lending money to the US government is the safest lending one can do — because everyone believes the US government will always pay back and never default on its debt — if the yield on US government bonds rises, it typically means all other kinds of loans also become costlier. In other words, lenders demand even higher returns for giving loans to other governments and businesses since they are all riskier than lending money to the US government.

It doesn’t help matters that this is not a US-only problem at the moment: Governments of most of the big economies have high levels of debt and even companies, especially in the artificial intelligence domain, are set to borrow heavily to fuel the next stage of their growth.

Higher borrowing costs across the board threaten to drag down economic activity, and that is why rising bond yields are bad news in the current context.

TAMIL NADU TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LTD
Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
PC1145 & PC1146	CE / P&C	Procurement of Panels & Supply of Scientific Testing Instruments
T.2393	SE / Transmission - II	Supply of 75 mm Aluminium Bus Bar

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission / opening, viewing and downloading of e-tenders, please visit websites: www.tantransco.gov.in, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app

DIPR/3000/Tender/2026

Navi Mumbai Municipal Transport

**Estate Dept.
E-Tender Notice**

Tender no. NMMT/TM/ESTATE/08/2026-27

Subject:- Appointment of a contractor to supply 750 contractual bus Conductors & 257 contractual bus Drivers to the NMMT as per requirements.

Above subjected tender is available on portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in> Right to accept or reject any tender is reserved by the Hon'ble Transport Manager of NMMT.

Sd/-
**(Umakant Jangle)
Transport Manager
N.M.M.T.**

NMMT/TM/ADMIN/607/2026, Dt. 30.09.2026

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NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec.No.PMM32-e-73/2026: Supply of 1 Set of Emergency Restoration System (ERS), comprising 10 Nos. Towers with associated hardware, suitable up to 400 kV. Date & Time of availability of above tender: **06.10.2026 at 6:00PM**. Website: www.tender.aeprocurement.gov.in Contact-No.CE/Transmission:0866- 2429230

RO No: GMCC/APTRANSCO/16126-27 Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/TRANSMISSION

Tamil Nadu Power Generation Corporation Ltd
Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
221	CE / Coal	Time Chartering of one no Self Trimming Panamax or Kamsarmax Gearless Bulk Carrier Vessel
222	CE / Coal	Time chartering of 1 no Panamax Kamsarmax gearless vessel

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission / Opening, viewing and downloading of e-tenders, please visit websites: www.tangedco.gov.in, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tenders.tn.gov.in

DIPR/2998/Tender/2026

राजस्थान स्टेट सीड्स कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड

F7/RSSC/NIT/2026-27/13541 Date :- 30/09/2026

Notice Inviting E-Bid

Rajasthan State Seeds Corporation Limited, Jaipur invites E-Bids from interested Bidders for various supplies/ works as follows:-

Sr. No.	Particulars	Estimated cost in Lakh (Rs.)	Last date of online submission or Tender	UBN
1	E-Bid invites from Seed production company/institutions/agency for seed production assistance in Gudamalani (Barmer)	89.42	Up to 13.00 hrs. on 09.10.2026	SDS2627 SLOB00030
2	Procurement of berseem seed for rabi 2026-27 for Rajasthan	100.00	Up to 14.00 hrs. on 09.10.2026	SDS2627 GLOB00033

Tender documents & Details are available on website <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in or www.rajseeds.rajjasthan.gov.in, agriculture.rajjasthan.gov.in, Managing Director Raj.Samwadh/C/26/11068 DIN 10789648

**OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
PWD, DIVISION BHILWARA**

No.- 3758 Date: 25.09.2026
NIB CODE:- PWD2627A2987

-:Notice Inviting Bid 14/2026-27:-

Bids for "Various Building R & M (Civil & Electric) works, CC Road & Drain work & Road Repair works in PWD Dn. Bhilwara" work are invited from interested bidders upto 06.00 PM Dated 05.10.2026 (Monday). Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state. The approximate values of the procurement is Rs. 356.24 Lacs, (Total of 28 Bid).

UBN No. :-

PWD2627WSOB13421,	PWD2627WSOB13422,	PWD2627WSOB13423,
PWD2627WSOB13424,	PWD2627WSOB13425,	PWD2627WSOB13426,
PWD2627WSOB13427,	PWD2627WSOB13428,	PWD2627WSOB13429,
PWD2627WSOB13430,	PWD2627WSOB13431,	PWD2627WSOB13432,
PWD2627WSOB13433,	PWD2627WSOB13434,	PWD2627WSOB13435,
PWD2627WSOB13436,	PWD2627WSOB13437,	PWD2627WSOB13438,
PWD2627WSOB13439,	PWD2627WSOB13440,	PWD2627WSOB13441,
PWD2627WSOB13442,	PWD2627WSOB13443,	PWD2627WSOB13444,
PWD2627WSOB13445,	PWD2627WSOB13446,	PWD2627WSOB13447,

Sd/-
(B.L. Regar)
Executive Engineer
PWD Division Bhilwara Mob. No. 94145-74926

DIPR/C/16775/2026

GORKHA RIFLES

Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave hearts, Late Rfn Chaturman Rai, Rfn Bir Bahadur Limbu, Rfn Chakra Prasad Rai, Rfn Jagat Bahadur Rai, Rfn S B Rai, Rfn Ari Bahadur Rai, Rfn Garja Man Rai, Rfn Sarbadhoj Rai, L/NK Krishna Bahadur Rai, NK Bijoy Bahadur Limbu and Rfn Debi Prasad Limbu, of 7/11 GR, whom made supreme sacrifice during OP (CHO LA SKIRMISH) on 01 Oct 1967.

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Javans Head Constable Ashok Kumar on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting with militants in area of Thuru, Reasi (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

HEAD CONSTABLE YASHPAL SINGH 47 BN BSF 20.09.1957 – 01.10.2002	HEAD CONSTABLE NEMI CHAND 47 BN BSF 29.09.1962 – 01.10.2002	HEAD CONSTABLE BALBIR SINGH 47 BN BSF 10.02.1964 – 01.10.2002	CONSTABLE PRATAP KUMAR SAHOO 47 BN BSF 12.04.1976 – 01.10.2002
CONSTABLE SUKHDEV PRADHAN 47 BN BSF 15.05.1976 – 01.10.2002	CONSTABLE UTTAM MONDAL 47 BN BSF 01.10.1977 – 01.10.2002	CONSTABLE A VEERA MANI 47 BN BSF 11.06.1979 – 01.10.2002	

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Javans Head Constables Yashpal Singh, Nemi Chand, Balbir Singh & Constables Pratap Kumar Sahoo, Sukhdev Pradhan, Uttam Mondal and A Veera Mani on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in Pulwama area (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

HEAD CONSTABLE BALWAN SINGH, PMG 49 BN BSF 01.09.1962 – 01.10.2001	CONSTABLE RAJ KUMAR, PMG 49 BN BSF 10.04.1969 – 01.10.2001
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable B Jayan on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Srinagar area (J&K). They fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Their sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding them with PMG (Posthumously).

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Ashok Kumar Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in area of Handwara area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CONSTABLE ASHOK KUMAR SINGH 76 BN BSF 01.07.1969 – 01.10.1990	CONSTABLE B JAYAN 143 BN BSF 24.01.1977 – 01.10.2002
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable K Sudhershnan Reddy on his Balidan Diwas. On 30 Sep 2002, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Kashmir valley. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty on 1st Oct 2002. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Shaurya Chakra (Posthumously).

CONSTABLE SUDHERSHAN REDDY, SHAURYA CHAKRA 129 BN BSF 14.03.1979 – 01.10.2002	
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Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable K Sudhershnan Reddy on his Balidan Diwas. On 30 Sep 2002, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Kashmir valley. He fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty on 1st Oct 2002. His sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding him with Shaurya Chakra (Posthumously).

**OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER,
P.W.D., CIRCLE-JHALAWAR**

Room No.-158, Ground Floor (Public Works Department), Mini Secretariat, Jhalawar

E-mail:- piu_jhalawar@rediffmail.com / sejwar.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

Phone No.: 07432-233336 Date: 25.09.2026

SHORT TERM NIT No. 18/2026-27
Notice Inviting Bid
NIB No. PWD2627A2953

Bids for Construction of Various Non-Patchable and Missing Link Roads in Distt. Jhalawar (B.A. 295.00/2026-27) are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM, Dated 08.10.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the Rajasthan and <http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in> website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 772.23 Lacs.

S.No.	UBN No.	S.No.	UBN No.	S.No.	UBN No.
1	PWD2627WSOB13285	2	PWD2627WSOB13288	3	PWD2627WSOB13289
4	PWD2627WSOB13291	5	PWD2627WSOB13292	6	PWD2627WSOB13293

Sd/-
(Mukesh Chand Meena)
Superintending Engineer
Public Works Department
Circle-Jhalawar

DIPR/C/16642/2026

**ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER
PHED REGION-I JAIPUR**
Jyoti Nagar, Jaipur (Raj.)
E-Mail- acel_jpr.phed@rajasthan.gov.in

No- ACE/PHED/Ar. Dausa-27/27- NOTICE INVITING BID (NIT No. 03/2026-27)

On behalf of the Governor of Rajasthan NIT No. 03/2026-27 online tender is hereby invited from eligible bidders for "Providing, Laying, Jointing, Testing and Commissioning of pipeline for drinking water supply in municipal area of Baswa, District Dausa including 05 year O&M after completion of one year defect liability period, under Budget Announcement 17.05/2025-26". Interested bidders may participate upto 06.00 PM on dated 22.10.2026 as per criteria mentioned in the detailed NIT/Tender document available on website: <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> & <http://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in> Tenders are to be submitted online in electronic format on website <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> as per prescribed schedule.

NIT No.	Particular	Estt. Cost (Rs. In Lakhs)	UBN No.
03/2026-27	"Providing, Laying, Jointing, Testing and Commissioning of pipeline for drinking water supply in municipal area of Baswa, District Dausa including 05 year O&M after completion of one year defect liability period, under Budget Announcement 17.05/2025-26"	2436.15	PHE2627WLOB05943

DIPR/C/16866/2026 Additional Chief Engineer

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA, HOME DEPARTMENT (PORTS & TRANSPORT)
MAHARASHTRA MARITIME BOARD

Indian Mercantile Chambers, 2nd Floor, Ramjibhai Kamani Marg, Ballard Estate, Mumbai-400 001. Tel.: 022-69041777 Fax : 022-69041740
Web site : <https://mahammb.maharashtra.gov.in>
Email : ceo.mmb@maharashtra.gov.in / ceommb@gmail.com

E-Tender Notice
Main Portal : <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

Maharashtra Maritime Board (MMB), Mumbai, hereby invites bids from the eligible agencies for the following works :

Sl. No.	Name of Works	Date and Time
1	Selection of Agency for Grant of Advertisement Rights at Multiple Locations under Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Maintain (DBFOM) Model	29.09.2026 @1800 Hrs

Note :
• The tender shall be floated separately for each location. Bidders are requested to carefully examine the tender documents and location-specific details before submitting their bids.
• The complete tender document, including eligibility criteria, terms and conditions, scope of work, location details and other relevant information, shall be available for viewing and downloading on the Government of Maharashtra e-Tendering Portal at <https://mahatenders.gov.in> from 29.09.2026 at 18:00 Hrs to 19.10.2026 at 18:00 Hrs.
• MMB reserves the right to accept or reject any or all bids, in whole or in part, without assigning any reason thereof, and without thereby incurring any liability to the bidders.

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer,
Maharashtra Maritime Board, Mumbai.

Date : 29.09.2026
Place: Mumbai

DGIPR/2026-27/3042

Open E-Tender Notice
Date: 28.09.2026

Sr. DEN/COM/WCR, Bhopal acting for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tenders against following works, upto 15.30 hours on the dates mentioned against each tender. The complete tender documents and detail information regarding tender, is available on the website <http://www.irops.gov.in>. NIT can also be seen on the notice board of DRM (WY)WCR/Bhopal office. Manual offers are not allowed against these tenders. For any correction, in these tenders, if necessary, corrigendum will be uploaded on website prior to tender opening date and copy of corrigendum will be placed on Notice Board of this office, which may be seen upto the date of tender opening. Tenderers are requested to offer their rates and submit tenders according to the provisions of GST ACT 2017. NIT No. WCR-BPL-W- : 26 27-W-24-109, Date : 23/09/2026

Name of work including Location : Part A) GUANA-GWL Section:(i) Repairs to approach road of Mohana Railway Colony. (ii) Construction of approach road for qtr. no. RB-11 to AB & 11 AB of BDWS railway colony under ADEEN SVPI. Part B) Construction of gummets for alight signal exchange by Points man at 30 locations as attached over Bhopal Division, Published cost of tender (Rs.): 7452469.94, Earnest Money : 149100.00, Completion period : 9 Months, Last date for submitting tender : 15/10/2026

Sr. DEN/W
West Central Railway, Bhopal

स्वच्छ भारत अभियान
एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

EAST COAST RAILWAY

e-Tender Notice No. ETCECONIBBS 2026033, Dated : 24.09.2026

NAME OF WORK : EXECUTION OF EARTHWORK IN FORMATION, MINOR BRIDGES, MAJOR BRIDGES, STATION BUILDINGS, SERVICE BUILDINGS, P-WAY LINKING WORK, BALLAST SUPPLY, PLATFORM WORK, PLATFORM SHELTER, DRAIN WORK, CAMPING FACILITIES, PROTECTION WORKS, TUNNEL BETWEEN CH : 116.205 KM TO CH : 116.415 KM, AND OTHER ALLIED WORKS BETWEEN BARKOTE(EX) (CH : 98.325 KM) - MAHULDIHA(EX) (CH : 117.525 KM) INCLUDING AMBAGAON YARD IN CONNECTION WITH TALCHER - BIMALAGARH NEW BG RAIL LINK PROJECT.

Approx. Cost of the Work : ₹ 43080.29 Lakh, EMD : ₹ 8.61,60,600/-, Completion Period of the Work : 24 (Twenty-four) Months.

Tender Closing Date & Time : At 1200 hrs. of 27.10.2026.

No manual offers sent by Post / Courier / Fax or in person shall be accepted against such e-tenders even if these are submitted on firm's letter head and received in time. All such manual offers shall be considered invalid and shall be rejected summarily without any consideration.

Complete information including e-tender documents of the above e-tender is available in website : www.irops.gov.in

Note : The prospective tenderers are advised to visit the website 15 (Fifteen) days before the date of closing of tender to note any changes / corrigenda issued for this tender. The tenderers/bidders must have Class-III Digital Signature Certificate and must be registered on IREPS Portal. Only registered tenderer/bidder can participate on e-tendering.

The tenderers should read all instructions to the tenderers carefully and ensure compliance of all instructions including check lists, para 3.1 (additional check-list) of Tender form (Second sheet) Annexure-I of chapter 2 of Tender documents, submission of Annexure-BIG & G1 duly verified and signed by Chartered Accountant.

Chief Administrative Officer (Con)/ PR-212/CJ/26-27
Bhubaneswar

indianexpress.com

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For the Indian Intelligent.

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FROM ANYTHING TO EVERYTHING.

EDUCATION ADMISSION

HOLY SPIRIT INSTITUTE OF NURSING EDUCATION

Holy Spirit Hospital & Research Centre, M. C. Road, Andheri (E), Mumbai - 400 093.
M: 7738466863, Tel: 28242774, 28248500 Ext. 820/821
Email: holyspiritcon@gmail.com
Website: www.holyspirit.collegeofnursing.org

ADMISSION

Under 15% Institutional Quota Seats available - 4 Nos.

Applications are invited for Admissions to First year B.Sc. Nursing Course from female unmarried candidates who have registered with state CET Cell and appeared for MH Nursing CET 2026 as well as eligible as per MH Nursing CET information Brochure.

Apply before 06/10/2026 upto 3:30 pm

Display of Merit List on 06/10/2026 at 4:00 pm

0071063233-1

RECRUITMENT

SITUATION VACANT

Utilize your Experience, Talent & skill. Work Independently to generate passive income and grow your wealth. Age : 50+ . Call: 9867769036.

0071032565-11

PART TIME JOB

Required Retired/ VRS Seniors Age 40+ to work with Govt Registered Company. Wonderful Package, Promotions , Foreign Conventions + Many. Call# 9324802959.

0071032563-6

BUSINESS

POULTRY

AMIR Broiler, Small: Rs. 168/-, Big: Rs. 162/-
Contact:- Phone: +91-8828895000 / 8080432388 / 022-25251901 / 022-23860517

0071057905-1

VENCOBB ExFarm Price (Pune Yesterday) : Rs. 130/- kg (Live)
Suggested Retail Price : Rs. 226/- kg (Dressed, without Skin)

0071058075-1

S.K. Patel Small: 170/-, Big: 162/- . 8082040343/ 24460095/ 24459098. To subscribe to paper rate & purchase rate. 9320460095/ 9930193010.

0071063271-1

Mumbai Eggs Association Today Suggestive Farm-gate eggs price for today 01/10/2026 Rs. 615/- per 100 Eggs : 9820057700/ 9820351822/ 7303390009.

0071061789-1

ZORABIAN Today's Ex-Farm Live Broiler Rate Rs. 128/- Retail Market Rate Rs. 162/- Mobile : 8879050887/ 9372663242 Office : 022-26604937/ 38/ 39.

0071061156-1

NECC Mumbai Zone suggestive farm-gate egg price for today 01/10/2026 is Rs. 605/- per 100 eggs (for the information of trade & industry)

0071061533-1

PROPERTY

ESTATE & PROPERTY

PROPERTY IN PUNE - FOR LEASE. Prime 1,200 sq. ft. space, Koregaon Park, PUNE. Mezzanine floor above German Bakery, facing O Hotel, North Main Road, near Osho Ashram. Square, Vastu - compliant. Ideal for jewellers, designer boutiques, clinics, salons, premium brands. Call Sidhu: +91 94235 75354

0040880657-2

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Army No-1084664M, Rank - HAV, Name - basant babaji povlekar, Resident of Kolad, Tal- Roha, Dist-Raigad Maharashtra PIN-402304 have change my name from Basant Babaji Pavlekar to Vasant Babaji Povalekar, vide affidavit, Dt-02-09-2026.

0071063235-1

I, Kamal, widow of Ex - Nb Sub, Dnyanu Karande, S.No. JC110954L R/o. A/501, Bhumiiraj Meadows, Sector 19, Airoli, Navi Mumbai, Dist. Thane - 400708 (Maharashtra), have changed my Name from Kamal to Kamal Dnyanu Karande & DOB from Not Recorded to 01/06/1954 vide Affidavit.

0071063230-1

Our Counters will remain closed on Friday, 02-10-2026 on account of "Gandhi jayanti "
Advertisers may please take note of the same.

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Mumbai Building Repair & Reconstruction Board Special Land Acquisition Office											
Special Land Acquisition officer, Gruhanirman Bhavan, Room No.337, Second Floor, Kalanagar, Bandra(East) Mumbai-51 Telephone No. 022-66405218							Date: 30/09/2026				
Out H./SLAO/MBRRB)9881797/2026											
Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Act 1976 section 93(3) & Section 93 (4)											
NOTICE											
Read -	1) Housing Dept. Guidelines by G. R. Govt. of Maharashtra Vimanka-2019/P. No.148(Part-1) / RR-1 dated 22/08/2023.										
	2) Govt. Resolution No. Land Acq. 2025/Prop. No.23/RR- Dated 04/12/2025.										
	3) Proposal by Executive Engineer/F (South) Division M.B.R.&R. Board Outward No. 1) EE/F-(South) division/DE-3/ E-2969858/2026 dated- 06.01.2026 and 2)EE/ F(South) division/ DE-3/ON. 000003/2026 Dated 14/1/2026.										
	4) Govt. Shuddhipatpra Resolution No. Land Acq. 2025/Prop. No.23/RR-1 Dated14.08.2026.										
	The property situated at C.S.no.181, Parel- Siwari division, Building no.62/63, T.J.Marg, Mumbai 15, Cess No. FS-1117[2] and 1117[3] known as K. K. Modi chawl for which NOC for redevelopment granted vide letter No. R/NOC/F 392/599/MBR&R Board, Dated 02/02/1998 by Chief Officer/MBR&R Board. Then revised NOC was issued vide letter No. R/NOC/F 392/3907/MBR&R Board, Dated 30/04/2016. And again re- revised NOC was issued on Dated 31.07.2019 and was again extended on Dated 19/01/2023.										
	Then NOC was cancelled by The Chief Officer /MBR&R Board vide letter No. R/Cancellation NOC/F-392/8213/2024 dated 06.09.2024 due to the failure to start the work of rehab building.										
	And whereas Vice President and CEO/MHADA in respect of the said land submitted proposal to the Department of Housing, Govt. of Maharashtra dated 11/04/2025 for approval of land acquisition of said land as per 91 A section of MHAD Act 1976 for issue of clearance and compulsory acquisition.										
	And where as the Govt. of Maharashtra approved the said acquisition proposal under MHAD Act 1976 section 91(A) and 93(1) for area 9592.93 Sq.m. of said property C.S.no.181 and 186 vide Govt. Resolution No. Land Acq. 2024/Prop. No.23/RR-1 dated 04/12/2025. After sending proposal to delete C.S. no.186, Govt. has issued corrigendum for C.S. no.181 and area 9701.98 sqmtrs. on dated 14/08/2026.										
	Now in exercise of the powers conferred under section 93(3) & 93(4) of the said act, I Gopinath Thombre, Special Land Acquisition Officer, Mumbai Building Repair and Reconstruction Board give notice that the Govt. of Maharashtra has approved the said acquisition proposal vide Govt. Resolution No. Land Acq. 2025/ Prop. No.23 /RR-1 dated 4.12.2025 and the corrigendum issued vide Govt. Resolution No. Land Acq. 2024/ Prop. No.23/RR-1 dated- 14/08/2026. Now the said land must be vacated within 15 days from the date on which the clearance and compulsory acquisition order which may be issued by Special Land Acquisition Officer, Mumbai Building Repair and Reconstruction Board, Mumbai under sub section (5) of section 93 of the said act become operative. The alternate accommodation shall be provided as per the availability and only after receiving application from the Tenants /Occupants.										
	The Occupiers, Owner, Developer, Lessee and Mortgagors (if any) of the said land are here by called upon to submit objections and suggestions in duplicate, if any, to the acquisition proposal and why the said land with the existing building there on, (if any) should not be acquired, so as to reach at the office of the Executive Engineer, F South Div, MBRR Borad, Sunshine Plaza, 2nd floor Mumbai Marathi Sangrahalaya Marg, Dadar [East], Mumbai-14 or Special Land Acquisition Officer/RR Board, Room No. 337 Second Floor Gruhnirman Bhavan, Bandra East, Mumbai - 51 on or before dated 23/10/2026.										
Note - The acquisition proposal as approved by Govt. is kept open for inspection to the public in the office of Executive Engineer, F-South, M.B.R.&R Board, Sunshine Plaza, 2nd floor, Mumbai Marathi Sangrahalaya Marg, Dadar [E], Mumbai-14 And Special Land Acquisition Officer/RR Board, Room No. 337 Second Floor Gruhnirman Bhavan, Bandra East, Mumbai -51 during office hours except Saturday, Sunday and other Public holidays.											
SCHEDULE 'A'											
Land measuring approximately 9701.98 Sq.m. C.S. No.181, Parel - Siwari division, Building No. 62/63, T. J.Marg, Cess No. FS-1117 [2],1117 [3] Mumbai-15. Known as Modi Wani chawl.											
Date: 30.9.2026											
sd/- (Gopinath Thombre) Special Land Acquisition Officer Mumbai Building Repair and Reconstruction Board Mumbai -51.											
SCHEDULE 'B'											
Certified list of Tenants/ Occupants.											
Chawl No. (1)	Room No. (2)	Floor (2a)	Sr. No. (3)	Name of Tenant as per Rent Receipt (4)	Name of Occupant as per Ration Card (5)	Name of Occupant as per Elec. City-Bill (6)	Name of Tenant/ Occupant with whom Agreement for Redevelopment (7)	Users R/NR (8)	Carpet Area (9)	Built up area (10)	Remark (11)
1	1	Gr. Fl.	1	Tukaram Varange	Smt. Rajashri Shridhar	Tukaram V.Varange	Shridhar Tukaram Varange	R	11.06	14.49	Certified True Copy
1	2	"	2	Sridhar Tukaram Warange	Shridhar Tukaram Warange	Shridhar Tukaram Warange	Sridhar Tukaram Warange	R	11.06	13.05	-
1	3	"	3	Shailenshing Govind Thakur	Latabai Hanumant Wagh	Latabai Hanumant Wagh	Latabai Hanumant Wagh	R	11.06	13.05	
1	4	"	4	Dattaram Shripat Ayare	Mohan Dattaram Ayare	D.S.Ayare	Dattaram Shripat Ayare	R	11.05	13.05	
1	5	"	5	Ghanshyam Raghunath	Sulochana Ghanshyam Narvekar	G.R.Narvekar	Sulochana Ghanshyam Narvekar	R	11.06	13.05	
1	6	"	6	Parshuram Bhau Nagap	Akaram Bhau Nagap	Akaram B. Nagap	Nagap Tukaram Bhau	R	11.06	13.05	
1	7	"	7	Ramaji Bhikaji Rane	Bhikaji Ravji Rane	B.R.Rane	Bhikaji Ravji Rane	R	11.06	13.05	
1	8	"	8	Babu Chavan	Dattaram Babu Chavan	D.B.Chavan	Dattaram Babu Chavan	R	11.06	13.05	
1	9	"	9	Sujan Govind Wadekar	Vithoba Ramchandra Wadekar	Ramchandra G. Wadekar	Vithoba Ramchandra Wadekar	R	11.06	13.05	
1	10	"	10	Surve Shivaram Ganpat	Shivaram Ganpat Surve	Kashiram A.Surve	Surve Shivaram Ganpat	R	11.05	14.49	
1	11 & 12	"	11	Arjun Mahadeo Joshi	Indira Arjun Joshi	Arjun Mahadeo Joshi	Indira Arjun Joshi	R	22.5	30.45	
1	13	"	12	Krishnaji Agwale	Ashok Krishna Parab	Radhika K. Agwale	Prab Ashok Krishna	R	11.06	13.05	
1	14	"	13	Kashiram Ganaji Sawant	Subhadra Kashiram Sawant	Kashiram G. Sawant	Sawant Subhadra Kasiram	R	11.06	13.05	
1	15	"	14	Yashwant Arjun Jambe	Yashwant Tawade	Y.A.Tawade	Tawade Jaywanti Yeshwant	R	11.06	13.05	Death Certificate Submitted.
1	16	"	15	Manohar Pandurang Ghugare	Dattaram Laxman Chavan	Yashwant A.Tawade	Saraswati Dattaram Chavan	R	11.06	13.05	
1	17	"	16	Krishna Shivaram	Laxmibai Krishna Kuwalekar	L.K.Kuwalekar	Lilawati Tukaram Nagap	R	11.06	13.05	Affidavit submitted.
1	18	"	17	Krishna Tukaram	Phutak Anant Ganpat	K.T.Phutak	Phutak Anant Ganpat	R	11.06	13.05	
1	19	"	18	Dattaram Tukaram Parab	Satyavijay Dattaram Parab	D.T.Parab	Satyavijay Dattaram Parab	R	11.06	13.05	
1	20	"	19	Keshav Mahadeo Shriyat	Keshav Mahadeo Malap	K.M.Malap	Malap Keshav Mahadeo	R	11.06	13.05	
1	21	1st	20	Ganpat Deovaka	Ganpat Deovakas Varose	G.D.Varose	Varose Ganpat Deoka	R	11.06	14.49	
1	22	"	21	Saraswati Ganpat Raut	Ganpat Ganpat Raut	Saraswati Ganpat Raut	Saraswati Ganpat Raut	R	11.06	14.11	
1	23	"	22	Balu Raaghu Padwal	Chandrakant Balu Padwal	Balu Raghu Padwal	Padwal Chandrakant Balu	R	11.06	12.91	
1	24	"		Jewantibai Mahadeo	Patil Chandrabhaga Yashwant	Manohar Y.Patil	Chandrabhaga Yeshwant Patil	R	11.06	12.91	
1	25	"			Sawant Laxman Gangaram	L.G.Sawant	Sawant Laxman Gangaram	R	11.06	12.91	
1	26	"	25	Govind Bhimaji Rane	Smt.Radhika Govind Rane	Govind Bhimaji Rane	Radhabai Govind Rane	R	11.06	12.91	
1	27	"	26	Ratnabai Shivaram	Bendale Dattaram Rambhau	Dattaram R. Bendale	Bendale Dattaram Rambhau	R	11.06	12.91	
1	28	"	27	Kamana Nagaji Patil	Kamana Nagaji Patil	Kamana N.Patil	Patil Kamana Nagaji	R	11.06	21.91	
1	29	"	28	Babu Laxman Thakur	Dinkar Vasudeo Thakur	Vasudeo Babu Thakur	Thakur Vasudeo Babu	R	11.06	12.91	
1	30	"	29	Ganpat Govind Pawar	G.G.Pawar	Ganpat G.Pawar	Ganpat Govind Pawar	R	11.06	12.91	
1	31	"	30	Ramchandra B.Humane	Humane Raghunath Arjun	Ramchandra R. Humane	Humane Raghunath Arjun	R	11.06	14.11	
1	32 & 33	"	31	Atmaram Mahadev	Narkar Satyavati Atmaram	Atmaram N.Narkar	Narkar Satyavati Atmaram	R	22.5	29.46	
1	34	"	32	Saku Ram Tasu	More Madhu Somaji	More Madhu Somaji	More Madhu Somaji	R	11.06	12.91	
1	35	"	33	Koyanabai Ramchandra Chalke	Koyanabai R. Chalke	Koyanabai R. Chalke	Sunil Manohar Bane	R	11.06	12.91	Affidavite Submitted.
1	36	"	34	Tukaram Dondu Sawant	Sumittra Shripat Surve	Sumittra Shripat Surve	Surve Sumittra	R	11.06	12.91	
1	37	"	35	Keru Babaji Pawar	Pawar Keru Babaji	Pawar Keru Babaji	Pawar Keru Babaji	R	11.06	12.91	
1	38	"	36	Tukaram Atmaram	Tukaram Atmaram Amkar	Tukaram Atmaram Amkar	Amkar Tukaram Atmaram	R	11.06	12.91	
1	39	"	37	Laxman Ramchandra	Mangala Bapu Tawade	Mangala Bapu Tawade	Tawade Mangala Bapu	R	11.06	12.91	
1	40	"	38	Kasibai Tukaram	Vasant Babu Masye	Kashibai Phatak	Phatak Kasibai Tukaram	R	11.06	12.91	
1	41	"	39	Narayan Laxman Kautkar	Kautkar Sunil Narayan	Narayan L.Kautkar	Kawatkar Narayan Laxman	R	11.06	12.91	
1	42	1st	40	Mahadev M.Btavan	Rajaram Tukaram Shivdakar	Mahadev N. Pokarankar	Parvatibai Mahadev Pokarankar	R	11.06	14.11	
1	43	"	41	Anandibai Bhikaji Maske	Ramakant Shivaram Ajivkar	Ramakant Sitaram Ajivkar	Ajavilkar Ramakant Sitaram	R	11.06	13.73	
1	44	"	42	Vithal Bhaushe Devrukhkar	Devrikhar Vithal	Vithal B. Devrukhar	Devrukhar Gajanan Vithal	R	11.06	12.76	
1	45	"	43	Naresh Sakharam Iyre	Naresh Sakharam Ayre	A.N.Sakharam	Naresh Shakharam Ayare	R	11.06	12.76	
1	46	"	44	Maruti Bai Valkar	---	---	---	R	11.06	12.76	Document not shown.
1	47	"	45	Laxmibai Pandurang More	Laxmibai Pandurang More	Pandurang G.More	More Laxmibai Pandurang	R	11.06	12.76	
1	48	"	46	Prakash Narayan Panchal	Prakash Narayan Panchal	Prakash Narayan Panchal	Panchal Prakash Narayan	R	11.06	12.76	
1	49	"	47	Indirabai Sahadev	Indirabai S. Kadam	Indirabai Sahadev	Kadam Indirabai Sahadev	R	11.06	12.76	
1	50	"	48	Satyavan Sadashiv Waigankar	Satyavan Sadashiv Waigankar	S.S.W					

Shah: Punjab will be ‘chitta-mukt’ by Dec 31, 2029



Union Home Minister Amit Shah with drug-affected families in Jalandhar on Wednesday. EXPRESS

AAP hits back: BJP must begin yatra from Gujarat

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Jalandhar, September 30

SETTING A DEADLINE for one of the BJP's biggest political promises in Punjab, Union Home Minister Amit Shah Wednesday said the state would be made "chitta-mukt" by December 31, 2029. He also assured mothers and youth that after that date, chitta would neither be sold in Punjab nor be allowed to leave the state. Addressing the concluding rally of the BJP's 13-day 'Nasha Mukht Punjab Yatra' in Jalandhar, Shah said there were several issues beyond Punjab, including farming, women's security, industry and employment, but added that the party intends to

make "chitta-mukt Punjab" its main poll issue for campaigning for the 2027 Assembly election. However, the ruling AAP hit back at the BJP and asked Shah to explain the seizure of 526 kg of heroin and methamphetamine worth over Rs 3,000 crore in an operation involving the Gujarat ATS and Indian Coast Guard. "Amit Shah came to Punjab today to give lectures on drugs. At the same time, 526 kg of heroin and methamphetamine worth over Rs 3,000 crore has been seized in an operation in which Gujarat ATS provided the intelligence. We have been saying that Gujarat has emerged as a major gateway for drugs in the country. This seizure once again shows the scale of the problem. If Amit Shah is serious about Nasha Mukht Bharat, he should start his Nasha Mukht Yatra from Gujarat, not Punjab," the AAP said in a statement.

BIG PUSH TOWARDS 900 GW NON-FOSSIL CAPACITY BY 2035, SAYS PM

Eye on transmission bottlenecks, Cabinet clears green energy plan

Green Energy Corridor Ph-III: Evacuation of 135 GW renewable energy across states, first dedicated battery storage component

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, September 30

THE UNION Cabinet on Wednesday approved the Green Energy Corridor Phase-III (GEC-III) scheme, aimed at enabling the evacuation of up to 135 gigawatts (GW) of renewable energy across states. The scheme, with a total outlay of Rs 1,86,405 crore and targeted for completion by FY 2032-33, is aimed at tackling a festering problem in India's power sector — even as peak power demand has been surging to record highs, grid operators have been forced to curtail electricity generated by solar power sources due to transmission bottlenecks. Along with the development of the intra-state transmission system (InSTS), the scheme, for the first time under the GEC programme, includes a dedicated battery energy storage component, with provisions for deploying 50 GWh (gigawatt-hour) of Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) at renewable energy developer/generator sites or other locations of importance to the grid. As per the government, the storage capacity is intended to address intermittency, transmission congestion and peak-hour curtailment, while helping meet demand during non-solar hours. In a post on X,



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw during the Cabinet briefing in New Delhi on Wednesday. ANIL SHARMA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said: "Cleaner power. Stronger grids. More opportunities. The Cabinet decision on the Green Energy Corridor Phase-III will ensure: 135 GW renewable energy evacuation; 50 GWh battery storage; stronger power grids across States and UTs; more jobs in manufacturing, construction and energy storage; big push towards 900 GW non-fossil capacity by 2035." Of the total outlay, Rs 1,36,378 crore has been earmarked for developing intra-state transmission systems, while Rs 50,000 crore has been allocated for 50 GWh of BESS. The scheme will involve total central financial support of Rs 54,082 crore. "The central financial assis-

tance (CFA) will help in offsetting the intra-state transmission charges and thus keep the power costs down. Thus, the government support will ultimately benefit the end users — the citizens of India," the government said. In another decision related to the energy sector, the Union Cabinet approved the continuation of the targeted subsidy of Rs 300 per 14.2 kg domestic cooking gas cylinder for beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) for FY 2026-27. The subsidy, which will be prorated for 5 kg cylinders, is estimated to lead to an expenditure of Rs 12,001 crore. As on September 1, the country had 10.57 crore PMUY beneficiaries.

Govt approves MSPs for rabi crops, wheat hike at 17-year-low

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, September 30

THE CENTRE announced Minimum Support Prices (MSPs) for six rabi crops for the 2027-28 season on Wednesday, with wheat — India's second-largest crop by acreage — receiving a 17-year-low hike of just Rs 25 per quintal, a marginal 0.97% increase. The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) made the decision "to ensure remunerative prices to the growers for their produce," a statement read. The MSP of wheat is fixed at Rs 2,610 per quintal. The Rs 25 hike in the wheat MSP is the lowest in absolute terms since 2010-11. Last year, the government had hiked the MSP for wheat by 6.6% to Rs 2,585 per quintal. On this marginal hike, Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Shrivraj Singh Chouhan said, "Wheat stocks are overflowing. We possess many times the amount actually required. Justice will be done to the farmers. Productivity for crops like pulses is very low, and efforts are being made to encourage their cultivation." The approved MSP is 106% of the cost of cultivation per quintal of wheat, Chouhan said. The average annual area under wheat cultivation stood at 31.52

million hectares over the past five years. The modest increase in wheat MSP this year is significant, especially given that major wheat-producing states, such as UP and Punjab, hold their assembly elections early next year. Wheat is one of the six officially mandated rabi crops in India under the government's MSP system. The others are safflower, rapeseed and mustard, lentil, barley, and gram. The MSP of rapeseed and mustard for the 2027-28 season is fixed at Rs 6,613 per quintal, up by Rs 413, or 6.66%, from Rs 6,200 per quintal last year; and lentil (masur), at Rs 7,390 per quintal, up by Rs 390, or 5.57%, from Rs 7,000 last year. The MSP of barley is at Rs 2,286 per quintal, up by Rs 136, or 6.33%, from Rs 2,150 per quintal announced last year; and gram, at Rs 5,958 per quintal. Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that the government's procurement in the upcoming season will be 324 lakh tonnes and that farmers will receive Rs 90,962 crore in MSP across the six rabi crops. In a separate development, Chouhan approved the procurement worth Rs 5,547.99 crore at MSP under the Price Support Scheme for the Kharif season 2026-27 in UP, Karnataka and Telangana.

Girl Veeramani sexually abused in 2004 died by suicide: Police



Veeramani has been booked for abetment of suicide.

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, September 30

THE SPECIAL Investigation Team probing sexual abuse allegations against granite baron R Veeramani, 84, is preparing to file its first charge-sheet within days, even as the Chennai police have now booked him for allegedly abetting the suicide of a minor girl more than two decades ago. "We hope to file the charge-sheet within two weeks," a senior police officer said, referring to the first POCSCO case, registered in October 2025. The 2004 death surfaced during the investigation after police accessed a message allegedly sent by co-accused Shanthi, 60, to Veeramani, asking whether he remembered his involvement in the death of a girl. A special team traced the girl's family, after which her mother lodged a complaint alleging that Veeramani had sexually abused her daughter and that the girl later died by suicide. The mother also told investigators that the family had approached the local police at the time, but no action was taken. Police have now booked Veeramani for abetment of suicide and invoked provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act against him, Shanthi and others. Investigators are also verifying information that Rs lakh was paid to the girl's family or relatives on two occasions. The expanding investigation comes a month after Veeramani, Shanthi and her husband, Mahendra Simhan, 63, were arrested on August 29 in the original case. That investigation began on October 7, 2025, after an NGO volunteer gave the Anti-Vice Squad a pen drive containing a video purportedly showing Veeramani sexually assaulting a minor. Police initially sought to close the case after saying they could not identify the girl, but a Special POCSCO Court rejected the closure report and ordered further investigation.

Monsoon ends with 13 per cent rain deficit, driest year in a decade

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, September 30

THE MONSOON season ended on Wednesday with a 13 per cent deficit in overall rainfall, the largest in more than a decade. India Meteorological Department (IMD) said rainfall over the country as a whole during the four-month monsoon season was 87 per cent of long-period average, or LPA. In quantitative terms, India received 759.4 mm of rainfall against the LPA of 868.6 mm. LPA is the average rainfall received in the monsoon season over the 50-year period between 1971 and 2020. The 13 per cent deficit makes this monsoon the driest in 11 years, the fourth driest in this century, and the 13th driest



Even as seasonal rain was reportedly below normal, several regions like Ghatat Town, in Paschim Medinipur in West Bengal, reported flooding following heavy rain. ANI

since 1901. The last time seasonal rainfall fell below 90 per cent of LPA was in 2015, which was also affected by a strong El Nino in the

equatorial Pacific Ocean. El Nino, which refers to an abnormal warming of surface waters in the equatorial Pacific Ocean, is known to suppress rainfall over India. The opposite phase, La Nina, when the surface waters are cooler than normal, generally favours good rainfall. This year, the developing El Nino is expected to turn into the strongest ever. In the last ten years, there have been only two occasions when the monsoon rain has dropped below normal (96 to 104 per cent of LPA). In 2017, India had received 95 per cent rain while the following year it was 91 per cent. Punjab, Assam, Meghalaya and Arunachal Pradesh recorded deficient rainfall throughout this season, while parts of Marathwada, Vidarbha, north Karnataka experienced prolonged dry spells through July, August and September, IMD officials said.

'IDENTIFYING CITIZENS NECESSARY'

Amid Census and SIR debate, RSS calls for nationwide NRC

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, September 30

AT A time when the political discourse is seized with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the Census is underway, the RSS on Wednesday called for a nationwide National Register of Citizens (NRC) and said that identifying citizens was necessary to address "population imbalance" and protect the country's "unity, integrity and security". Speaking at an event at the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts, RSS publicity in-charge Sunil Ambekar said there was a need to identify people who had been "wrongly included" in electoral rolls, and to ensure citizenship for those who



NRC is important to address population imbalance, protect unity and culture: RSS publicity in-charge Sunil Ambekar

had come to India from neighbouring nations under the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). "When solutions (to population imbalance) are discussed, it is said there should be a National Register of Citizens," he said, adding India's Partition happened

due to population imbalance. He argued that in our neighbouring countries that became Islamic states after 1947, many people who were left behind were from SC/ST and economically weaker sections and they continued to face persecution. "For those who have come back, ensuring their citizenship through CAA is necessary. Identifying such people through the NRC is necessary. If people have been wrongly included in the voter list, it is necessary to identify them," he said. Ambekar said objections to the exercise could be addressed through existing legal mechanisms, including courts, but argued that accepting a non-citizen as a citizen "for purely political reasons" would be wrong.

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KPSC

format, sources said. The test also found a 99 per cent chance that the 14 rank-holders had allegedly received leaked question papers before the exam. The probability test was conducted by the CID unit of Karnataka Police, which is probing the recruitment scam in which a middleman, Basavaraj Kannale, is alleged to have collected Rs 20 lakh to Rs 40 lakh from around 20 aspirants to provide the questions allegedly leaked on January 7 by KPSC exam controller Gynanendra Kumar Gangwar, an IAS officer. Gangwar was arrested on August 29 and Kannale four days later. None of the candidates has been arrested yet, with at least ten of them turning approvers after confessing to paying money for leaked questions. Under the test, a match of 95 percent or above indicates an exact link between the answer keys of the candidates concerned. The probability of fraud is considered statistically certain when values in the range of 99.6 percent or 100.0 percent are generated, sources said. Karnataka's CID unit had previously used the test to find candidates who got the same answers right and wrong in an investigation of top rankers in the sub-inspectors recruitment exam held by the police recruitment board in 2021. Three candidates were found with a 100 percent chance of having received external assistance — the case, with 52 accused, is under trial. Such tests are also commonly used by the Institute for Banking Personnel Selection to

detect cheating in banking exams. "These days artificial intelligence tools can be used to run probability tests to identify cheating in exams. In this case (veterinarians), the findings from the probability test have matched the investigations, with 10 candidates who finished in the top 14 ranks having already confessed to being part of a racket where they paid large amounts to access questions in advance," sources said. The four other candidates among the 14 in the exam had also allegedly obtained the leaked questions, the CID probe found, although they have not confessed to investigators. The KPSC withheld the results of the recruitment exam following the investigation, which is based on an FIR filed on July 24 against then KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukar and two other members by candidates alleging that they were wrongly denied selection to 400 posts announced in 2024. KPSC and Sahukar were at the centre of a series of investigative reports by The Indian Express on the recruitment scam, published earlier this month. This newspaper found that the scandals were part of a larger pattern of irregularities during the tenure of Sahukar, who was handpicked by the BJP for the KPSC in 2019 and shielded by the Congress, which came to power in Karnataka in 2023. The Indian Express also reported that the alleged irregularities flagged by job aspirants included marks withheld and top scorers targeted for bribes; interview panels manipulated; tabulation records altered; answer sheets tampered with; and ques-

tion papers leaked to select candidates. Sahukar was suspended on August 25 in a separate scam related to the illegal recruitment by KPSC of his own daughter. Probability test also shows that three other candidates, including an aspirant linked to Sahukar, may have received questions for the general proficiency paper, one of the two entrance test papers for January 9. What probability test found The key findings: ● The second, fourth, fifth, sixth, seventh, ninth and tenth rank holders in the main category had a 100 per cent match for the answers they got correct and wrong. The first, second and third rank holders in the backlog (pending exams) category also matched 100 per cent for answers in the two entrance papers. ● The test showed a 99 per cent match for the probability of cheating by the first, third, eighth and 12th rank holders in the main category. These rank holders did not confess to being part of the larger racket, but the CID investigation has corroborated the findings that the four candidates allegedly cheated in the two entrance papers, sources said. The findings featured in the Karnataka High Court on Tuesday during a plea for anticipatory bail by the candidate who obtained the third rank. The 29-year-old veterinary doctor secured 486.75 marks or 81.12 per cent in the exam despite being an "average student", Special Public Prosecutor B N Jagadeesh told the High Court. "Despite negative marking,

she has obtained 486 marks. In one paper, she attempted 95 questions and got 89 correct and six wrong. In another paper, she attempted 91 questions and got 83 right and eight wrong," the SPP said during arguments. "The analysis has found that the answers she got wrong are the same as the answers that other successful candidates (suspected of fraud) got wrong. She chooses the same questions and gets the same answers wrong. This raises suspicion," the High Court was informed. The SPP said that as many as 10 top rank holders turned approvers after confessing to being provided the questions before the exams on January 8 and 9, and had not been arrested as a result. The High Court questioned the state for not arresting the third rank candidate even though she was not considered an approver in the case, unlike the 10 others. The probe has found that the three candidates who obtained the top three ranks in the backlog category, and 11 who placed at the top of the main category, gained access to the questions for the entrance test before their exam. A total of 1400 candidates appeared for the exams for 400 vacancies, and 329 were selected, 56 in the backlog category and 273 in the main category. Sources said investigators suspect that Gangwar and Kannale may have leaked more questions to candidates who paid large amounts and fewer to those who may have "approached through other routes". Documents placed in the

High Court also show the marks scored by rank holders in the main and backlog categories — and the money allegedly paid for leaked papers: ● In the backlog category, the three top scorers scored 481.5 marks out of 600 (80.5 percent), 411.75 (68.62 percent) and 400.5 marks (66.75 percent), respectively. They allegedly paid a total of Rs 50 lakh to the middleman and his associates. ● In the main category, candidates who obtained the fourth, fifth, sixth and 13th ranks scored 483.75 marks (80.62 percent), 483 marks (80.5 percent), 471.5 (78.50 percent) and 443.25 marks (73.87 percent), respectively. They allegedly paid Rs 77 lakh between them for the leaked papers. The case documents also show that the top two rank holders in the main category scored 493.5 marks (82.25 percent) and 487.50 (81.25 percent), respectively. The second rank holder has confessed to cheating, case records show, while the first and third rank holders are under investigation. The seventh and tenth rank holders also allegedly paid undisclosed amounts and obtained 468.75 marks (78.12 percent) and 458.25 marks (76.37 percent), respectively. So far, the CID probe has found that at least 11 candidates paid bribes totalling Rs 1.52 crore to Kannale, the alleged middleman, to obtain the exam questions leaked by controller of exams Gangwar. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has also arrested Gangwar and Kannale in a related case of alleged money laundering. On Tuesday, the ED obtained 14 days of custody of Kannale.

Judge

claimed he had received "several complaints", which "raise doubts" about his "integrity". Based on this, Justice Mehta had sought the transfer of the acting CJ to another High Court and the appointment of a new Chief Justice. Later that month, the Supreme Court Collegium recommended Chhattisgarh High Court Judge Sanjay K Agarwal as the Chief Justice of Rajasthan High Court. This came hours after Sharma went on leave amid protests by lawyers. Speaking to The Indian Express, Sharma denied allegations of favouring influential litigants, manipulating rosters, interfering in inquiries or transferring judicial officers to benefit particular parties. He said a difference in functioning style doesn't automatically mean one is wrong, and defended his administrative record as Rajasthan's acting Chief Justice, citing pending promotions, transfers and increased funding. "I am surprised, if there is a complaint, would it not go to the Chief Justice (of India) first," Sharma said, adding that apart from submitting responses to Justice Mehta's four letters, he has also written to the CJ raising an issue with regard to whether a judge of the Supreme Court can interfere in the affairs of the High Court. "These kinds of issues, internally between the judges, have arisen several times earlier. But it has never come to the lime-light in the newspapers. Nobody goes to social media. There is a celebrated judgment of the Su-

preme Court, Prakash Chand versus State of Rajasthan, from 1997. The matter travelled to the SC, which laid down strict guidelines. Now all of us are bound by those strict guidelines; it binds me as well as a judge sitting in the Supreme Court," he said. "If he, as the SC judge, does not act accordingly, then some action should be taken against him also. I had a huge practice and left that just to give back whatever I have learnt. That is why I maintained that dignity... judges are not supposed to be tried on social media. The faith of the general people should not be affected," Sharma said. "If we start judging each other's working style, it is not done. And if you start saying in the media that this particular judge has doubtful integrity — as he said — and he has no concern, no business to say this. But he did it. Now what is its effect? Lawyers said that if a Supreme Court judge is saying that, then this means that this judge has doubtful integrity; they went on strike," he said. "For eleven and a half months into my tenure as the acting CJ, there was not even a single strike in Rajasthan, but he instigated them (lawyers). It doesn't matter. They didn't confirm me as Chief Justice; it was a stroke of luck that I got a chance to be the acting CJ of Rajasthan. And I took it as an opportunity to do something better for Rajasthan," he said. "I don't know from where he got the idea that my administrative capabilities are not up to the mark and that I should be transferred from here. I was amazed, because he has never been with me, we have not worked together, we were not to-

gether as lawyers. He was practising in Jodhpur and I was in Jaipur. As judges also, he was in Jodhpur and I was in Jaipur. Our field of work was also different because he was essentially in the criminal side and I was a constitutional lawyer. Then, for four years, he has been away from Rajasthan. How would he know about the problems here?" Sharma said. "What I finally say is judges should know their limits, where they should speak, where they should not. We are people who speak through our judgements; our judgements are tested. I have decided more than 88,000 cases in my short tenure of nine and a half years. I have decided cases which had long repercussions and have been upheld by the SC, whichever has been tested (by the SC)," he said. On why he believes the allegations were made by Justice Mehta, he claimed, "I have absolutely no idea. Might be simple professional jealousy. In 2011, both of us were elevated as senior advocates. I was elevated without moving an application; the entire full court selected me to become a senior advocate. He had applied, of course. And I am a first-generation lawyer. I have no one in my family background, and he comes from a reputed judicial family... Both of us were made senior advocates together, and when the issue came for elevation, he saw to it that I didn't become (Chief Justice). And this thing has its own play; judges are influenced by the family you come from." On the allegation that he was benefiting influential or rich litigants, Sharma said, "Who are they? There has to be some complaint from someone."

FRESH COMPLAINT AGAINST SIR DORABJI TATA TRUST

Tata Trusts file caveat with Charity Comm after Venu’s petition

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 30

TRIGGERED BY the complaint by Tata Sons Director Venu Srinivasan against Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and Noel Tata to Charity Commissioner, Tata Trusts have filed caveats with the commissioner’s office asking the body to hear them before giving any order.

This follows the letter written by Srinivasan, also a trustee of Tata Trusts, to the Commissioner’s office seeking “an immediate inquiry into the administration and governance of SDTT, including the appointment and continued status of the existing perpetual Trustees, and the basis upon which Noel Tata assumed and continues to hold the Chairmanship of Tata Trusts”. Earlier, Charity Commissioner’s office had issued an ex parte order restraining Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT) from holding meetings and taking decisions, a move that led to the postponement of Tata Sons AGM and prevented Tata Trusts from exercising its 66% voting rights in Tata Sons.

SRTT and SDTT together hold over 50% stake in Tata Sons. The Charity Commissioner is yet to announce its decision on the complaint filed by Srinivasan and another lawyer against SRTT five months ago. Srinivasan had sent a complaint — mainly pertaining to perpetual trustees and other



Venu Srinivasan has written to the Charity Commissioner seeking a probe into the administration and governance of SDTT. REUTERS

governance matters — against SRTT on April 28.

“The Trustees are exposing the Trust and its charitable corpus to potentially immense fiscal consequences by involving the Trust directly in commercial activities which may not be incidental to its charitable objects. Such conduct constitutes mismanagement of the affairs and property of SDTT and a breach of the duties owed by its Trustees,” Srinivasan said in his letter to the Charity Commissioner. “I respectfully request your office to: initiate an immediate inquiry into the administration and governance of SDTT, including the appointment and continued status of the existing perpetual Trustee, and the basis upon which Noel Tata assumed and continues to hold the Chairmanship of Tata Trusts, the circumstances surrounding the appointment of

Neville Tata and my exclusion from the relevant decision-making process and the involvement of SDTT and its Trustees in the commercial and strategic affairs of Tata Sons,” Srinivasan wrote. What has upset Srinivasan is that while Noel Tata is a perpetual trustee, Srinivasan has a three-year tenure, making him a “rebel” in the Tata Trusts ecosystem, according to an insider. “Tata Trusts themselves, acting through their Chairman and operating team, have assumed a direct role in identifying, negotiating and seeking implementation of substantial commercial transactions concerning Tata Sons. Such activities go materially against the charitable objects and obligations of the Trust. The tax consequences of such conduct are substantial,” Srinivasan wrote.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NUMBER OF FACTORY WORKERS IN INDIA ROSE 7% TO 1.67 CR

Factory wages rose 5% in FY25, but fell in Jharkhand

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 30

JHARKHAND WAS the only state whose factory workers were paid less, on average, in 2024-25 compared to the previous year, with government data released Wednesday showing wage per worker in the eastern state fell 5.2%. In contrast, factory wages rose 5.3% nationally to Rs 2.28 lakh in 2024-25, up from Rs 2.16 lakh in 2023-24, according to the Annual Survey of Industries.

To be sure, factory workers of Jharkhand are paid far more than the national average, with *The Indian Express*’s calculations showing that average wage in the state was Rs 3.04 lakh in 2024-25, third only to Sikkim’s Rs 4.06 lakh and Goa’s Rs 3.14 lakh.

In fact, wages in Jharkhand were the highest in 2022-23 and 2023-24, at Rs 3.17 lakh and Rs 3.2 lakh, respectively. As a result, the fall in 2024-25 seems to be a correction as high wages in the state attracted more workers.

In 2024-25, the number of factory workers employed in Jharkhand rose 9% to 2.08 lakh — even though the number of factories reduced by nine to 2,880. Meanwhile, the average wage in Jharkhand’s neighbour Bihar jumped 16.7% — the highest of any major state — to Rs 1.63 lakh in 2024-25. However, this was driven by a 2% fall in the number of workers to 1.15 lakh, with the number of factories edging up by 1% to 3,426.

The Annual Survey of Industries (ASI), conducted by the Ministry of Statistics and

• Factory wages, growth in best paying states



Programme Implementation (MoSPI), is one of the most important surveys in the country and covers the formal manufacturing sector. Its results provide insights into how the country’s — and each state’s — manufacturing industries are changing and are key in calculating the GDP and formulating government policy.

Worries in Gujarat?

The results of the 2024-25 ASI are based on inputs from 86,547 units, with MoSPI estimating that the number of factories in India rose 2.6% in 2024-25 to 2.7 lakh. In 2023-24, the number of factories had risen by 2.7%. As such, this is the first time in more than a decade that the number of factories has increased by more than 2% in successive years.

With 12.8%, Uttar Pradesh saw the largest increase in the number of factories in 2024-25 to 24,964. However, Tamil Nadu (41,221), Gujarat (33,084), and Maharashtra (27,379) were ahead in the number of factories. While Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra saw a 3% rise in

factories in 2024-25, Gujarat saw a 1% reduction.

These changes led to Uttar Pradesh raising its share of factories in the country by almost a full percentage point to 9.4%, the highest increase of any state in 2024-25. Meanwhile, Gujarat’s share fell the most — by 0.4 percentage points — to 12.4%.

Tamil Nadu continues to have the highest share of factories in the country, with the figure unchanged at 15.4%.

The story was similar in terms of the number of workers, with Uttar Pradesh seeing a 14% rise, second only to Haryana (15%) among major states. Tamil Nadu continues to have the highest number of factory workers in India, having seen a rise of 5% in 2024-25 to 26.1 lakh. At an all-India level, the number of workers increased 7.3% to 1.67 crore in 2024-25.

Uttar Pradesh also saw above-average wage growth of 6.7% in 2024-25, as did Maharashtra (6.1%) and Tamil Nadu (5.6%). In Gujarat, wages only rose 2%, less than half the all-India average of 5.3%.



US direct investment stock in India reached \$58.54 billion in 2024, a 3.37% decline from 2023. REUTERS

‘Economic nationalism, corruption are barriers to investment in India’

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 30

A NEW US Department of State report on the investment climate in India has said that India welcomes foreign direct investment (FDI), but US investors are encountering an environment balancing openness with “economic nationalism” and the risk of corruption in the regulatory system, which is posing a barrier to FDI.

“While India permits 100% FDI in most sectors without prior approval, India requires foreign investors — including wholly owned subsidiaries incorporated in India, paying Indian taxes, and maintaining an Indian workforce — to request governmental approval to invest in multi-brand retail trading, private banking, pharmaceuticals, defence, print and digital media and satellites,” the report said.

It also alleged that US businesses report actual corruption and the anticipation of potential corruption — particularly in

regulatory systems — as barriers to FDI, adding that US direct investment stock in India reached \$58.54 billion in 2024, a 3.37% decline from 2023. Weak investment has been a major worry for Indian policymakers. Data showed that India saw a jump in net FDI inflows in July.

‘Burdensome restriction’

The Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) restricts concurrent FDI and foreign portfolio investment (FPI) investments, creating a redundant and uniquely burdensome restriction that blocks independent funds within the same investment group from participating in initial public offerings (IPOs) if any affiliated fund holds pre-IPO FDI stakes — a safeguard rendered unnecessary by the existing 10% FPI cap and unmatched by any other major jurisdiction, the report said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NHAI inspects 17 under-construction projects

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, September 30

THE NATIONAL Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has taken up a special quality inspection of 17 under-construction projects across nine states, where the bid value was over 15% less than the estimated project cost.

Officials said the first round of inspection will be completed by year-end, and it will be re-inspected after six months to check the quality of works.

The aggressive bidding has remained a serious concern in the highway sector, where contractors quote prices below the

estimated cost to get the project, but it runs into multiple delays and substandard quality of work, leading to issues such as cave-in and structural damages.

The highway authority officials said the projects have been selected on the basis of three criteria: construction cost of over Rs 500 crore, tender discount of more than 15% and physical progress between 35% and 80%.

According to the officials, the inspections will be carried out by specialised teams led by 39 experienced and retired engineers from various government organisations.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

New efficiency norms: What will change for OEMs, small cars & SUVs

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 30

INDIA’S NEW fuel-efficiency rules for passenger vehicles will force carmakers to increasingly manage the efficiency of their entire vehicle portfolio, rather than individual models, from April 2027. The final Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE)-III framework, notified on September 29, has introduced a new formula to relax norms for smaller cars, while doing away with an earlier proposed special concession for the category, and gives electric vehicles the biggest compliance benefit.

The CAFE norms will apply from April 1, 2027, to March 31, 2032. They cover M1 category passenger vehicles manufactured or imported for sale in India. At the heart of the system

is a fleet-wide calculation: a manufacturer’s permitted fuel consumption is determined by the weighted average unladen weight of the vehicles it sells.

This means a carmaker selling a large number of lighter vehicles and one selling predominantly SUVs do not face exactly the same target. The heavier the average fleet, the higher the permitted fuel consumption.

An important change from earlier proposals is not just the broadening of a small-car concession provided in earlier draft. The underlying weight equation has also been altered. Earlier versions had used a lower reference weight (1,170 kg) and a steeper weight adjustment. The final formula uses 1,229 kg and a flatter annual multiplier. So the final framework does not create a separate regulatory category for cars

below 909 kg. Instead, the effect of vehicle weight is built into the broader fleet formula.

Small vs big car debate

The small-car question became one of the most contentious parts of the CAFE-III process because India’s market is dependent on compact, relatively light petrol cars — with carmaker Maruti Suzuki having an oversized presence in the small cars’ space. The treatment of small cars had emerged as one of the biggest points of contention during the drafting of CAFE-III. A September 2025 draft subsequently proposed an additional 3 g/km benefit for petrol cars weighing up to 909 kg. Some carmakers opposed the carve-out, arguing that it would disproportionately benefit a segment

dominated by the country’s largest car maker. However, now, the final rules do not give a separate 3 g/km benefit to cars below the 909-kg threshold. But that does not mean the final formula treats a small car and a large SUV identically. Weight remains central to the calculation. A lighter fleet has a lower permitted fuel-consumption figure, while a heavier fleet gets a higher one. The new norms have been welcomed by carmakers. “It is a comprehensive regulation arrived at after scientific data calculations and detailed stakeholder and inter-ministerial consultation with ambitious targets for energy efficiency improvement and CO2 reduction. The regulation recognizes the contribution of multiple powertrain technologies and

fuels encouraging multi-faceted R&D and innovation,” said Rahul Bharti, senior executive officer, corporate affairs, at Maruti Suzuki. “The norms provide a clear and predictable regulatory roadmap through a 3+2 year compliance block structure, enabling manufacturers to undertake long-term product and technology planning with greater certainty,” said Tarun Garg, MD and CEO, Hyundai Motor India. **EVs enjoys the edge**

The biggest powertrain-specific benefit in the final rules goes to battery-electric vehicles. However, the norms do open up multiple energy pathways for carmakers to balance out their overall fleet emissions.

“The framework recognises the contribution of renewable

and low-carbon fuels, including ethanol-blended petrol, biofuels and CBG, through the introduction of the Carbon Neutrality Factor. This provides manufacturers with an additional pathway for improving their fleet-level CAFE performance, alongside vehicle efficiency improvements and electrification. The provision supports India’s broader transition towards cleaner fuels while encouraging innovation across multiple technology pathways,” the Ministry of Power said in a statement. A battery-electric vehicle and a range-extended electric vehicle get a volume derogation factor of 3. In effect, one such vehicle contributes three times its actual sales volume when the manufacturer’s fleet performance is calculated. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• BRIEFLY

FY27 2nd half to be challenging: CEA Nageswaran

New Delhi: CEA V Anantha Nageswaran has said the second half of the current fiscal is going to be challenging as downside risks to global growth have increased and interest rates are rising across the world. He also said the 7.8% GDP growth in the April-June quarter is based on “credible and reliable data”. PTI

Interest rates on small savings schemes for Q3 unchanged

New Delhi: The government on Wednesday left interest rates unchanged for various small savings schemes, including PPF and NSC, for the tenth straight quarter, beginning October 1, 2026. “The rates of interest on various Small Savings Schemes for the third quarter of FY 2026-27, starting from October 1, 2026, and ending on December 30, 2026, shall remain unchanged from those notified for the second quarter (July 1, 2026, to September 30, 2026) of FY 2026-27,” the Finance Ministry said. PTI

Geojit Financial gets new MD & Executive Chair

Mumbai: Geojit Financial Services Ltd, one of India’s leading investment services companies, has appointed CJ George as its Executive Chairman and Jones George as Managing Director, effective October 1, 2026, as part of its long-term succession plan. The transition was approved by the Board of Directors during the meeting of the Board on 22 July 2026. ENS

Windfall tax on diesel & ATF exports slashed

New Delhi: The government on Wednesday cut the windfall gains tax on export of diesel and ATF, while retaining it at the same level for petrol for the fortnight beginning October 1. The rate of special additional excise duty (SAED) along with road and infrastructure cess on export of diesel will now be Rs 16 per litre, down from Rs 20 a litre. SAED on export of ATF is set at Rs 10.5 per litre, as against Rs 15 per litre currently. PTI

Apple Pay enters India in tie-up with Axis Bank

Nameera Anjum
New Delhi, September 30

APPLE DEBUTED its payment service, Apple Pay in India on Wednesday, 12 years after it was first launched in the US, with Axis Bank-issued Visa and Mastercard credit cards available on the platform initially.

“India is home to a dynamic and digitally savvy population that continues to embrace a cashless future while expecting the highest standards of security and privacy, and we’re excited to bring Apple Pay to users in India today,” said Jennifer Bailey, Apple’s Vice President of Apple Pay and Apple Wallet.

Axis Bank, the country’s fourth-largest credit-card issuer, had 16.29 million credit cards outstanding in August, according to Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data. HDFC Bank had 27.10 million cards, while

ICICI Bank had 19.83 million.

The potential market size is significant. India had 124.05 million credit cards outstanding in August, while credit-card spending stood at about Rs 2.02 lakh crore during the month, according to RBI data.

Axis Bank Chief Executive Officer (CEO) and Managing Director (MD) Amitabh Chaudhry said, “As payments become increasingly embedded in customers’ everyday digital lives, our focus is on bringing together innovation and trust, while making every interaction more intuitive and relevant.”

Moreover, fintech platform PayU also brought Apple Pay under its merchant network. This will allow merchants to offer customers a secure, contactless and seamless payment experience online, in-app and in-store. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• MARKETS

			
Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
72,480.29	22,620.45	1,47,888	₹95.83
-48.78	-95.75		
-0.07%	-0.42%	Silver	Oil
		₹2,20,435	\$116.52

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

अजमेर विकास प्राधिकरण, अजमेर
अजमेर शहर, विभिन्न मण्डल, अजमेर, Email :- ajmerada@gmail.com
Website :- www.rajasthan.gov.in/ada, Tel.No. :- 0145-2627748-2627749

क्रमांक :- अजिपा/0.2/रकसीकी/2026-27/राजकाज 24726731 दिनांक :- 27/09/2026

E-TENDER - 26/2026-27

Bids for Construction of Spiritual Center at Swami Vivekanand Smarak in Kotra, Ajmer amounting Rs. 300.00 Lacs for are invited from interested bidder for upto 21.10.2026, 6:00 pm. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>) & (<http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) <http://www.urban.rajasthan.gov.in/ada> departmental website.

UBN No. : **AJD2627WSOB00151**
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10938

Executive Engineer

CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
(A NAVRATNA UNDERTAKING OF GOVT. OF INDIA)

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
CONCOR invites E-Tender in Single Packet System of tendering for the following work:-

Tender No.	CON/Area-III/EP/ICD-WFD/WH-F/E-964267/1/2026-27
Name of Work	Providing Fire Fighting System and Fire Alarm System at ICD-Whitefield, including Construction of Pump Room
Estimated Cost	Rs.820.43 Lakhs(Including GST)
Completion Period	15 (Fifteen)Months
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs. 16,40,900/- (through e-payment)
Cost of Tender Document	NIL
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable)	Rs.3540/- (inclusive all taxes & duties through e-payment)
Date of sale of Tender (online)	01.10.2026 (from 15:00 hrs.) to 27.10.2026 (up to 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of Submission of Tender (online)	28.10.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online)	29.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

For financial eligibility criteria, experience with respect to similar nature of work, etc, please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concorindia.com, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderwizard.com/CIL only. Further, Corrigendum / Addendum to this tender, if any, will be published on website www.concorindia.com, www.tenderwizard.com/CIL and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall not be issued for the same.

Group General Manager (Projects)
Phone No.: 011-41222500

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान
No. :- F-2(01)Acct/Contract/2026-27/181-183 Date :- 25/09/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या : 48/2026-27

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उदयपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यें मय डिफेक्ट लाईबिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदको से निधरित प्रपत्र में ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

निविदा कार्य की कुल लागत	रुपये 571.30 लाख (11 करोड़)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड / अपलोड करने की अवधि	28.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 22.10.2026 को सायं: 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथि	28.09.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 22.10.2026 को सायं: 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथि	23.10.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे

विरतुत विवरण वेबसाईट urban.rajasthan.gov.in/uitudaipur, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in व www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
UBN No. :- ITU2627WSOB00285 TO ITU2627WSOB00295

अतिरिक्त अधिकृत - पतुर्द
उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण

कम सायं/दि/26/10976

SUGARFED PUNJAB
(The Punjab State Federation of Cooperative Sugar Mills Ltd.)
Plot No. 53, Phase-II (Opposite Bassi Cinema), S.A.S Nagar (Mohali)

E-tender Notice-2026-27

3375142Nos. of food grade High Density Polyethylene HDPE/ Polypropylene (PP) Woven coloured Sacks (with liner for packing 50 Kg. Sugar IS 14968:2001 (Reaffirmed 2015- amended 2023 or with latest amendments).

Un-SLAKED LIME 3928 MT
unslaked lime with minimum 85%-90% of CaO contents, packed in polythene lined bags of 30 to 40 kg. each. Un-burnt lime should not exceed 2%. Silica oxide not more than 2%.

Hydrated LIME 1195 MT
% of available CA (OH)₂ - min. 90%
Active Cao% - min. 68.4%
Acid insoluble - min. 1%
Iron & Aluminium as Fe₂O₃ & AL₂O₃ - In traces
Screened through Mesh-250 packing - PP/HDPE

Details are available on website: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>
For participating in the above e-tendering process, the bidders shall have to get themselves registered with <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> and get user ID, Password. Class-3 Digital Signature is mandatory to participate in the e-tendering process. For any clarification/difficulty regarding e-tendering process flow, enrollment please contact help desk of NIC on 0172-2970263, 0172-2970284.

Managing Director

MYSORE PAINTS & VARNISH LTD.,
(A Govt. of Karnataka Undertaking)
New Bannimantap Extension, MYSURU-570 015, Karnataka.

Phone: 0821-2493831/ 2497469/ 2499340,
website: www.mysorepaints.karnataka.gov.in
email: materials-mpvl@karnataka.gov.in
Date: 30/09/2026

Global Tender Notification

Tender are invited from reputed manufacturers / authorized dealers for supply of the following materials (Conversion charges) through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal(KPPP) (<https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>). The details are as mentioned below:
Sl.No.01. Tender notification Number: MPVL/2026-27/IND0027 **Tender Description:** Procurement of Silver Nitrate (e-Tender notification for supply of Silver Nitrate. 1 Item. Estimated value Rs.72.00 Crore). **Tender Category:** Supply of Goods. **Last Date & Time for submission of Tender / Bids:** 16/10/2026 **Date & Time of Technical Bid Opening:** 18/10/2026
Interested parties may visit www.mysorepaints.karnataka.gov.in for details and can contact the undersigned for any further clarifications/ information and request to participate in the tender.

For Mysore Paints and Varnish Ltd.,
Sd/-
Materials Manager/(TIA)

CROSSWORD

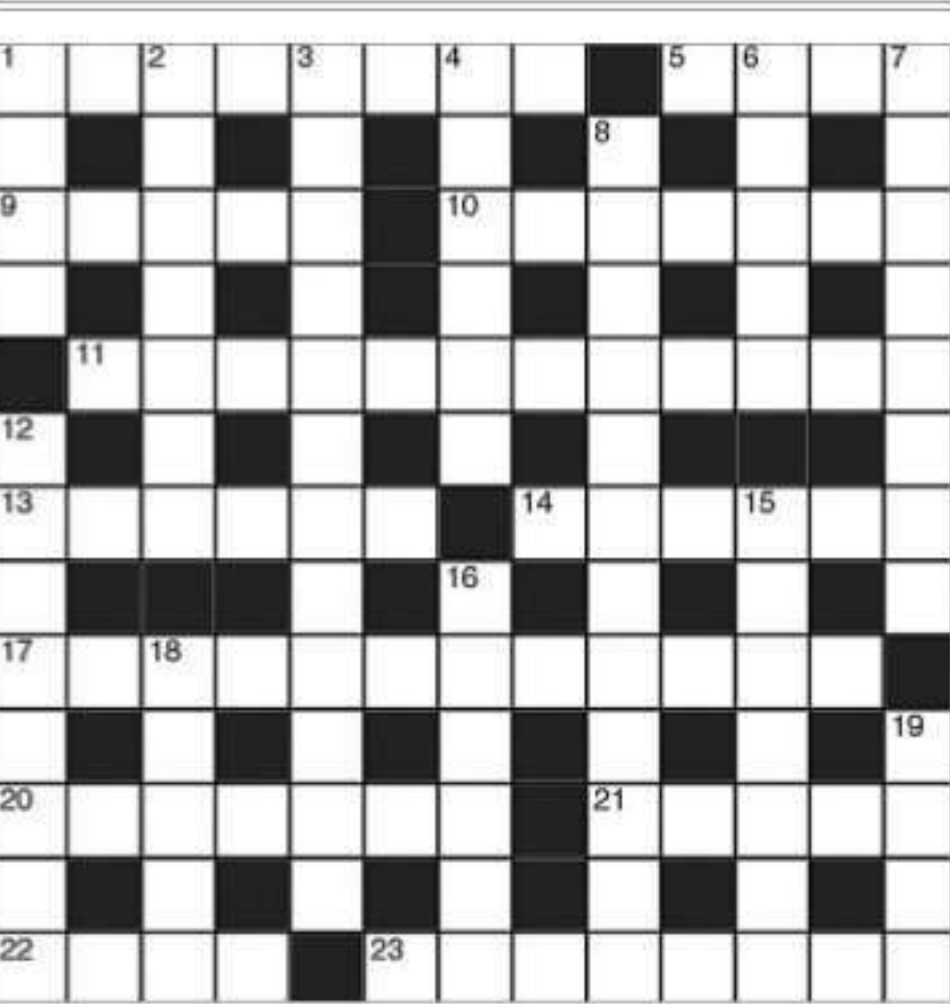
6108

OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS



ACROSS

1 Hard task master? (8)
5 So far fit for the job (2,2)
9 A four-figure sum can be impressive (5)
10 Abuse a pen for making a mess (7)
11 Failures expected in electrical faults (12)
13 Sound cover for some entertainment (6)
14 Group endlessly employed in making money (6)
17 Yet always the greater? (12)
20 Money used in stories about the New Testament (7)
21 Reunite it with new string (5)
22 Girlfriend who could be blind or stoned (4)
23 What Cinderella became after twelve (8)

DOWN

1 Going off in great spirits (4)
2 Comes to cheer as arranged (7)
3 It has a stirring influence beneath the surface (12)
4 Have prospects? (6)
6 Clear the ground (5)
7 Acts as a superintendent abroad we hear (8)
8 To complain so may be common all over the world (12)
12 Issued with both the name and date wrong (8)
15 Before the vote this will decide the issue (7)
16 He acts in a refined way (6)
18 Servant brought up the box with beer in (5)
19 Try to listen! (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6107
ACROSS: 1 Minusule, 8 Malmo, 9 Gingham, 10 Wrasse, 11 Adonis, 12 Exposure, 15 Emphasis, 18 Spruce, 20 Tariff, 21 Portend, 22 Enter, 23 Mastering
DOWN: 2 Iliad, 3 Urgent, 4 Coarsens, 5 Embryo, 6 Close-up, 7 Novellette, 11 Absentees, 13 Passport, 14 Spirits, 16 Affirm, 17 Orator, 19 Canon

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

A facility for ____ covers the absence of original thought - Dorothy L. Sayers (9)

CCA00

GARNET

EHNIT

AANTQU

SOLUTIONS:

Cococa, Thine, Argent, Quantia

ANSWER:

A facility for quotation covers the absence of original thought -



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

6458

SUDOKU

2	5		4	7		8
	1		3			
			5			3
5	6					
3	2			4		7
					2	5
8	7		2			
		7		1		
1		3	8	6		2

6457

SUDOKU

7	5	6	8	3	1	4	9	2
1	2	3	9	7	4	6	5	8
9	8	4	6	2	5	1	7	3
6	4	5	2	1	8	9	3	7
2	9	7	3	4	6	5	8	1
8	3	1	7	5	9	2	6	4
5	1	9	4	8	7	3	2	6
4	7	2	5	6	3	8	1	9
3	6	8	1	9	2	7	4	5

PFC CONSULTING LIMITED

(A wholly owned subsidiary of PFC Limited)

Regd. Office: First Floor, "Urjanidhi", 1, Barakhamba Lane, Connaught Place, New Delhi - 110001, (India) Fax: 011-23443990

GLOBAL INVITATION (THROUGH E-BIDDING ONLY)

FOR SELECTION OF TRANSMISSION SERVICE PROVIDER ON BUILD, OWN, OPERATE AND TRANSFER (BOOT) BASIS FOR INTER-STATE TRANSMISSION PROJECT

PFC Consulting Limited, a wholly owned subsidiary of Power Finance Corporation Limited (A Government of India Undertaking), invites proposal for setting up of transmission projects on Build, Own, Operate and Transfer (BOOT) basis following single stage two envelope process of "Request for Proposal" (RFP). Interested bidders may refer to the RFP notification and RFP documents available on the website <https://www.mstcecommerce.com> and <https://www.pfcclindia.com>. The Bidders may obtain the RFP documents on all working days between 10:30 hrs (IST) and 16:00 hrs (IST) from 01.10.2026 to one working day prior to bid submission for the projects mentioned below on payment of a non-refundable fee of Rs. 5,00,000/- or USD 7,000 plus applicable GST @18% from 9th Floor, Wing - A, Statesman House, Connaught Place, New Delhi - 110001, Tel.: 91-11-23443912; Fax: 91-11-23443990; e-mail: pfccl.itp@pfcindia.com. The RFP documents can also be downloaded from <https://www.mstcecommerce.com> and <https://www.pfcclindia.com>, however, in such case, interested party can submit Response to RFP only on submission of non-refundable fee of Rs. 5,00,000/- or USD 7,000 plus applicable GST @18% separately. The survey report and clarification to RFP documents shall be issued to those bidders, who have obtained/purchased RFP documents by paying requisite fee at least one working day prior to bid submission date. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated regarding clarifications/amendments/time extensions etc., if any. The important timelines in this regard are as follows:

S. No	Name of Transmission Scheme	Last Date for seeking clarifications (dd/mm/yyyy)	Last Date for submission of response to RFP (dd/mm/yyyy)	Date of opening of Response to RFP (dd/mm/yyyy)
1.	Transmission system for Integration of Kadapa-II REZ (Phase-I)	21/10/2026	04/12/2026 up to 15:00 hrs (IST)	04/12/2026 up to 15:30 hrs (IST)

Note: PFC Consulting Limited reserves the right to cancel or modify the process without assigning any reason and without any liability. This is not an offer.

Bid Process Coordinator

An Initiative of

Initiative Partner

PFC CONSULTING LTD.

(A wholly owned subsidiary of PFC Ltd.)
(A Govt. of India Undertaking)

Ministry of Power

Government of India

Central Electricity Authority

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT PRASARAN NIGAM LIMITED

N.I.T. No. 13, 14/2026-27

Tenders are invited from reputed contractors registered in appropriate class with RRVPNL and A or AA class in Central/State Govt. Department and their undertakings and registered in GST department for the bid S. No. 1 to 2 of NIT No 13 (2026-2027) under Executive Engineer (Civil) Ajmer / Sikar and bid S. No. 1 of NIT No. 14 (2026-2027) bid under Executive Engineer (Civil) Mertaity. All details of above NIB are available on website <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://energy.rajjasthan.gov.in/rrvpn> and <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>. UBN No. - VPN2627WSOB01504 & VPN2627WSOB01477 (Bid No. 11C0022622 to 32C0012628), UBN No. - VPN2627WSOB01505 (Bid No. 28C0012617)

Raj.Samwad/C/26/10967

R.R.V.P.N./TR/7816/2026

Superintending Engineer (Civil), Ajmer

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No. F.6(JDA/G.Store/Stationary Supply/2026/D-331 Dated : 28-09-2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

NIB No.: JDA/G.Store/19/2026-27

Online Bids are invited For "One Year rate contract for Stationary Supply" up-to 08.10.2026 Till 6:00 PM. Estimated cost of Work is Rs.1,00,00,000/- (One Crore Only). The last date for Applying for Bid and making online payment on JDA Portal is 08.10.2026 by 06.00 PM. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document Available on jda.rajjasthan.gov.in www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in. (UBN No:- JDA2627GLRC00339

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be

1. Registered on JDA website jda.rajjasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.

2.Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission

Raj.Samwad/C/26/11002

Deputy Commissioner (Store)

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice Date:26.09.2026

SIGNAL & TELECOMMUNICATION DEPARTMENT

Sr.DSTE/CO/Kota for and on behalf of President of Union of India invites e-tenders against Tender No. KOTA/ SNT/SIG/2025/27/R/1 Due date to open mentioned below in table. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. Tender No. KOTA/SNT/SIG/2025/27/R/1, Name of work: "Kota Divn : Enhancing the system redundancy by provision of Digital Axle Counters in parallel with Track circuits at stations yard on Main Line in Kota Mathura section." Approx. cost of the work: Rs. 45,19,32,232.48, Bid Security value : Rs. 90,38,700.00/-. Last Date & Time of submission and opening of tender : 15:00 Hrs. on Date 01.02.2027. The Tenders can be viewed at website www.ireps.gov.in. The tenderer/bidders must have class III Digital signature certificate & must be registered on IREPS portal. Only registered tenderer/bidders can participate in e-tendering. Also should have valid GSTIN. Sd/- Sr. DSTE/Co. West Central Railway, Kota

सख्त भारत अखियात एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

Let's move India forward

Rajasthan State Beverages Corporation Limited

(A Government of Rajasthan Undertaking)

Plot No. 2, G-202A Bhawan, (Fourth & Fifth Floor), Opp. Aranya Bhawan, Jhalana Sansthanik Area, JAIPUR-302004, Tel.: 0141-2744293, email- ed.rbcd@rajjasthan.gov.in

No.- 4333 Dated : 29/09/2026

Short-Term Notice Inviting e-Bid

e-Bids for Loading and Unloading work of IMFL/FMFL/BEER cases in Depots of 4 Districts in the year 2026-27 to 2028-29 for (Two Year) are invited from interested bidders upto 6:00 PM on 08.10.2026 the bid documents may be downloaded from <https://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <https://iems.rajjasthan.gov.in>. UBN No. BCL2627SL0B00022 - BCL2627SL0B00025

Raj.Samwad/C/26/11033

Executive Director

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Government of India Undertaking)

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Chief Commercial Manager, Konkan Railway Corporation Limited, invites sealed applications from interested parties for "ENGAGEMENT OF M-UTS SAHAYAKS ON PILOT PROJECT BASIS OVER KONKAN RAILWAY AT VARIOUS STATIONS" to work at Madgaon, Chiplun, Ratnagiri, Thivim, Karmali and Udipi stations over Konkan Railway" in the prescribed format for issue of unserved tickets only through M-UTS device on commission payment basis and will be deployed in or near the ticketing area. Tender Notice No. CO-16034/1/2026-COMM dated 30/09/2026. Last Date of submission of application : On 30/10/2026 upto 15.00 hrs. Opening of application : On 30/10/2026 at 15:30 hrs. For more details and to download the Tender Form, please visit our website www.konkanrailway.com --> Department--> Commercial. Applications can be downloaded for KR website at www.konkanrailway.com. Application form duly filled-up can be submitted at any station:- 1) Madgaon, 2) Ratnagiri 3) Chiplun 4) Thivim 5) Karmali and 6) Udipi

Directorate of Tourism, Government of Maharashtra

Head office: 4th Floor, Sakhar Bhavan, Ramnath Goenka Marg Nariman Point, Mumbai-21

Tel.: 91-22-69107600, 91-22-69107604 E-mail: dev.dot-mh@mah.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE

Subject:- Invites eligible consultancy firms to hire a "Project Implementation Unit for the World Bank supported 'MahaSTRIDE' Operation" for Directorate of Tourism, Govt of Maharashtra.

Reference:- The Director, Directorate of Tourism, Govt. of Maharashtra, Invites Request for Proposal from eligible consultancy firms to hire a "Project Implementation Unit for the World Bank supported 'MahaSTRIDE' Operation" for Directorate of Tourism, Govt of Maharashtra.

To download RFP document from D1.05.10.2026 at 17.00 hrs to D1. 30.10.2026 at 15.00 hrs

Date of opening of tender D1. 30.10.2026 at 17.00 hrs

Please visit <https://mahatenders.gov.in> & <https://maharashtratourism.gov.in>

Place: Mumbai

D1.1.10.2026

Sd/- Director Directorate of Tourism

Malegaon Municipal Corporation, Malegaon

Sanitation Department

Published Rate E-Tender Notice No. 01/ 2026-27

Commissioner, Malegaon Municipal Corporation, invites e-tenders for a period of 5 years from suitably registered and licensed contractors. The work involves outsourcing daily tasks such as road sweeping and gutter cleaning in Prabha 02 and 03, as well as the "1,000 Colony" area within the Maldhe Shivar, and conducting fogging and spraying operations in these Prabha using the contractor's own equipment, vehicles, insecticides, and disinfectants. These tenders are being invited via the e-tendering process, and the notice has been published on the Government's website: <http://mahatenders.gov.in>. Details regarding the tender notice, scope of work, terms and conditions, tender document availability, and dates for submission and opening of tenders are available on the aforementioned website from Date 30/09/2026 at 17.00 Hrs. until Date 15/10/2026 at 17.00 Hrs. Relevant information regarding this work can also be obtained from the Sanitation Department at the Head Office.

Commissioner

Malegaon Municipal Corporation

Note: All further instructions and corrigenda will be published on the online website.

epaper.indianexpress.com

{ ASIAN GAMES : SEPT 19 - OCT 4 }

WINDFALL IN ARCHERY: GOLD MEDALS IN WOMEN'S, MEN'S AND MIXED TEAM COMPOUND EVENTS

From Sonepat to Okazaki, how India's star archers rehearsed a golden sweep



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 30

THERE WAS a little bit of Okazaki in Sonepat last month.

At the Sports Authority of India centre in Sonepat, Indian compound archers spent 15 days training in a replica of the Asian Games environment they would encounter in Japan. The same screens, music system, targets, podium, flags and colour scheme were recreated, so that when they eventually arrived at Okazaki Chuo Sogo Park, there would be as little that felt unfamiliar as possible. "We wanted them to feel that whatever happens here, they have already experienced it," said Dronacharya Awardee Jiwant Singh Teja.

On Wednesday, India showed why that preparation mattered. They swept all three compound team golds at the Asian Games — in the women's, men's and mixed categories. They also beat the Asian Games' most dominant archery nation, South Korea, thrice, two times in the semis and once in a final. The mixed-team victory, secured by Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Jadhav after a shoot-off, also earned India their first Olympic quota place for Los Angeles 2028.

"We have been proving ourselves from the past few years," Jyothi Vennam, who paired with Chikitha and Prithika Pradeep for the women's team gold, said. "We have been winning each and every medal possible at the highest and I think, yeah, maybe we are better than South Korea."

Wednesday was also India's best gold-medal day of these Games so far. Alongside the archery hat-trick, Neeru Dhandha and Kynan Chenai won the mixed trap gold in shooting, giving India four golds in a single day.

But the significance of the archery sweep stretches beyond another successful Asian Games.

When India swept all five compound golds at Hangzhou in 2023, the category — in which archers use a bow fitted with pulleys and cables, allowing archers to shoot with greater power and accuracy than a traditional recurve bow — was still fighting for its place on the Olympic stage. Now it has one. The International Olympic Committee has added mixed-team compound to the Los Angeles 2028 programme, making it the first Olympic medal event for the discipline.

That has changed the equation. An event that once had Asian Games and World Championship glory at stake

Mixed team gold, secured by Chikitha and Sahil after a shoot-off against Korea, earns India an Olympic quota place



The compound mixed team event will be making its debut at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics and Sahil Jadhav (L) and Chikitha Taniparthi have secured a quota place for India through their win. PTI

now has an Olympic medal at the end of the road, and countries that had lagged behind India have started investing accordingly.

China, according to Teja, began serious preparations around 2018 and has steadily built itself into a force. At these Games, China's Liao Jiahao and Liu Jinyi finished first and second in men's qualification. South Korea has also sharpened its compound programme. Its mixed team set a world record earlier in the competition, while 14-year-old Kang Yeonsoo became the first under-18 women's archer to shoot a perfect 150 in a 15-arrow match.

"Everyone doubled down on their preparation," said David Cousins, the high-performance coach brought in specifically to prepare India for the Olympic push. "It got a lot harder and it will get harder after this, for sure."

India's response has been to double down, too. At SAI Sonepat, Teja and the coaching staff recreated the competition environment and then repeatedly put their archers through pressure situations. A second team from the Centre of Excellence was brought in to compete

against the national team two to four times a week. "We set up the exact same environment," Teja said. "We installed the same screens, used the same music system, set up identical targets, and built the same podium, flags and colour scheme."

Practicing perfection

The pressure was deliberately manufactured. If the world record was 238, the target was 238. If six arrows were required, all six had to be 10s, with at least three Xs — the tiny centre at the heart of the 10-ring, where the highest-scoring arrows land. Sometimes, the rule was even simpler: only six Xs would allow the session to end.

The mixed-team final against Korea provided the perfect test. The teams were locked at 157-157 after four ends. The gold came down to a shoot-off. Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Jadhav shot 20; Korea's Park Jungyoon and Choi Yonghee managed 19.

It was precisely the kind of moment the Sonepat sessions had tried to manufacture. "The biggest thing is just they have been through training scenarios that are way more complicated and way more mentally and emotionally stressful than

this," Cousins, a five-time World Championship gold medallist, said.

"It's just getting them to internalise that they trust everything you put them through, that they trust themselves, that they believe in their teammates and themselves, and then just get up there and execute with no doubts," he said.

Cousins added that securing early Olympic qualification will give the archers a head start over the rest. "The nice thing about securing the first Olympic spot is that we can use 2027 to be a little bit more tactical and almost be offensive, not defensive," he said.

The three golds in Nagoya, then, are more than a continuation of India's Asian Games dominance. They are an early statement in a new Olympic race, one in which China, Korea and others have begun investing heavily in catching up.

And India might not be finished here. They still have a chance to add two more individual compound golds on Thursday, when the men's and women's individual titles are decided.

They brought Okazaki to Sonepat. When they finally reached Okazaki, it felt familiar.



Coach Pravin Sawant (R) reckoned Sahil's physique and temperament were better suited to compound

Sahil realises his coach's dream by hitting bull's eye

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 30

THREE SECONDS remained on the clock when Sahil Jadhav raised his bow.

The Asian Games mixed team final had been reduced to its most unforgiving form. India and South Korea were tied 157-157, and in the shoot-off Chikitha Taniparthi had opened with a 10, matched by South Korea's Jungyoon Park. Jadhav was next, with the Korean team waiting.

He waited, and waited longer before releasing the arrow.

Ten.

Now, South Korea needed another 10 to stay alive. Yonghee Choi's final arrow landed in the nine-ring, handing India a 20-19 shoot-off victory, a second compound archery gold of the day. Jadhav later combined with Kushal Dalal and Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru for a team gold. Tucked inside the celebration is India's first Olympic quota in archery for Los Angeles 2028, where the mixed team event will make its Olympic debut.

The story of these two medals stretches well beyond the shooting line in Okazaki. It runs through a family in Satara that kept finding money for an expensive dream, and through a coach who once worked hospital night shifts to fund his archery career.

Pravin Sawant never made it to an international stage as an archer. His student now has an Olympic berth.

"It's like a dream come true — two dreams, in fact," Jadhav, 25, said. "It's awesome."

Jadhav was 19 when he first picked up a bow at a summer camp in Wai.

His parents wanted him to try an individual sport and he initially trained in the wooden Indian round before moving to recurve. Sawant, who was coaching in Satara, saw that the youngster's physique and temperament were better suited to compound.

Jadhav had started late by archery standards and spent

years waiting for the breakthrough, missing selections and major teams while continuing to train. Then came Covid, his father lost his job, and the family's stretched finances became a question of whether he could continue playing the sport.

"The family wanted Sahil to stop competing," Sawant said. "I convinced them to let him continue so that he had a chance to justify his talent."

Mother sold jewellery

His mother, a teacher, sold her jewellery to help buy Sahil a compound bow.

Sawant could relate to the family's situation. His own archery journey took off when he simultaneously worked as a ward boy in an orthopaedic hospital.

"I would finish night duty and spend the day travelling 45 kilometres to Wai to practise, using whatever money I earned from the job to pay for training and equipment," Sawant says.

He too had dreamed of representing India. "Who doesn't have that? To play for India," Sawant, who is now a police constable, says.

But the dream ran into the realities of his circumstances. "I couldn't do that as a player. Because I didn't get all those things. I didn't get proper coaching. I didn't get the equipment. I didn't get an upgrade in my knowledge from time to time."

What he could not find for himself, he began trying to build for others.

When travelling to Wai became difficult, he began training at Shahu Stadium in Satara. Other youngsters began joining him, and whenever Sawant finished his police duty, he would train them. The coach who had once squeezed archery into the margins of his working life was slowly building a second career as coach.

Aditi Swami and Ojas Deotale emerged from Sawant's Drushti Archery Academy to become world champions in 2023 before playing leading roles in India's compound gold rush at the Hangzhou Asian Games. Aditi won the women's individual and team golds; Ojas returned with three gold medals.

Jadhav was the next one to leave Satara, moving to the National Centre of Excellence in Kolkata, but distance did little to alter the relationship with his first coach.

If anything, their meetings became rituals of their own. Jadhav, who has a fondness for tea, and Sawant would sit over endless cups whenever they met, talking through training, competitions and what had to change.

For Nagoya, they had settled on a number. "52 seconds," Sawant said. "It's the length of our national anthem. We never target the gold, we always play for the anthem."

Yet, on Wednesday, the metaphor acquired an uncanny precision.

The mixed team final had been slipping towards a shoot-off after India, which had led through the earlier ends, saw South Korea shoot a perfect 40 in the fourth while India managed 39.

The scoreboard read 157-157, leaving four arrows — two each — to decide the gold.

When Jadhav stepped onto the shooting line after Chikitha played her part, he seemed to have hesitated for a moment before finding the bulls-eye.

It was not the arrow that mathematically won India the gold; South Korea still had one shot left. But it was the arrow that made the final Korean shot unforgiving.

When Choi hit a nine, Jadhav lowered his bow as the Indian celebration began. "This is awesome," he said.

MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	151	67	59	277
2	Japan	50	77	73	200
3	S Korea	24	30	49	103
4	Uzb'stan	16	19	19	54
5	Thailand	12	10	12	34
8	India	10	21	29	60

DAY 12 CAPSULE

Haul: 4 gold, 4 bronze
4 GOLD

Women's compound team

The trio of Chikitha Taniparthi, Jyothi Vennam and Prithika Pradeep defended the women's team gold medal from 2023 with a win over China.

Compound mixed team

Chikitha Taniparthi and Sahil Jadhav won mixed team gold to secure the quota for 2028 LA Olympics.

Men's compound team

Sahil Jadhav, Kushal Dalal, and Ganesh MR also defended the men's team gold.

Trap mixed team

Neeru Dhandha continued her supreme run and partnered with Kynan Chenai to win second gold of this edition.

4 BRONZE

Women's 60kg

Priya Ghanghas lost her semi-final bout to Yang Chengyu of China, and won the bronze.

Men's 90kg

Kapil Pokhariya settled for the bronze after his 1-4 semi-final loss to Turabek Khabibullaev.

Men's +90kg

Narender Berwal won a +90kg bronze medal. He lost his semi-final bout 5-0 to Aibek Oralbay of Kazakhstan.

Men's Greco-Roman 87kg

Sunil Kumar defeated Roberts CJ of Philippines to win bronze medal in men's Greco-Roman 87 kg. This is his second medal after a bronze in the 2023 edition.

TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 13

Archery: Compound Women's Individual QF (6:38 am), Men's individual QF (9:47 am)

● After defending team gold medals, Chikitha Taniparthi and Ganesh MR will look to defend the individual titles.

Wrestling: Men's Greco-Roman 60 kg, 77 kg, 97 kg, Women's 62 kg (Qualification medal matches, 7:22 am onwards)

● Sumit (60 kg), Aman (77 kg), and Nitesh (97 kg) will look to add on to Sunil's medal. Mansi Ahlawat will start her campaign in women's 62 kg.

Cricket: Men's semifinal (10 am)

● Defending gold medallists India will take on neighbours Sri Lanka.

Hockey: Men's semifinal (1 pm)

● A red-hot Indian men's team will take on arch-rivals Pakistan.

Shooting: 25m pistol rapid men's individual QF stage 2 and team final (6:10 am), 25m pistol rapid men's final if qualified (12:00 pm)

● Fifth placed Anish Bhanwala will be aiming to qualify for the individual's final event.

TOUGH ROAD TO SUCCESS

Selling rice harvester to taking loans from friends: Sacrifice behind Chikitha's glory

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 30

IT WAS called the Disco 100 set, when Chikitha Taniparthi set her eyes on the recreational archery kit set from Decathlon for the first time.

It must've cost not more than Rs 3000 back then, but when her uncle - father's brother - first brought it during a family get-together, Chikitha was fascinated. This was at Sultanpur village in Peddapalli district of Telangana, 200 kms north of Hyderabad. Two steel-tipped arrows, a range of just 1 metres. But the Disco 100 (short for Discovery, not the dance) was like a Cinderella-ball for her in the fields behind her farm, for her. She tried it out, and the the kit went away with the Uncle.

What followed her first experience shooting was tougher than a glass slipper ferried by a

prince, though the fairytale ended in a gold.

The stunning gold medal in Compound Archery Mixed Team that gave India its first Olympics quota for the Los Angeles 2028 Games, was a culmination of that dreamy afternoon with the simplest of store-bought recreational bows. For Chikitha never stopped shooting arrows, and on Wednesday combined with Sahil Jadhav, 25, winning a shoot-off over Koreans Park Jeong-yun and Choi Yonghee, at Nagoya.

Chikitha's father, 51-year-old paddy farmer Srinivas Rao, was reduced to selling his family's rice harvester, to ensure Chikitha could buy a proper Compound bow, as her interest morphed into passion and passion was tempered by discipline of day in-day out competition. The family would also need to take loans to get the

bow and bear her training expenses till the Reliance Foundation started funding for her best-quality bows.

Chikitha's mother Sreelata Rao would cheer her daughter on, from their home in Sultanpur village in Peddapalli district in Telangana even as she completed two gold medals after topping qualification. Not only did she win in the Women's team with veteran Jyothi Surekha Vennam and Prithika. She also combined with Sahil as the Indians were tied on 157-157 after the end of the fourth round before the shoot-off happened. Chikitha hit a ten followed by the Korean too hitting a ten. Sahil then hit a close ten before the Korean missed as the Indians won the shoot-off 20-19 to seal the title and Olympics quota.

"We stay in the small village of Sultanpur and only have our 2 acre farmland, where we



Chikitha Taniparthi applied her martial arts training in karate to archery as the sport teaches stillness and concentration. PTI

grow rice. It was Chikitha, who played karate earning a black belt at a local academy, who read about an archer in a newspaper and wanted to pursue archery," her father recalled.

"After her training for more than a year, I sold our rice harvester to get her a new bow as well as took loans from the village friends and others at a low interest to support her train-

ing. All in our family have been rice farmers and to see Chikitha win a gold medal as well as get the Olympics quota for India is a special feeling for us as well as the whole village," 51-year-old Rao told *The Indian Express*.

Rao would take his daughter to nearby Karimnagar to train along with a local archer for a year and would also set targets made of card boxes and archery target cloth at the empty space behind their home to help Chikitha practice. "In her free time, she would shoot with the makeshift targets at the empty space besides our house," he recalls.

The family was cruelly cheated off money in trying to buy her first bow. The father recalls how they lost more than 1.5 lakhs in trying to get new equipment. "The first compound bow we tried to get, we lost the money amounting to

Rs 1.5 lakh in fraud. After a year, I took a loan of Rs 3.5 lakh to get her a new bow and later when she won the sub-junior nationals, the Collector of our district got her a new bow from the government funds," he recalls.

"Later, we decided to travel to Delhi to seek training and it was there that we met international archer Abhishek Verma, who supported Chikitha and mentored her and later she got selected for the SAI Centre in Sonepat," recalls Rao.

The earlier training in karate had helped too.

Archery is a stationary sport. Prizes stillness. Demands extreme concentration. There is a rhythm that elite sport demands — where your heart rate could be off the charts, but you need to nail that one trigger or arrow releasing movement, which still needs shoulder power. To get that balance right, many athletes train in

martial arts - karate, judo, jiu Jitsu, to achieve absolute mental poise / strength in that moment. It's why a Karate black belt can translate into an Asiad gold many many years later. It is mind training that becomes muscle memory.

The quota secured, gold added to India's tally, Chikitha will be welcomed home with her favourites. For Chikitha, it's chitti muthyalu (small pearl) rice - that delectable rice-grain that's best served in biryanis or pulao because the pearls swallow the spice.

Chikitha shared that she wants to get a new rice harvester for the family. And with the prize money, that's the first thing she will do. Apart from that, she likes having the Chitti Muthyalu rice, which is also called Small Pearls. With this gold medal, she is the pearl of our village and family," says Rao.

Lovlina beats world champ to set up rematch with Ziyi Bao

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 30

LOVLINA BORGHAIN beat world champion Natalya Bogdanova of Kazakhstan 3-2 in the women's 75kg semi-final on Wednesday, becoming the first Indian woman boxer to reach consecutive Asian Games finals. Mary Kom, in 2014, was the only Indian woman to reach one before her.

Borghain had been given a direct entry to the semi-finals at the Commonwealth Games before losing the final to Australia's Emma-Sue Greentree. She is now only the second woman boxer to reach the final at this Asian Games, after Parveen Hooda.

Bogdanova, a southpaw, worked her at close range in the first round and took it 2-3. Borgohain moved to the outside in the second, landing at distance, and took it 10-9 on all five scorecards. Bogdanova came back to take the third 2-3, but Borgohain held her off the whole round. In the fourth, two of the three remaining judges gave it to her, enough for the win.

Sparring helped

"Lovlina had sparred against the Kazakh here, and we knew she would come into this bout with an offensive mindset and southpaw style. So the plan was to box from the outside. The Kazakh came with good mid-range and close-range work in the first round, which is difficult against a southpaw, and Lovlina fell towards the last seconds of the first round and lost it.

"But then Lovlina boxed much better from outside and scored with her side-step left hook and the long-range hook too, and the Kazakh slowed down. She displayed her longer range with straight left and straight right too. We knew she needed better scores from at least one of the three remaining judges to win the bout, and she worked from the outside. I am not happy with the last minute, where the bout became a little messy. But considering what Lovlina did, I thought it was a good job," said Santiago Nieva, India's women's foreign head coach, speaking from Nagoya.

Borghain will now face China's Ziyi Bao. In Hangzhou, she lost the final to Chinese boxer Li Qian. "Lovlina operates better in long range with her good footwork. The key will be not to let the bout begin messy in this weight, and to keep her composure and manage the bout on her strengths," Nieva said.

Commonwealth Games champion Priya Ghanghas lost 1-4 to former world champion Chengyu Yang of China in the women's 60kg semi-final. Kapil Pokhriya lost 1-4 to reigning world champion Turabek Khabibullaev of Uzbekistan in the 90kg semi-final.

Fastest to 200, Gill takes India past 400

CHASE MASTERS

Skipper's 223 and 255-run stand with Rohit make pursuit of 406 look like a stroll

Sandip G
New Delhi, September 30

With a nudge to mid-on and a stroll, Rituraj Gaikwad wrapped up a historic night and an astounding chase at Guwahati's ACA Stadium, AKA bowlers' graveyard. He turned back and fell into the embrace of the night's protagonist—Shubman Gill, unbeaten on a monumental 223, his side reaching 406, a target West Indies deemed was insurmountable, in merely 43.3 overs, with not a nerve frayed nor hair split.

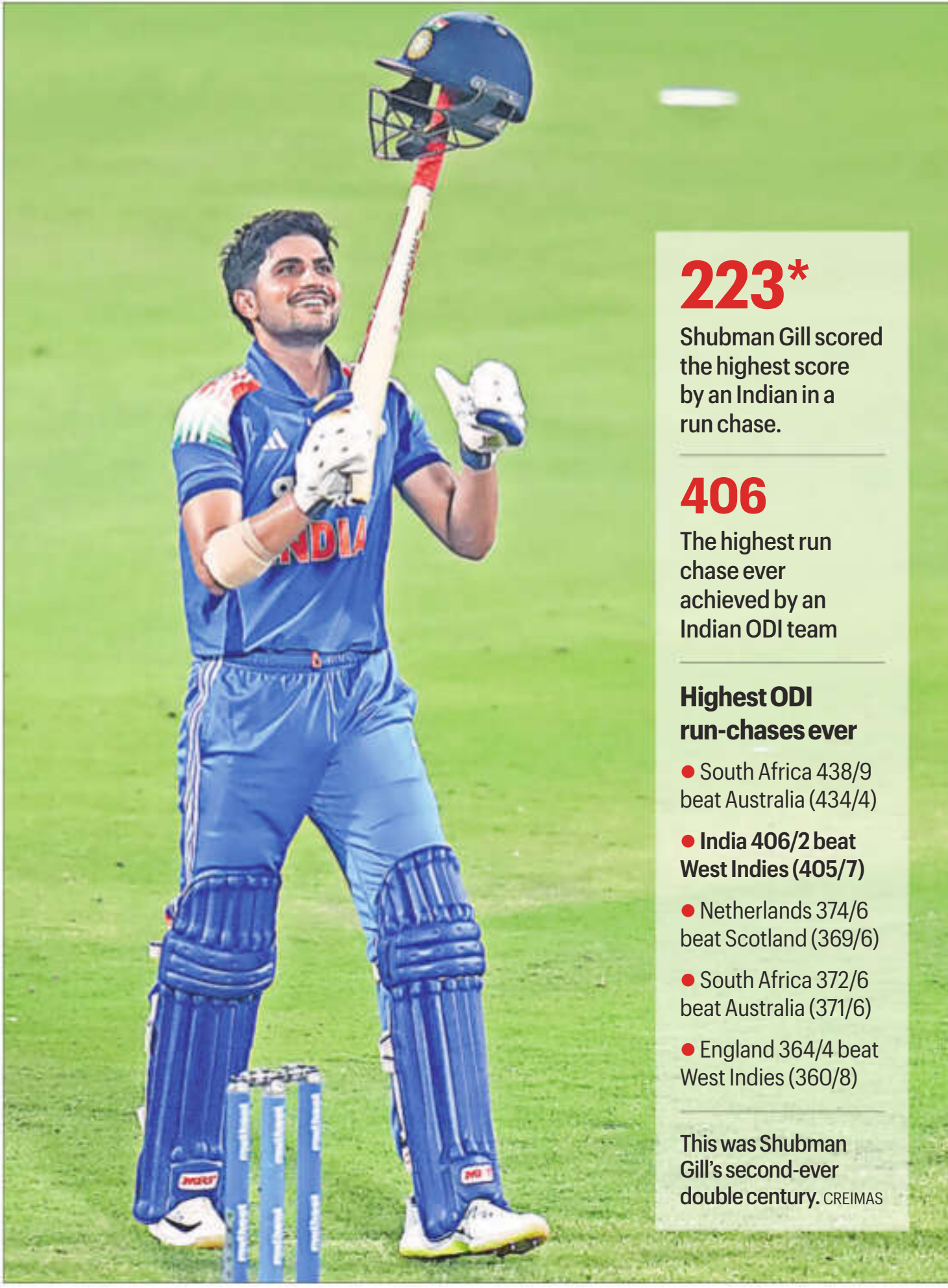
Gill's double hundred merits to be considered among the grandest knocks by an Indian batsman. The stroke-play marvelled; the inscrutable temperament foretold a long and splendid career. The fears of the format losing its lustre when Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma retire seem unfounded. In Gill it has a new figurehead.

But the match boggles the mind, assaults cricketing sensibilities, and leaves the audience confounded rather than thrilled. A pursuit as heady as this shouldn't shock the world. If 250-plus targets are chased down in T20s, it's little wonder that competent batting units scale 400-plus peaks, especially when the path is smooth and there is little resistance from the elements.

The chase manifested Indian batting's glowing riches, just as it condemned West Indies's appalling bowling. The game could be interpreted in two ways—a triumph of high-class batting, or a tragedy of low-quality bowling from both sides. All five hundreds on the day featured magnificent stroke-play; but no bowler on the day was even faintly impressive.

A target beyond 400, even by the game's dizzying chasing standards, daunts. But if John Campbell and Co could, so could a more pedigreed batting group. Gill and Rohit Sharma displayed nerveless aggression. No strokes of theirs looked remotely risky, partly because West Indies' seamers were scattergun, often faltering on the shorterside. But chiefly because Gill and Rohit are supreme stroke-makers, whose expanse is so vast that they can manoeuvre perfectly good balls to the fence. They blocked those that swung away late from Jayden Seales, but when they did not deviate off the wicket, they found the gaps.

Neither resorted to the crash-bang-wallop approach. Rohit, the usually more adventurous of the pair, did not venture into the stream of adventure. He left two off the first three balls he faced alone; the first burst of boundaries arrived when Alzarri Joseph bowled short, messed up



223*

Shubman Gill scored the highest score by an Indian in a run chase.

406

The highest run chase ever achieved by an Indian ODI team

Highest ODI run-chases ever

● South Africa 438/9 beat Australia (434/4)

● India 406/2 beat West Indies (405/7)

● Netherlands 374/6 beat Scotland (369/6)

● South Africa 372/6 beat Australia (371/6)

● England 364/4 beat West Indies (360/8)

This was Shubman Gill's second-ever double century. CREIMAS

Gill was fantastic on the other end. He was in control of his batting. To see him stay not out was fantastic to see as well. It comes down to concentration."

ROHIT SHARMA, INDIA BATSMAN

his lengths and Rohit slapped two fours either side of point. He was rushed into a pull but it sailed over the fine-leg fence.

But the former captain was seldom in haste. The next 12 balls yielded him three runs but he knew bad balls would come; he knew he could make up; he knew India would overhaul the total if he stayed there.

The bad balls arrived in a flurry, leaving the crowd dazed in Rohit's stroke-plays splendour. He lashed a cut between point

and backward point. Alzarri blew his cheeks in resignation. He nonchalantly flicked Seales over midwicket.

As Rohit slipped into an unbreakable boundary-hitting trance, West Indies captain Shai Hope, one the centurions for his team, looked petrified. He simply kept dialling different numbers but none answered his SOS pleas. Keemo Paul steamed in; Rohit smeared him for a brace of sixes.

His partner Gill wondered at some of his strokes. His show was as thrilling, perhaps more brutal square of the wicket. Like Rohit, he is a minimalist. He doesn't shuffle across the crease, doesn't have an elaborate flourish. But his movements are precise, the flexing of wrists just enough to direct the ball through the gaps. If Rohit cajoles the ball, he commands it to the space he wants it to travel. He short-arm-pulled, smote seamers inside-out. He was not one for slogs.

Both took turns to accelerate, not so much intentionally as imperceptibly. At one juncture,

Rohit was on 62 from 45 balls and Gill on 46 from 36. Just 26 balls later, the captain was celebrating his 11th ODI hundred. Rohit was on 83, and the score had blitzed to 206 in 22 overs. The required run rate had dropped from eight an over to seven by then.

Gill had stormed to 142 when Rohit completed his 35th hundred, off 72 balls. He added only one more run, but by then the pair had shellacked 255 runs, India's highest opening stand in a chase. By the 30th over, India had rolled to 303/1, needing a shade above five runs an over. The result was effectively settled, but Gill was in no mood to relent. But the 811-run day captured the format's existential crisis. If ODIs are to survive, shirt-fronts are not the solution. **BRIEF SCORES: West Indies 405/7 in 50 overs (Amir Janogo 114, Shai Hope 104, John Campbell 101; Kuldeep Yadav 2/65) lost to India 406/2 in 43.3 overs (Shubman Gill 223 not out, Rohit Sharma 101) by 8 wkts.**



The Sher-i-Kashmir stadium will host the Irani Cup, featuring the likes of Rishabh Pant & Manav Suthar. EXPRESS

5,000 passes for 700-seater stadium: Srinagar ready for biggest match in years

Shuvaditya Bose
Srinagar, September 30

HAD CRICKET a scent of its own, it could be smelt here, in Srinagar.

A carpet of emerald green unfurls across the Sher-i-Kashmir stadium. Lift your eyes from the outfield, and the valley takes over, mountains rising in shades of brunswick and grey. On the ridge above, the Shankaracharya Temple stands like a sentinel. A breeze wanders into the ground, bearing the cold of the Dal Lake.

Widen the lens, however, and a second picture asserts itself. Coils of barbed wire hem the ground on all sides. Braving those are fans jostling for a pass. Enthusiasm alone does not guarantee entry; every seat has to be earned with a display of the Aadhaar card's physical copy.

Patrolling, with canine diligence, is a triad of sniffer dogs of different breeds: a German shepherd, a labrador, and a beagle.

"This is the first time in the last four decades, since 1986 (ODI between India and Australia), that a match of this magnitude is being played in Srinagar," says Majid Dar, head of cricket operations at the Jammu & Kashmir Cricket Association. The ground is readying itself for history: the Irani Cup, to be contested between defending red-ball champions Jammu & Kashmir and Rest of India.

"We have worked day in day out to get things ready on time. The capacity of the ground is 700, but excitement among fans for this match is huge. We have built makeshift stands to accommodate more people. We will be issuing 5,000 passes, and I am expecting a full house. The security arrangement is top-notch," Dar says.

The stadium has known international cricket only fleetingly, both fixtures etched in controversy. The Irani Cup is not one, but it carries the aura of one, buoyed by the presence

of national team players Rishabh Pant and Manav Suthar.



Not once has the city's appetite for cricket dipped. Samiullah Beigh, joint second-highest wicket-taker for the state in the Ranji Trophy, finds it a struggle to contain his emotions as he reminisces about the ground.

"I vividly remember the match against Goa in 2013 at this venue. We were chasing a target of 262. When people realised that we were inching closer to a win, they came to the ground in massive numbers. Around 10,000 people showed up. I remember the Goa captain asking me what the chants meant, as he assumed they

Widen the lens, however, and a second picture asserts itself. Coils of barbed wire hem the ground on all sides.

were cursing Goa. I told him, it's not about Goa, it's about us," Beigh says.

On that day, it was about "them." And, in particular, "him": Beigh, for whom batting was never the calling card, scored a resilient half-century as a 114-run eighth-wicket stand earned Jammu & Kashmir the win. Former speedster Abid Nabi, the Jhelum Express, has 156 wickets to his name for Jammu & Kashmir. None, though, holds a place as special in his memory as the five he picked up in a local match, on this very stadium.

"My favourite memory here is not from a Ranji Trophy match, but a competition called the Mirza Nooruddin Cricket Tournament. I made my debut in the semi-final, took five wickets and scored 48 runs. This game earned me the moniker of Jhelum Express."

It took Jammu & Kashmir 23 years, and 99 attempts, to record their maiden victory in a Ranji Trophy match, a four-wicket win over Services in December 1982. Playing a crucial role was wicketkeeper-batter Parvez Qaiser, whose association with the ground predates his association with the state team.

"My relationship with the Sher-i-Kashmir stadium began much before I had even started playing cricket," he says. "I used to bunk classes in school and go to the ground to watch matches. Once Bishan Singh Bedi had come with the Delhi team, and I was very excited to watch him live. Naturally, I bunked school. When I returned, I got a thrashing from my master in school. But moments later, the same guy asked, 'Bedi ne kitne wicket liye?'"

The stadium being readied for Thursday bears scant resemblance to the one Qaiser had known. "In our days, it was just a ground. It had no fencing, no stands, no pavilion. No permanent bathroom either, only a makeshift one. There was no water supply, fans drank the same water that was used on the pitch. And even then, it was the second home of many Kashmiris," he says.

Nabi echoes similar sentiments. "Infrastructure has improved leaps and bounds. In my time, there were hardly any facilities. We had to run ourselves to the ground for every little thing, from spikes to bats. What has never changed, though, is the passion Jammu & Kashmir has for cricket. The sport runs in our blood."

Against Pant's team, Paras Dogra's men will take the field as defending champions.

"We had a function after the 2024/25 season, where we reached the quarter-final," Qaiser says. "There, I said, next time we have this event, we will be the champions. Not many people believed me then, but look at us now. Jammu & Kashmir have arrived."

That, they have. And, they might be here to stay.

{ ASIAN GAMES }

Inspired by father, guided by father-in-law: Kynan's road to Asian Games trap gold

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 30

KYNAN CHENAI's father Darius was a close friend of 1978 Asian Games trap gold medalist Randhir Singh, and one of their favourite subjects of conversation used to be guns. Darius is a former national trap champion himself, and the bond of friendship solidified further recently when Kynan, who began shotgun shooting in 2003, married Randhir Singh's daughter Ria Rajeshwari Kumari, who also professionally plays the sport.

Randhir passed away earlier this year and Darius feels he would have been delighted when Kynan and women's individual winner Neeru Dhanda combined to clinch the trap mixed team gold medal at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games on Wednesday. "I knew Randhir Singh ji through our common friends in shooting for the last two decades or more. The only advice he would give Kynan was to keep it simple and go back to the basics when things went wrong. That's what Kynan



Kynan Chenai and Neeru Dhanda after winning gold. AP

did today," Darius told *The Indian Express*.

Neeru was competing in her maiden Asian Games, while Kynan had tasted success at Hangzhou in 2023 when he won the team gold and individual bronze. Kynan had started after watching his father in Hyderabad, and had even competed against him at the 2007 Nationals in Jaipur.

"I started shooting competitively in my 30s on the insistence of my friends Manavjit

Singh Sandhu and Mansher Singh. While Kynan studied at a boarding school, he would accompany me to the shooting range during our vacations abroad. And when he showed an interest in shooting, I got him to train under Mansher," shares the father.

On Wednesday, the Indian pair shot a total of 136 to qualify fourth for the four-team final. They were placed fourth with six points after the first 10 shots, but eventually set an Asian

Games record of 34.

Out of his 20 shots, Kynan missed only his first. Neeru missed three of her first five shots before she recovered to shoot two perfect series. She would miss two shots in the last series but they had already done enough to win the gold.

"Kynan was a bit disappointed after he missed the individual final. And with Neeru struggling initially, he made sure that the team made a comeback. Neeru showed with her recovery why she is one of the best shooters. Training under 2008 Olympic champion David Kostelecky of the Czech Republic has made him a better shooter. India's foreign coach Peter Wilson too has been working on Kynan's technique," says Darius.

With the trap mixed team event part of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, the gold assumes added significance.

"Getting the Olympic quota is the next target but such performances do help," says Mansher, now India's High-Performance Manager (Shotgun).

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 30

ONCE, SJOERD Marijne called Salima Tete a Ferrari.

The India captain had the acceleration to turn a loose ball into a counterattack, the speed to leave defenders chasing shadows and the engine to keep going long after others had slowed down. But somewhere along the way, the Ferrari became a fleet.

"Now, there are 10 Ferraris on the field," Salima had said before the tournament, crediting her teammates for the speed and fitness that have become defining features of this Indian team.

On Wednesday night, South Korea got a glimpse of what she meant. India did not just beat South Korea 2-0 to reach the Asian Games final. They spent 60 minutes squeezing the life out of the semi-final. India dominated possession, repeatedly entered the circle, won penalty corners and, when the goals finally came, refused to take their foot off the accelerator.

For half an hour, though, it was a test of patience. South Korea had managed to do what few had at these Games: keep India scoreless. The Indian at-

tack, which had been feasting on opposition defences through the pool stage, kept coming up against bodies, sticks and a goalkeeper in its way. Nine penalty corners came in the first half without producing a goal.

Marijne's team, however, did not panic, or get restless. Eventually, the pressure told, as Ishika and Salima scored a goal each in the third and fourth quarters, respectively, to hand India a 2-0 win. By the end, India had 61 per cent possession and had won 12 penalty corners to Korea's three. They had also kept Korea from turning their rare moments of possession into sustained pressure. It was the kind of territorial control that has been the defining feature of India's campaign in Kakamigahara.

They entered the semi-final having scored 66 goals in five pool matches, the most by any team in the tournament, while conceding just three. Deepika had 21 goals, Navneet Kaur 10 and Rutuja Pisal seven. The goals had come through different routes, too: 34 from field play and 30 from penalty corners.

But those goals came against opponents who aren't exactly hockey nations. Uzbekistan, Indonesia, Thailand. In a way, the



Deepika Kumari (C). HOCKEY INDIA

semi-final was a step-up after the lightweight battles in the early rounds, and even though South Korea did not prove to be an attacking threat, their watertight defence tested India's patience.

The breakthrough, when it came in the 44th minute, was almost cheeky. Ishika was the injector at a penalty corner, but instead of the expected Deepika drag-flick, Deepika received the ball at the edge of the D and immediately played it back to Ishika. The variation caught Korea off guard. Ishika swiped at the ball and broke the resistance.

After nine unsuccessful penalty corners in the first half, India had found another way in.

And once they did, they did

not wait long for the second. In the 48th minute, Salima did what Ferraris do best: accelerate. She drove into the D and tried to squeeze through from the baseline before cutting the ball across the dangerous space between the penalty spot and the goal line. The ball created panic in front of the Korean goal, sticks and bodies converging as the defence scrambled. It ricocheted off a defender and went in, doubling India's advantage.

The numbers tell the story, but they do not quite capture the relentlessness. With less than five minutes left and India already two goals ahead, Rujuta chased down a misplaced pass to make sure India retained possession. There was no immediate danger, no need to sprint. But the ball was there, so Rujuta went after it.

It was a small moment, almost insignificant against the two goals and the 12 penalty corners. Yet it was perhaps the clearest illustration of what this team has become. A side that had scored 66 times in the pool phase was not satisfied merely with attacking. A side that had conceded three goals was not content merely with defending a lead.

